



UnMe... *it's* Complicated



From the bestselling author of
Until Love Sets Us Apart

DR. ADITYA R. NIGHHOT

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Love is not complicated, people are!

Pyaar, Mohabbat, Ishq, Junoon—Love has its own synonyms. The four-letter word, easy to spell and easier to say, is far more complicated when the brain and heart play their parts in a relationship.

Aditya, a nerd, falls head over heels in love with Rutuja, who happens to be the eye candy of the college. Rutuja loves books and wants Aditya to pen down a story. Will Aditya, a non-reader, manage to write a novel? Just when their relationship goes on a roller-coaster ride for the worse, Aditya decides to attempt suicide.

Can a relationship make you weak?

Can true love make you a rebellious, self-destructive, and violent person? Or will it make way for a better future?

From the bestselling author of *Until Love Sets Us Apart* comes another heart-wrenching tale of not just true love and friendship but also about hope and destiny, and the journey of a non-reader as he becomes a bestselling author.

Also by the author



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Until Love Sets Us Apart

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PASSION

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Published by

FiNGERPRINT! PASS!ON

An imprint of Prakash Books India Pvt. Ltd.

113/A, Darya Ganj, New Delhi-110 002,

Tel: (011) 2324 7062 – 65, Fax: (011) 2324 6975

Email: info@prakashbooks.com/sales@prakashbooks.com

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www.twitter.com/FingerprintP

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ISBN: 978 93 8971 720 4

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*‘Pyaar toh har kisi ko hai,
Bus farak itna hai ki,
koi aazmata hai aur koi nibhata hai’*

Translation:

*Everybody loves somebody,
The only difference is that
a few try it while a few mean it.*

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DISCLAIMER

Although this story is based on a true incident, some characters are fictitious and any resemblance to any character, place or a person—living or dead—is a matter of coincidence. The book is a pure form of art, written for entertainment purposes only, and in no way wishes to defame or pass judgement on any person or incident.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I would like to begin by thanking a few people without whom this book would have been incomplete:

•An author without readers is as incomplete as a story without an ending. I would like to thank each and every reader who has constantly supported me and helped me become a national bestselling author with my first book 'Until Love Sets Us Apart'. Without your love, this successful journey as an author would be incomplete. I hope you continue to shower your love on this book and many other books to come.

•God, for blessing me with the art of writing, and Rutuja for giving me the reason to become an author.

•My parents, for being the strongest pillars of my life, and for being with me in my thick and thin.

•Shikha Sabharwal, Gaurav Sabharwal, and Pooja Dadwal for seeing potential in my story and backing it at the national level.

•Neeraj Chawla and Yola Singh for their continuous support in marketing and promotions.

•Vidya Sury, for being the perfect editor. An author pens down his emotions but it is your efforts as an editor that help connect the emotions with the readers.

•Rajaram Rawool, Dashrath Shetye, Mahesh Kumar, and Mayank Verma for constantly supporting me and being a phone call away.

•Nihar Ranjan Behura, Gururaja Narayana, Nataraja Rayappa, Sanjay Shaw, and each and every person at Fingerprint Publishing and Prakash Books

India.

- Every bookstore, retailer, and supplier for their efforts.
- Each and every person whom, I, unknowingly might have forgotten to mention here. It is completely unintentional.

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PROLOGUE

Love is not complicated, people are!

8 JUNE 2014

What can be something as good as this in a person's life? Rather, what can be worse than this? It's 2 o'clock in the morning. I can see the moon shining in the dark and watching me. God. Who is He? People believe in God, worship Him, but there's no God in my life. I left Him long ago; rather He left me when I needed Him most. This is the statement of every person who has been in love and then been left alone. I don't know whether I should blame Him or not. I don't know whether what I am just about to do is correct or not; but one thing I can probably blame the Almighty for is bringing her into my life. Whom should I hold responsible for something that happened all of a sudden? God? Me? Or her? People say get a dog and feed him once, and he will be loyal to you all his life but what about the two-legged creature with a thinking mind—the so-called Homo Sapiens Sapiens! Even if you give your life for this person, you can't guarantee his loyalty. Love is weird but it's worth experiencing. Love is like war, easy to begin but hard to end. Ishq, Mohabbat, Junoon, Pyaar . . . love has its own synonyms but there are some people who cannot stick to even one. Romeo and Juliet probably belong only in books, because real life is something else. Long live Romeo and Juliet in books! Stories usually end with lines like, ' . . . and they lived happily ever after'. If the writer of these stories ever goes back to his characters a few years later, I am sure the sequel would end with 'happily never after'.

I was so involved with her that I probably forgot the real me. I am probably the guilty one. God . . . I don't believe in Him. I hate Him, and I also hate myself. I miss her like hell! But who cares! I am standing on the terrace of a

ten-storey building with a bottle of whisky. I've already finished three bottles, and three packs of cigarettes, and my body still wants more . . . can't help it! Just can't get her out of my mind. Why the hell did this happen to me? Why only me? What was my mistake? Probably loving someone selflessly!

Now, after being drunk there is only one thing and one last piece of determination left somewhere deep in my mind and that's just . . . ending my life. I call it 'just' or 'easy' in the sense that nothing can be easier in my life than this. Having already faced lots and lots of difficulties, people say, "come out of your problems" but, how can I? And whom should I come out for? My past has not been great, and neither is my present. Everything is complicated here—my life, my love, my future—bloody everything! My heart cries over and over again . . . please somebody help me, please get me out of this agony but no one seems in the least bit interested to even look my way. Helpless, all I can do now is END MY LIFE.

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ABOUT 2 YEARS AGO . . .



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It was 13 June 2012, the so called ‘D day’ in a tenth-grade-passed student’s life. The results were supposed to be out and everyone, including me, was tense. I often had nightmares of failing in Mathematics. Probably the worst subject I guess, in most people’s life. I never liked the subject. I always had a tough time with it but thanks to the prestigious Indian education system, I couldn’t avoid this subject until after my tenth grade. Even though I had always been an average student, this year I had studied hard and burnt the midnight oil before the exams.

It was 11 o’clock and I sat in front of the stupid computer screen typing my exam roll number. Anxious about the results, I felt as if my rapidly beating heart was trying to jump out of my body screaming, I can’t handle this anymore. The internet network was weak and the page kept loading. With every circle it completed, my heart rate increased, and then . . . what next? In the blink of an eye, I had my mark sheet in front of me.

Master Aditya had passed his tenth-grade board exam with distinction and secured 92 per cent.

What? I asked myself. I couldn’t believe it! I re-entered my roll number to double check what I had just seen. I jumped off my chair and sprang towards my cousin sister, who was hovering near the door, waiting to see my results. I had forbidden her from entering my room as I wanted to check my mark sheet by myself. The moment I shared my result with my uncle, Mr. Ronit Patil and my aunt, Mrs. Alka Patil, the house was filled with cheer. They were overwhelmed by my result. A wave of joy enveloped the house.

My parents were in London and were expected back after a couple of years, once they were done with their professional commitments. I was living with my uncle and aunt in Pune since the past year, completing my education.

My uncle is a Paediatrician and my aunt an MBBS. They never discriminated between me and their only child—my sister Namrata—who was just a year younger than me. She was in the ninth grade.

A couple of hours later, my uncle threw a small party for my friends, and some of his office staff. They were happy with my success. After the party, my uncle asked me, “What next, my son? Where do you want to study now? You will get admission in one of the finest colleges in Pune!”

Namrata replied with frustration, “Oh c’mon Papa! Let him at least enjoy a day out,” and then turning towards me, she said, “How can you be so studious, bhaiya? Don’t you feel like enjoying a little . . . studies are so boring!”

I replied to my uncle, “Any college you feel is good for me. Works for me.”

I didn’t respond to my sister’s question, as I knew it would lead to nothing but an unending quarrel between us. We were antagonists. I liked studies, she hated studying. I hated Justin Bieber, and she was mad about him. I loved Bollywood music and movies, while she was the Hollywood fanatic. I preferred any local brand while she was choosy about Zara, Forever 21, fbb, etc. whenever we went shopping together. She was rather good at Mathematics—the only subject I was weak at.

13 June 2012 had been the luckiest and happiest day of my life. I battled with my sleep as happiness didn’t allow me to doze off. I somehow had to sleep considering that I would wake up to a long day ahead, with the task of visiting colleges for the admission procedures. I kept thinking about how the new college and my new friends would be, and how my future would pan out . . . bright or dark?

Of course, it’s gonna be bright! I assured myself and dozed off to sleep.

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15 DAYS LATER

The sun rose and set, nights came and went, and people continued to congratulate me. My life had taken a turn. Yes, I was heading to my new college. It was my first day there, just fifteen days after the results had been announced.

A little nervous and a little excited, I had mixed feelings. I hurriedly put on clothes, and rushed to college. Stepping out of the car with my uncle and a backpack on my shoulders, I had a broad smile over my face. I was going to one of the finest colleges in Pune, where almost every student dreamed of studying. Neatly shaved, in black pants and blue shirt tucked in, I looked more like an IT person than a student. All the way to my classroom, my eyes scrolled the place to check if I knew anyone. The college was known for everything that dealt with academics as well as extra-curricular activities. The other side of the college, which I was aware of, was that students often skipped lectures and roamed around in the city. The famous FC Road lining the campus of our college made it the perfect place for students to hang out. Streets were filled with couples—all immature relationships bloomed on this road! Probably, only God knew how many had united or broken here. I had no intention of falling in love. I was there to study and become something on my own—something I would be proud of and also make my parents and relatives proud. All my life, I had been a nerd. I couldn't even imagine initiating a conversation with a girl. My school days had passed with me being with the rowdy boys. Girls had been out of our syllabus of life. Moreover, I wasn't into fashion trends or the type, who could attract a girl with humour. Pushing my thoughts aside, I attended the first lecture.

Immediately afterwards, as I was checking the notice board, I spotted a girl. To my surprise, it was one of my school friends.

The moment she saw me, she walked to me and exclaimed “Hey! How come you are here . . . huh?”

“Got admission in this college—how are you?” I asked her, smiling.

“I am good, a little stressed out, and coming directly from a long vacation. What about you? You seem to have gained a little weight,” she laughed.

“Hmm yes, I have been eating lots and lots of sweets, and haven’t exercised lately,” I was as polite as possible. The situation was a difficult one for me, what with my lack of practice talking to girls.

She looked into my eyes and hesitantly looked down. She asked in a low tone, “Hey, my friends and I are going out for a movie, would you like to join us in the evening? It will be great fun!”

I seriously didn’t want to go out with her. I had my reasons. I kept thinking of an excuse, and after a long pause finally got an answer.

“I am not sure if I can make it. It’s my sister’s birthday today,” I lied. I was a bad liar. She probably understood. My body language must have conveyed it to her.

“I’ll try and if possible, I’ll let you know. You carry on, please,” I smiled to cover up.

“Fine . . . if you do change your mind let me know.”

“Yes, sure,” I replied, glancing at my watch.

She looked again at me and turned away, saying she had to leave.

This was a difficult moment though. I didn’t want to spend time with her, and my reason was quite silly. Schools are always about childish crushes and teasing. Your classmates pair you up with someone, and then tease you incessantly, day and night. My schoolmates had been no different, and I was

not over it yet. I had taken it seriously, and had caged myself within the false belief of the one-way crush I had on her. Teasing us with each other's names had led to feelings for her but then it was the hesitant me who had kept her away. The immature Aditya, back in 2012, had taken the pairing up to heart when she was already over it. She looked upon me as just another friend and here I was, still stuck to the old days. She had invited me to various places on and off, and I had kept making excuses. Looks wise, she was beautiful and tall with a height of 5 feet 8 inches. I was also the same height. Her rather ordinary name—Shaila—wasn't a modern girl's name, but was still charming. She had always been the talk of our school. Every boy had a secret crush on her. The main reason for not dating her was because I did not want to get distracted from studies—my primary goal. Back then, I believed that girls were the main cause of distraction. The simplest way to describe them is comparing them with cigarettes—highly addictive once you get entangled in them and then, so hard to come out of it.

Shaila was good at heart and was the only girl that I had come across, who was blessed with both beauty and brains. I too secretly had an immature crush on her but as far as she was concerned, I was like any other friend. I didn't want to mess up this ongoing relationship we shared and spoil our friendship.

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As the days passed in the new college, I started liking the campus and the curriculum. Most of the students had already formed their own groups. Amongst these was the English-speaking group of boys and girls, who bunked classes every day to roam around in the city; then came the other category, the talkative girls of the college who didn't let guys into their group. There was yet another kind of group—the rowdy boys of the college, shabbily dressed, riding bikes and stalking girls 24 x 7. I was yet to find my kind of group. As I had always been somewhat conservative, finding the right kind of friend circle was not easy for me.

The first friend I made was Nikhil, followed by Varun. I met Nikhil during the lectures. We sat next to each other and then engaged in a conversation. Then came Varun—he was being scolded by the Physics teacher. Instead of doing the experiment, he had been busy chatting with someone over WhatsApp. It was then that he had sought my help over the Physics experiment, as he was weak in studies. Our friendship grew with each passing day and the three of us became the so-called 'three musketeers of our college'. I liked Nikhil more than Varun. Not that I hated Varun . . . I just found his habits annoying.

Nikhil was an average student, good at heart, and a happy-go-lucky person. He had lost count of how many times he had fallen into a relationship and how many times he had broken up. We quarrelled over this issue every other day. I kept telling him, 'Respect girls, Nikhil, don't play with them'. He believed love was a game of girls. I often argued with him saying, 'Can't you stick to one girl?' Well he was a good person at heart: he was a true friend and would be the first to help someone in trouble. He was way better-looking than I was and a big flirt. I called him a con man because he could talk any girl into everything and anything he intended. He hated me

for calling him this but he knew I was only teasing him, and took it in the right spirit.

Varun was an average guy in terms of looks and in studies. He was aimless in life and that's what I disliked about him. He lived in the present and didn't care about the future. This is fine to a certain extent, but when it comes to one's career, one must be determined about what to do next. He smoked, drank, and was like a devdas in his life. His father was among the richest people in Pune. As a wealthy businessman, he allowed Varun excess freedom and money, which he happily misused. Initially, I did not notice his good qualities but he surely had some well-hidden ones.

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One day, Nikhil, Varun, and I were sitting in a park, busy going through our Biology textbook. It may sound absurd but we found it peaceful to study in the open air rather than indoors, confined in a library. Nikhil and I were reading the first chapter when Varun said, “Let’s have a round of cigarettes, what do you guys say?”

“Hey c’mon Varun, we have to study. And anyway, what do you get by smoking and polluting your lungs!” I replied. I had always been against smoking and I hate it even today.

“It’s my passion. With every breath, it brings happiness and what’s wrong in it, when you get happiness? Now Nikhil has a passion for girls, your passion is studies, and mine is this cigarette,” he laughed.

He pointed his cigarette towards us, as if he was introducing us to his girlfriend. As he finished it, he crushed it with his boot and lit another. He blew smoke rings, making me cough.

“Hey, just shut up okay! Why do you have to compare our qualities with yours? A girl has benefits the same way as studies but a cigarette takes away everything—your girlfriend, and your career, and it doesn’t even spare your life. It takes away fucking everything!” I said and looked at both of them with pride, as if I had won some great debate and was going to be awarded for it. Looking at Varun with utmost disagreement, I added, “And you better take that cigarette away or I’ll suffer from a respiratory illness now.”

“It has some good qualities too. It’s your point of view, which overshadows it. A cigarette doesn’t give you tension, rather it takes it away. On the other hand, both girls and studies stress you out. A cigarette doesn’t leave you

and go, it never breaks up with you unless you want to, but a girl does! Failing in an exam and breaking up with a girl disheartens you, but a cigarette lights up your spirit to move on. A cigarette also . . .”

“Please stop it! Nikhil, say something. Why are you just listening?” I yelled, feeling quite agitated.

“The two of you can just fuck off. What childish debate is this?” Turning towards me, he went on, “He likes cigarettes and you like studies. End of story! And what’s wrong with that? It’s his life; let him decide what is right or wrong for him. Let him be him!”

Nikhil asked Varun for a cigarette. I was shocked by his response. He smiled at me, and both started blowing smoke rings.

“Unbelievable!” I remarked.

Nikhil and I had started liking Biology and we decided to drop Mathematics. With Biology as our backbone subject, Medicine was our career path. We joined various classes for Physics, Chemistry, and Biology and worked hard. With the recently introduced new pattern, we had to appear for the NEET-UG exam, which comprised of both eleventh and twelfth grade syllabi—which was too exhausting for average students like us. But that did not deter us. The twelfth-grade boards had no importance in our lives as no admissions were based on them. So, that was a relief. In spite of being in the eleventh grade, we had to study for NEET-UG. Weekly tests, both in tuitions and in college, sometimes tortured us. Varun had a different strategy. He just said he would give the twelfth-grade board exams seriously and depending on his result, he would decide what he wished to do next.

Coming back to Shaila, my only friend in the college was a girl, and she had also opted for medicine—another co-incidence. She was focused on her studies and tended to score better than me. Not always though—I did give her some competition.

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It was time for our final exams. The eleventh grade was not an important year, though, and none of these silly marks were going to have a great impact on our career overall. Still, I wanted to retain my tenth-grade scoring trend, and so, I prepared quite hard for the exams. I never attended the college lectures as attendance was not an issue. Neither did Nikhil or Varun.

Our first paper was Physics. I called up Nikhil and Varun before the exam, just to check on their status.

Nikhil said, “Fine, doing well, I just have a little problem in P2, mainly in the chapters like ‘Refraction and Refractive index’ and ‘Optics’. It’s damn tough. What about you?”

“I have read all the chapters in our syllabus at least twice and I think I’ll fare well, but I am still a little scared. I might make mistakes being over-confident.”

When I called Varun, he said, “The whole portion seems new to me and it is beyond my capacity. This exam is going to screw me very badly. Hope God is with me and I at least pass. I want nothing more than that.”

I wished him all the best and hung up.

The final revision had to be done and so I got started with it. ‘Ray Optics’ was a little tough but I could manage it. Rather, ‘Electrostatics’ seemed tougher to me.

The exam was scheduled to start by 10.30 a.m. but I reached the college half an hour early. I checked my roll number and took my allotted seat.

I quickly looked around at the students. Almost all the faces seemed new. I had hardly attended any lectures as I had been busy with tuition classes. My roll number was 1325. There was no one sitting in front of me. There was an empty seat behind me as well. Both were probably absent. Not that this bothered me as I had no intention of cheating. I was quite well prepared and confident about getting top grades.

Papers were distributed and the exam commenced exactly at 10.30 a.m. A few minutes passed and I gained a good momentum, solving the initial two questions. The paper was rather easy.

I looked at Nikhil. He was busy writing as well. When I looked at Varun, I saw him staring at me. I smiled and continued writing my paper.

About fifteen to twenty minutes had passed since the exam started when I heard someone running in the corridor. As I raised my head to look, I heard another sound, the sound of slipping. I craned my neck further to have a better look at what was going on, when I heard a girl's voice say, "May I come in, Ma'am?"

I noticed she had slipped at the door but quickly regained her balance. Her silky hair hid her face. When she requested again, "May I come in Ma'am?" I saw her face. My heart skipped a beat. She wore a black top and blue jeans. Clutching the exam pad tightly pressed against her chest, she was panting.

"Why are you late?" asked the invigilator and she replied, "Sorry, Ma'am, I just met with an accident."

"Are you okay now?"

"Yes," she replied, wiping the sweat off her forehead.

"Okay come in," said the invigilator.

From the moment she arrived, all eyes were on her. I forgot the calculation going on in my mind. I forgot the kinematic formula. I forgot that I was giving an exam. I forgot to be myself. In the silence, I could hear the songs

playing in my mind. I was so engrossed in watching her, staring at her that I hadn't noticed that she was sitting right in front of me and writing her paper.

"Oh shit!" I exclaimed. I looked at my watch to find that thirty minutes had passed since the exam commenced. For the last fifteen minutes I had been dreaming about her. Not actually dreaming but fantasising about her. It brought a quick smile on my face and I got back to writing my paper.

With her sitting in front of me—her roll number was 1324—I couldn't focus on my paper. I wanted to talk to her; I wanted to know her name. I found myself going into dreaming mode again, imagining how I was going to start my conversation with her. I was a nerd and she was so beautiful, which made me really nervous. I made up my mind to approach her after the exam.

I found myself drifting into dreamland again and shook myself awake. What am I doing? Focus Aditya Focus! You are in the middle of an exam, I said to myself. Just as I continued writing my paper, she turned towards me and pointed towards questions 1 and 2 on her question paper. I gave her a weird look and then realised she wanted my help. How could I refuse such a beautiful girl? I hated cheating but I was not going to stop myself from helping her. I passed my answer sheet to her. She smiled and accepted it. I had never liked cheating and had never helped anyone in the past. 'No copying, no helping' was my exam motto. And now this girl had changed it.

Time went by and soon the exam got over, but I didn't dare to talk to her. Without even exchanging words, I had experienced so much that day. I decided I would try and talk to her during the next paper. Her one look had made me go crazy.

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Done with the Physics paper, I headed home and started studying for Biology. I couldn't get the girl out of my mind. There are people you have known for ages and still you don't get those special vibes. But here, I found that deep connection in the first meeting itself. Meeting? No! Just a couple of words exchanged while cheating. I just couldn't focus on preparing for the next exam but I managed to somehow revise my syllabus. Finally, I made up my mind to sleep, but couldn't sleep. Her sweet voice saying May I come in Ma'am? echoed somewhere deep inside my brain setting my heart aflutter. I was experiencing something new in my heart . . . for the first time. I couldn't wait to talk to her. The thought of her smile made me fall for her even more. I kept reliving the soft gesture as we exchanged papers. Why was this happening with me?

Was I in love? Is love at first sight even possible? I asked myself.

No, it can't be! the voice inside me answered. Again, I repeated the question and this time . . . got a positive response. It confused me even more and made me even more restless. Sleep eluded me. I started visualising her—her eyes, her nose, her lips, and her silky hair covering her face. I was reliving that moment again and again. Some kind of waves were flowing inside me. It was that moment in my life when I knew I was just getting carried away with emotions—emotions of love or infatuation, whatever they were called but the feeling in itself was so special and unique that I wanted to capture the moment and experience it over and over.

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The next day, the moment I woke up, I hurriedly took a shower. This morning was different. Today, I had a different reason to hurry to college. It was an alien feeling—a feeling that I had never experienced before in my entire life. The thirst to see her again made me hurriedly dress up, so that I could make it to college early and look at the girl who had entered my heart. While guys my age would have wanted to fix a date with her, I was more of a vintage Bollywood, romantic movie guy, whose heart would be calmed at her mere sight. With every heartbeat, her thoughts invaded me and I spent longer than usual trying on shirts and deciding what to wear, and finally went with a red checked shirt and blue jeans. I wanted to impress her.

I reached college and didn't even bother to look for Nikhil and Varun. I went straight into the exam hall and sat in my place. She wasn't there yet. I waited for her and kept my eyes fixed on the door. Restless, I went out and roamed in the corridor to check if she was there.

Finally, the bell struck and I had to return to my seat. No sooner than I sat she entered the exam hall.

You should have come earlier . . . I wanted to talk to you! I exclaimed in my mind.

She hurriedly sat down and pleaded, "Please help me out today. Please, I haven't studied."

I nodded and wished her best of luck, but she didn't wish me back. She smiled instead and that's when I noticed her dimples for the first time. They were so cute they made me go mad for her.

The exam commenced and I started writing my paper. Actually, I wrote less and helped her more. The invigilator kept warning me during the exam. I wasn't good at copying but I think she was a master at it. Finally, the invigilator asked me to get up and sit at the opposite end of the hall.

In spite of being shifted, I couldn't stop myself from helping her from across the room. This was just too much! With the way she easily grasped the answers, I understood that she was good at lip reading.

What's the scientific name of cockroach? I told her the answer doing some funny mimicry. 'Periplaneta Americana'

It was like we playing Dumb Charades in the exam hall. I somehow managed to complete my own paper.

Finally, we handed over our papers and I headed towards her. I lost my walking stance. I was not at all confident.

How am I walking? I shouted at myself.

I managed to regain my composure and asked her, "How was the paper?"

"Good enough. All thanks to you. You really helped me so much," she said as she grabbed her bag and made her way down the stairs. I walked behind her with a smile on my face. The aroma of her hair made me want to be around her.

"It was my pleasure," I said rather formally, after a pause. She gave me a strange look.

"So?" she smiled as we reached the ground floor.

"Nothing," I ground my teeth. My heartbeat accelerated as our eyes met for the first time.

Why are you so cute? Why are you so beautiful? Why do you drive me crazy?

I wanted to know her name. Just as I was going to ask her, she asked me,
“What’s your name?”

“Aditya,” I said.

“Nighhot, right?”

“Yeah, how do you know?” I was taken aback.

“You topped the merit list of our college with ninety two percent in tenth if I am not wrong,” she said.

“Oh, yes,” I exclaimed, surprised to know that the merit lists put up on the notice board were actually seen by people.

“Well, I am Rutuja,” she said.

“Rutuja . . . umm . . . Rutuja who?”

“Rutuja . . . M*****.”

“Oh! Nice name!” I exclaimed.

Actually, I couldn’t make out her surname. Something from the letter ‘M’ was all I could understand. I didn’t dare ask her again.

She began walking towards the parking area and I tagged along.

“Are you on FB?” I enquired. (Facebook was the only medium to connect back then!)

I shouldn’t have, I thought the next moment. Such a beautiful girl, she must be on Facebook.

“Yeah, of course!” she said, giving me a slightly surprised look.

I bit my lips, thinking what to say next. With no experience of talking to girls, I had to think a lot.

I should have taken some tips from Nikhil. I spent the entire year of my eleventh grade with him and actually wasted it . . . thus ran my thoughts.

We kept walking towards the parking area. One of us would say something and the other would respond with a short sentence. It sounded more like an interview session than a conversation. Hemming and hawing, we kept looking at each other. Then she sat on her black Hero Pleasure scooter and smiling, said, “Nice talking to you. See you soon!”

She wanted to leave. I wanted to talk to her, spend more time with her. Without letting the disappointment of her departure show on my face, I replied, “Yes, see you soon.”

“How are you going?” she asked me.

After a split second of silence, I replied, “Going home with my friend.”

It was a lie. I took an autorickshaw back home every day. About to start my twelfth grade and with the rising incidence of road accidents, I wasn’t allowed to use a two-wheeler. How could I share this with Rutuja on the first day? How could I tell her that I took an auto home? How could I tell her that I was a bad rider and my family had strictly insisted that I use an auto? Not that I was ashamed or insecure about it, but somehow couldn’t honestly say it as it made me uncomfortable.

“Bye,” she said and started her scooter.

I watched her leave. As she faded away, I took an auto home. One more step ahead. I was happy. It wasn’t the best of conversations but I was satisfied that I had managed to get off to a good start. Good? At least average, I guess!

When I reached home, I lay on my bed thinking about her, the way she talked, and the way she walked. The memory of her every move made me smile, probably blush. Then the final verdict of the day came up with just me for an audience.

She is too good, hot, and beautiful. Her eyes are so attractive. I could get lost in them for a lifetime. I couldn't have heard a voice more melodious than hers. She is cute and must be good at heart as well, she is . . . my verdict went on and on in my mind, till I finally slept.

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The exams were over and the holidays had begun. A full year had gone by and very soon, I would be in the twelfth grade. But it wasn't really a vacation for me. I had to attend back-to-back classes to prepare for the NEET-UG exam.

The moment the holidays began, I had started missing Rutuja. Over the six odd days we had met, it had just been 'hi' and 'bye'. I didn't have her contact number to initiate further conversation, which made everything difficult for me. I liked her company and wanted to be with her. I felt helpless. With the college closed for vacation and almost two months to go for the new academic year to begin, it really was a tough time!

I logged in to my Facebook account and started searching for 'Rutuja'. I couldn't find her profile as there were too many Rutujas in the search list. I tried to recall her surname.

It's something from M . . . I reminded myself.

Shit man! I should have heard it properly! I repented not catching her full name.

With no hope left, I started checking out each and every Rutuja in the search result. I clicked on every profile picture and finally I found the one I was searching for.

Rutuja M*****—her name was displayed on my screen.

I immediately sent her a friend request. Later, I started checking out her personal information. Everything seemed just perfect until I saw her birth date.

She was eight months older than me. I felt dejected. The next moment someone inside me said, Chill buddy! What difference does that make to you? She isn't your girlfriend yet!

That cooled me down a little, but just a little. Then I stalked her profile and browsed some of her photos, and found them interesting. She looked super sexy in the pink t-shirt and those luscious pouted lips. I desperately wanted her now. I kept looking at her photos. I knew I was stalking, but the fun of stalking and building up dreams with that special person in itself is a joy on its own!

Is it infatuation? I asked myself.

It was the first time something like this was happening to me. She invaded my dreams. I had started daydreaming. I paid a lot of attention to how I walked, how I looked, and how well I dressed. This too was new for me. Was it love? My heart would just come up with:

***You are the one I love with all my might,
You are the one I keep thinking about every night,
You are the one I dream of when I sleep at night,
You are the one I think of when I hug my pillow tight,
And I am not giving up without putting up a fight.***

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Guys in the twelfth grade can relate to how difficult it is to attend classes in the months of April and May. The scorching sun dries you out and the long lectures screw you up. I had three back-to-back classes, each lasting for three long hours.

Nikhil and I would often go together and Varun would sometimes join us. He didn't have the urge to attend the classes.

I remember, once, after the tuitions, we went to have lunch at the famous Hotel Vaishali. It's known for its South Indian dishes. We ordered their famous Mysore dosa along with sweet lassi. Just as I was surfing through my mobile, Varun interrupted.

"Hey guys, I have something special to share with the two of you," he said.

"What's it, man?" asked Nikhil.

"I want to introduce you both to someone special . . . someone really special in my life. My girlfriend," he winked.

"Wow! Great! Finally, you got one!" The excited Nikhil exclaimed, "But when did this happen?"

"Where is she?" I added, excited.

"She will join us in about fifteen minutes," Varun replied with a huge smile on his face.

"Congrats, dude," I said and thought about when and how I would introduce my Rutuja to them.

Wait a minute! I am now regarding Rutuja as my Rutuja. I laughed at my thought.

My thoughts were very soon interrupted when I saw a girl walking towards us. She hugged Varun, giving him a peck on his cheek.

She was good-looking, tall, fair, and had the perfect figure. I guess she had just had a hair straightening session.

“Meet Shaira, my only love, my heart, and my soulmate,” Varun introduced, putting his arm around her waist. We went through the formal handshakes.

As soon as the dishes were served, we began relishing them. I asked Shaira, “So how did your love story begin?”

“Varun didn’t tell us anything, moron!” Nikhil joined me.

Shaira blushed and looked lovingly into Varun’s eyes.

Later, both started talking about their feelings for each other and told us how they had met.

“What a love story!” I exclaimed.

When we were about to leave, Varun told us that Shaira and he were going somewhere and so Nikhil and I left them alone.

On our way back home, Nikhil asked me, “Do you think they are a perfect couple?”

“Yes of course, they are! Didn’t you see how madly they are in love with each other?” I replied.

“Hmm . . . maybe you are right. So, don’t you think you should have a girlfriend in your life? Just in case you find someone . . .”

“Love is not something we find—it should happen naturally,” I said.

“And right now, I am not in the mental zone to fall for anyone, and I am not seeing anybody,” I continued, lying.

“Fine, my love guru!” Nikhil exclaimed, knowing I wasn’t in any way close to being a ‘love guru’.

“What about Shaila? She isn’t bad, is she?” he added

“I don’t need a girlfriend, Nikhil. She is good, but I don’t think we would gel. She is a good friend and I respect her.”

“Fuck, dude! I am not asking if you want to gel with her or not. I am just asking if she is good. You know her better and to be honest, I am thinking of her for me, not for you,” he replied, winking and laughing.

“Shut up! Don’t mess with her. She is too innocent. Don’t waste her life. You can hook up or mess around with many other girls but not her. She is not the type of girl you think her to be,” I shouted.

“Hey, hey! Calm down! Why are you freaking out? Do you have feelings for her?” Nikhil asked me, still laughing.

“It’s not about feelings, it is the way you think. It’s just that I care for her as a good friend and I don’t want you to mess with her. You never take relationships seriously and you won’t, this time either,” I shouted back.

“Some one’s getting too possessive about her,” Nikhil teased me.

“I don’t give a fuck about what you think. All I can say is you are not going to trouble her. She isn’t meant for you.”

“Chill dude! I am just kidding. You get pissed easily,” he replied. “You know what! You are too short-tempered. A rebel at times! It might just cost you someday.”

“Whatever,” I made a lame face as he looked at me through the mirror.

Soon, he dropped me home. I bid him goodbye and then my mind started playing its usual brain games. I doubted him and made various conjectures

on how the situation would turn out, just in case Nikhil had already made up his mind. I had known him for a long time. Of course, he wouldn't listen to me at the first go. He definitely had something more on his mind. I had to keep Shaila away from him . . . very much away from Nikhil! But why was I thinking about Shaila?

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Already disturbed by Nikhil's intentions, I logged in to my Facebook account and found that Rutuja had accepted my friend request. It had been a couple of days since I had sent her a friend request.

Delighted, I checked if she was online and luckily, she was.

I thought of a topic to initiate the conversation. Nothing came to me, so I just went with:

Me: Hi, how are you?

Rutuja: Hiee, I am good, just came from Dagdusheth, had gone to worship . . . what about you?

(Dagdusheth is a famous Lord Ganesha temple in Pune)

Me:

Rutuja:

Me:

Rutuja:

This 'hmm' that people come up with in chats always irritates me. Does it mean it's the end of the conversation or a

Me:

Rutuja:

Me:

Rutuja:

Me:

And yes! That ‘hmm’ probably meant that she wasn’t really interested in the conversation. I got an answer but I was not going to give up.

As the holidays went on, we chatted, sometime during the day and sometimes at night. It wasn’t too frequent though, as she was rarely online. I often waited for fifteen to twenty long days just to say ‘hi’ to her. Our conversation had started but it was restricted to a mere ‘hello-had lunch? – how are you? – bye’ kind of chat.

Days passed and finally it was 24 June—my birthday. I logged in to Facebook just to see if she had wished me. I saw that she had sent me a message.

‘Happy b’day buddy! It’s your day, live it to the most. You’ve just made it to the next year of life and life is all about dreams and achievements. Pull up your sails and turn your boat towards the adventure of life. Wish you a superb day and a prosperous year ahead.

I don’t have your mobile number, so couldn’t call you up. Pass me on your number, if possible.’

I immediately replied to her:

*“Thanks a lot. Will note down the thought somewhere :p You at least remembered me on my b’day and that’s more than enough for me. Thank you. My mobile no. is 9623*****”*



With mobile numbers exchanged, chatting with each other now became a lot easier. Day by day, our conversations grew. Our friendship grew. New flowers bloomed. I had started liking her more with each passing day.

I was often struck with the questions . . . Does she feel the same about me?

What will she say if I tell her how I feel about her?

What if she rejects me?

Will she break my heart?

Will it affect our friendship?

I was totally confused about what to do next.

The next question, which struck me was Is she single?

Oh shit! I exclaimed. I have never even asked her!

Immediately I texted her, “Hey, do you have a bf?”

Fuck! What a direct question! I just screwed up, I thought.

Rutuja:

Me:

Rutuja:

What do you think? What makes you ask me all of a sudden? :p

Just because it struck me. I think a girl like you can’t be single.

Oh, then I have a boyfriend!

The words 'I have a boyfriend' tore my heart apart and my dreams came crashing down like a house of cards. Then I read what she wrote again, and it occurred to me that she might just be mocking me. The words 'Oh, then' before 'I have a boyfriend' made it sound sarcastic. I cursed myself for choosing WhatsApp as the platform for the question. Feelings couldn't be conveyed.

What should I say now? How do I respond? Should I pretend to be happy or just show my real emotions? What should I type? Fuck WhatsApp!

And before I could think of a way out, I could see 'typing . . .' appear on the screen.

Rutuja: There?

Me: Yes. Congratulations, happy for you

Rutuja: Hahaha!

Me: Who is the lucky one? ;)

Rutuja: Ajinkya, my childhood friend. Chill, relax, gtg, ttyl, bye :p

What does she mean by chill? Does she know that I am hitting on her? Is she playing with me?

Her half-baked responses confused me even more.

Me: Bye, see you



Our conversations went on and on as the days went by, but the confusing situation made everything difficult for me. Soon, our college reopened. We were now in the twelfth grade and it just gave me the opportunity to spend more time with her.

I had at least learnt about her likes and dislikes and we were similar in many ways.

- We both loved music.
- We both were filmy (I, more than her)
- We liked watching movies.

I got to know her more. She liked Aamir Khan and if anyone spoke anything against him, she would definitely peel off their skin. She liked chocolates and cakes, and was a shopaholic. She once told me that she was an only child. Her dad was a police officer and she hated it. He never had time for her. Her mother was a manager at HDFC and she too was always busy. The only ones whom she could look up to were her friends and she had definitely started considering me one of them. Although she had many cousins, she hardly talked about them.

When our college reopened, Rutuja and me were always together. She had never attended any of the college lectures in the eleventh grade as attendance was no issue. That was probably the reason I hadn't come across her earlier but I was happy that I was her only friend in college—at least for

now. She hadn't made many friends yet. I introduced her to Varun. Nikhil was on a long vacation with his parents in Macau and was expected back after a month. He missed the NEET-UG classes and asked me to take notes for him as well.

With Rutuja, college had become a lot of fun. We would roam around in the campus all by ourselves and spent a lot of time with each other. We were in the same batch for practicals and this made it much easier to communicate.

Once, after classes, she said, "Hey, can you please drop me home today? My vehicle is out for servicing."

I suddenly realised I had lied to her about my two-wheeler. And now I was caught in the lie.

"Ugh, yes but I haven't got my two-wheeler today. We can take the auto. I'll drop you on my way home."

"As if you have a two-wheeler!" she laughed.

"Huh?"

"I always knew! I have eyes dude. I see you take an auto every day," she laughed.

Now I was truly embarrassed. "Sorry," I said, looking sheepish.

"No worries, it's cute. Let's go."

So, she keeps an eye on me! I took it positively and smiled.

We walked together to the main gate and were soon out on FC Road.

"Let's eat something first," she insisted as I was about to wave an auto.

"What do you want to eat?"

"Paani poori," she said.

“Bhaiya ek plate pani poori (One plate of paani poori),” I said to the guy. His shabby state and unhygienic conditions were unbearable to me, but I stood there because of Rutuja.

“Why one?” she asked me.

“Bhaiya, do plate banao (Make it two plates),” she said.

“I don’t eat paani poori.”

“Why?”

“I have never had it.”

“Are you fucking serious? Never?” she laughed.

“Yes, you know it’s unhygienic. You never know what type of water they use.”

She looked at me and making a face said, “Are you even a human being?”

I scratched my head in embarrassment.

“Today you eat and make a record for yourself,” she laughed.

“No, please! Just look at his hands,” I remarked.

“Mr. Aditya!” She stretched out her vocal cords, “You won’t die eating pani poori!”

As the guy quickly made the first pani poori and served it, Rutuja handed it to me.

“Please!” I tried to excuse myself.

“Have it!” She was adamant. She grabbed the pani poori from my hand and quickly stuffed it into my mouth.

“How’s it?” she asked.

“Seems good.”

“Bhaiya aur thikka banao (Make it a little spicy)” she said to the guy and thus began our rounds of pani poori. Love definitely makes you do the weirdest things.

Done with the pani poori session, I fetched a water bottle quickly. My mouth was on fire with all the spices and I needed it.

“I am going to suffer from diarrhoea, I bet,” I said.

“At least the episode of diarrhoea will make this pani poori moment eternal. You will remember every time you have a bad stomach,” she laughed.

“Life is all about living these small moments,” she continued, smiling.

I loved her for the child in her. I loved her for her practicality. Taking big steps, she walked along with me.

“Come here,” she said, taking my hand and pulling me to the roadside bookstall.

Her touch set off exciting sensations in me. I was holding her hand for the first time. I was looking at her. She released my hand the moment she realised it.

“Bhaiya, how much is this book for?” she asked the seller, in Marathi.

“Rs.175,” he said.

“I’ll be taking two more books. Give me a reasonable price.”

“It is reasonable ma’am,” he said.

“Any Ravinder Singh novels?” asked Rutuja.

“Here, this is the latest one,” he said.

She went through a few more books and picked up four romance novels.

“Give each for Rs.100,” said Rutuja.

“No ma’am, that’s not possible!”

“Take these copies if you want for hundred or less,” he added and handed her the exact replicas of the books she had selected.

“First copy,” he further added.

“Bhaiya, authors put so much effort writing them. Respect them and stop selling first copies. It’s illegal,” said Rutuja.

The man muttered something and before he could retaliate, Rutuja paid him Rs.600, at Rs.150 per book and took the original ones.

“Why did you even bargain when you were ready to pay one hundred and fifty for each book?” I asked.

“I wasn’t ready but then some things are not to be compromised. We must value effort. We as readers must not encourage them to sell first copies,” she said.

What about the effort I am putting in? The effort of love! Thus ran my thoughts. She reads romance novels; she has to sense my feelings for her.

“Auto,” she called out and waved her hand.

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“Do you read books?” she asked me as we sat in the auto.

“I like books but it’s been a while since I have read any,” I admitted.

“When did you last read a book?” she asked.

“Probably in the eighth grade.”

“Man, you’re pathetic. There is always more to life than textbooks. Stop being so studious.”

“I am not studious,” I replied.

“It shows,” she mocked, “Mr. Specs boy!”

“So, you mean guys wearing spectacles are studious?” I laughed.

“I don’t know about others but I know that the person sitting beside me is one.”

I chose to remain silent and she immediately changed the topic to Ravinder Singh.

“He is my favourite author,” she said. “Read his novels.”

“Romance novels?”

“Yes, I just love his books.”

“And why only his books?”

“What kind of question is that?” she looked at me. “Probably because you don’t write,” she laughed and winked. “Write a book and I’ll be a fan for a lifetime!”

“Why would I write? I hardly follow any author and I am not an art or literature student either,” I said.

“You never know, just in case you find a story someday.”

There was a split second of silence. She looked at me.

“Ms. Rutuja, chuck my story. Tell me yours. I might just write that down.”

“Which story?”

“Ajinkya and yours.”

She looked the other way and then outside.

“What happened?”

“There is no story. I was just mocking you when you asked me about a boyfriend,” she laughed.

And you gave me a heart attack, I wanted to say.

“Sorry,” she said, making a cute face.

“So, it seems I have a chance then,” I said. I don’t know how I gathered the confidence to say it or what made me say it. The words just came out.

“Don’t even try it on me,” she winked.

It embarrassed me and I tried to keep an expressionless face.

“Look at your face,” she laughed and hit me on my shoulder and caressed my face. The touch was just beyond eternity. I kept looking at her until she said to the driver, “Stop, stop here.”

“Where’s your house?” I asked her.

“A few yards away.”

“So, let me drop you there.”

“Ugh no, mom might just be home, I’ll walk from here,” she replied.

She stepped out of the rickshaw. She took a Dairy Milk Silk out of her bag and placed it in my hand.

“What is this for?”

“Just take it.”

“But why?” I asked.

“Just like that.”

She walked away and then turned back and smiled. I wanted to capture this moment for a lifetime. I kept looking at her and then held the Silk firmly in my hand. I was attracted to her. Her smiling face in that moment is imprinted on my mind even today. It was probably the first moment I could claim my attraction as love.

“Chalo bhaiya,” I said, a moment later.

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Each day brought a new ray of love for me. Rutuja and I started hanging out after college hours. The day began and ended with us. Our phone calls increased. Our chats had gone from seconds to minutes to hours. I looked forward to seeing her. It was as if the words ‘cute, idiot, dear’ were coined for me. We talked about more than college work. The difficult task for me was riding her two-wheeler. I wasn’t the best of riders, but with time I learnt how to. With our friendship blossoming, I had to make the next move—the proposal!

It was on a Sunday night when I was writing in my journal, listening to music. Sipping coffee, I was gathering courage as well as ideas to propose to Rutuja. As the days passed, I knew I was taking my own sweet time to convey my feelings to her. I knew if I carried on in this way, I was definitely going to lose her. Thoughts like these constantly circulated in my mind. I don’t know if it was destiny or sheer coincidence—but that minute, my phone pinged. It was a message from her.

Rutuja: ‘You know, I don’t really have the guts to say what I am about to, but I still want to tell you. I don’t know w

It was definitely a shocker for me. I felt as if struck by thunder. I was speechless. Currents were flowing up and down my spine. Moments ago, I had been thinking of when and how to propose to Rutuja and now everything seemed to be going my way. The fear of rejection had always been deep-seated in me. Somewhere in the back of my mind, I believed that I didn't deserve a pretty girl like her. And now that she had proposed to me, all fear of rejection, uncertainty, mixed emotions, and everything I had been going through had vanished in a minute. My heart raced and my palms turned sweaty. I reread her message a couple of times. I was shocked yet happy. Still, I was not convinced.

Am I dreaming?

Is she joking as usual?

Was this yet another way of mocking me?

Does she really mean it?

I pinched myself to find out that it wasn't a dream. The next minute, I jumped on my bed, happy and excited. God had made everything easy for me.

I took a couple of minutes to calm down and control myself. Then I dialled her number. She picked up right away and there was a long silence before I spoke.

I:

Hello . . . is it a joke or . . . was it a mistake?

-Silence-

Rutuja: Aadi, it is the truth. I have been having sleepless nights lately. I keep thinking about you. I don't know why

There was a long silence at my end. She had said 'I love you' and her words kept resonating in my mind. After a couple of seconds, I said, "Rutuja, I don't know if it's coincidence or sheer luck but I feel the same way about you. I think I fell in love with you the first time I saw you—in the examination hall—and these feelings have just become stronger with time."

"You must be kidding, right?" she asked.

"No, my dear, it's just strange that we have had feelings for each other and never expressed them."

My heart was dancing and singing with joy . . . loudly!

I love you when the sun shines bright,

I love you when the moon turns white,

In all the troubles, my heart is light,

If I have you in my sight.

"Aww, I am speechless," she said

"This is a very special moment for me," I replied.

"So is it for me! It's one of those unique relationships where the girl dared to propose to a fatty guy." I heard her laughing. She mocked, "My fatty boyfriend, still love you loads."

I was on cloud nine. Love was in the air. Finally, we could now regard each other as boyfriend and girlfriend. We chatted for hours together and decided to meet the next day. This meet was going to be special. We were about to embark on a brand-new journey!



*‘Fiza me mehakti shaam ho tum,
Pyaar me jhalakta jaam ho tum,
Seene me chupaye firte hain
hum yaadien tumhari,
Isliye meri zindagi ka dusara
naam ho tum . . .’*

Translation:

*You are a sweet evening
in this lovely atmosphere,
You are the first glance of my love,
my dear,
Now that my heart is filled
with your memories,
You have become a part of me with ease.*

It felt like I was in heaven. This morning was different. Nothing was the same anymore. The sun was brighter than ever. There was a cool breeze around and loads of love in the heart. With an urgent need to meet Rutuja, I woke up.

Wake up? When did I sleep?

Even before I brushed my teeth, my morning began with texting her. I sent her a 'good morning' message. The earlier night we had made random choices and decided to meet at Ice Cream Magic on my insistence. She gave in just because I loved having CAD B. We were meeting in the evening, and so I had quite a slow-moving day. Time seemed to crawl. I was eager to meet her and she felt the same about me!

I decided to propose to her more formally that day. It wasn't a big deal though, after the previous night. I spent the day buying her a gift as I wanted it to be special and surprise her. I wanted this timeless moment to be something we could remember for days to come. I don't know if I succeeded in making it special but I definitely made it memorable. It was our first date, now that we were in a relationship.

I had made elaborate arrangements. I tried on a lot of shirts to get the perfect look. Checking myself in the mirror for the umpteenth time, I ended up wearing a pink shirt and blue jeans. She had once mentioned that she liked the pink shirt on me and that was the only reason I wore pink on my first date.

As decided, I reached Ice Cream Magic in time and waited for Rutuja. I didn't have to wait long. I could see her park her two-wheeler right across the road from me. As she crossed the road and walked towards me, I felt star-struck. She looked prettier than ever. She wore a red tank top and blue denim jeans. With black eyeliner and lip gloss, she looked beautiful. Her curves gave my hormones a boost. As she came close to me, she avoided eye contact. She smiled but didn't look at me. Wow! She was shy! It made me fall for her even more. Holding her hand, I escorted her to a corner seat.

“What’s up Rutu? Don’t want to talk?” I said, as she remained silent.

“Rutu? Seriously?” she made a weird face.

“Sounds good,” I laughed.

“Hell, no!”

“So, why are you tight-lipped today?’ I was back to square one.

She blushed and said, “I still can’t believe it, Aadi. I never thought we could ever be together. Like, I . . . never . . .

never . . . in my dreams . . . thought we could fall in love . . .

be in a relationship. It is . . . like . . . a dream come true for me,” she stammered.

“Calm down honey, just look at you!” I laughed and she hit me in embarrassment.

I placed my hand softly on hers and looking into her eyes, said, “I love you dear and will always be with you.”

I pulled her cheeks, just to bring a huge smile on her face.

She hated CAD B, but I liked it. We decided to share one. Sharing something with your love is really special and on your first date—eternal. As the glass of CAD B arrived, I picked up the spoon and fed her.

“Cheers to our new life,” I said. Then she fed me. Love was finding its own way to flower. We had left behind the ‘just friends’ term and entered into something called ‘more than friendship’. After finishing the CAD B, I took out a letter from my pocket and handed it to her. I had spent hours writing it, purely because she was fond of reading.

It said:

‘I need you like the desert needs rain. I need you like the breathless need air. I want you like flowers need sunshine. I need you from the first chapter of my love story to the last. Forget chapter! I want you to be my story. The day I saw you made me fall for you, the day I heard you say, ‘may I come in ma’am?’ I fell in love with your voice. The day our eyes met, I lost myself in yours. God! You have sexy eyes. The day you came into my life as a friend, my heart’s desolate land turned into heaven. Never before had it happened to me. I wanted you as my girlfriend right from that day. From then on, if I was offered a single wish for a lifetime, it would be that our love lasts until you see an apple in an orange tree.’

The letter brought a smile to her face. I could see her eyes turn moist. She looked at me and continued reading.

‘I want to hold your hand, and laugh at our jokes, and walk by your side, and snuggle on the couch, and look into your eyes, and talk about whatever comes to mind and kiss your lips every single day. Gosh! The ‘and’ thing doesn’t end. I want all of you for a lifetime and probably even a lifetime would be too short—oh! how much I want you! I don’t need a burning sun and a cooling moon to show me my way because even the sun and the moon know that I have you in my life. I just want you to hold me whenever I stumble and walk with me. I am no Shakespeare to write about you, and I am no Picasso to paint you, but I have written your name in my heart and painted you in my mind. I am just yours and want to say that I am always with you, and I love you more than myself.

I love you Rutu . . . will you be my Valentine?’

She folded the letter and hugged me tightly. I hugged her back until people started noticing us.

“Love you Aadi! You are and will always be mine. You are really a sweetheart,” she said, tearfully.

“You are a real deewana,” she laughed and asked, “Did you write all this?”

“Straight from my heart,” I replied.

“You are good with words, you can write!”

“Not again!” I laughed, “Let go! I am more interested in the story of our lives than entertaining others with fictional ones.”

“Whatever! You already have me in your life.”

“And my story is about life and my life is you,” I replied.

She looked straight into my eyes and quickly kissed my cheek.

“Dear, people around!”

“Chal fattu!” she said, playfully.

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Making our way out of Ice Cream Magic, we headed to her two-wheeler.

“Let’s go to Venky’s,” she said.

“Now?”

“Yes, now! I am hungry!”

“You are always hungry,” I said and she hit me. Next, she handed me the scooty’s keys. Turning it on, she sat behind me, holding me by my waist.

“You’ve gained weight,” she laughed as her hand touched my potbelly.

Soon, we reached Venky’s. It was her favourite place. She loved the chicken nuggets there. I hated it the most, but we had landed up there only because she loved it. She quickly ordered some chicken nuggets and I ordered a coke for myself.

“Just coke? Are you sure?” she asked.

“Yes, it’s Monday and I don’t eat non-veg today,” I replied.

“Oh c’mon, seriously?”

I smiled. The guy at the counter had his eyes and ears on us. He just kept staring at us while waiting for our order confirmation. The moment I shared my ritual about Monday he gave me a weird look, as if I had hurt his religious sentiments.

“That’s it,” I said to him to make sure he stopped staring at us.

“That would be four hundred rupees,” he said and before I opened my wallet, Rutuja had already placed a five hundred rupee note in front of the guy.

“We are equals,” she smiled at me.

That was something unique about her. She was different. Love is all about sharing; right from your heart to your dreams, you share everything. She treated us as equals.

Moments later, our order was ready. Placing the food tray on the table, she quickly opened the ketchup sachets.

“I am damn hungry,” she declared.

She was just like a kid who is excited to eat chocolates when she has one in her hand. The way her mouth watered and the way she was desperate to open it and put it in her mouth. Dipping the nugget in ketchup and taking a quick bite, she sighed in satisfaction.

“Would you like some?” she offered.

“No, I am fine,” I said, sipping coke and reminding myself that it was Monday.

“Oh, fuck Monday, dude, just taste it! It’s yummy,” she said.

This set me thinking. God and I had always had that weirdest connection, which was worse than our mobile or internet services. Our connection had always had congestions. He was usually busy with someone else and had always overlooked me. That was when things didn’t go my way and my relatives and family pandits had warned me to stop eating non-veg on Mondays, Thursdays, and Saturdays. The red cotton string or the holy dhaga as they call it was there to protect me from all difficulties. They had scared everyone with various theories of Rahu-Ketu,’ and later convinced my family of the protection the dhaga and food ritual would provide. They said the connection would now strengthen because now I had a powerful

router, which could catch signals. But it had been a year and the only good thing that had happened to me was Rutuja.

Was it the dhaga that had helped me? Was it the fasting that had helped me?

“Have it. There is humanity and nothing else in this world. God resides in every person; He is everywhere and in everything, all the time. Don’t divide Him with days and religions. There is nothing like Mondays, Thursdays, and Saturdays,” she said and forced a chicken nugget into my mouth.

Disconnecting the router and hampering my signal with God, I munched on a chicken nugget. It was tasty and I didn’t hold myself back from having more.

“I love nuggets,” she said, happily.

She had the habit of declaring random things at every possible opportunity. Probably every girl does it.

Holding my hand tightly, she fed a nugget with her right hand and cheered, “Here’s to our new start!”

Her palm was soft. I was sensing it for the first time. It was just half the size of mine, which was like a monster’s palm.

“So mera bachha, should I feed you some more nuggets?” she winked.

“Bachha?”

“You are! I am eight months older than you,” she laughed, “I am your senior and I order you to eat more, even if you don’t like them.”

The thought of me being younger than her made me feel awkward. I opened my mouth like a kid and she fed me.

After finishing our meal, we stepped out.

“My stomach is full,” she said, placing her hand on her tummy.

“I have something more for you,” I said.

“What? Really? A surprise?” her eyes gleamed.

I nodded. “Open the boot of your two-wheeler,” I replied, smiling.

Without a word, she hurriedly opened it and found a pink club wear dress. Her eyes gleamed in excitement and joy. Beneath the dress, she found a note.

‘To the girl who made my heart pound and taught me what falling in love really means. You are the reason life is worth living these days. Falling for you will take my life but who cares, with you around me, it feels as though I am already in heaven. If you ever asked me to choose between you and my dreams, I wouldn’t know what to say because being with you is my only dream. You are my life, you are my hope, and you are my everything. Love you forever’

She hugged me and thanked me for the gift.

“You are so sweet Aadi! You know how to make me happy,” she said, smiling and hugged me again. She gave me a quick peck on my lips and then turned silent. She lowered her eyes.

“What happened?” I asked.

“Nothing,” she said.

Her face turned dull and she was still silent.

“Something is wrong,” I said, holding her face, “Tell me.”

She turned serious and said, “Aadi, it is the beginning of our relationship and it is always better to talk about our past before we hear anything from others.” She stopped and my heart skipped a beat. She continued, “The other day you had asked me if I had a boyfriend and I lied to you saying that Ajinkya was only my best friend. I am sorry I lied to you. I thought it might just not be related to us in any way. It’s my past and it remains in the past but I think it is better to begin a new relationship with honesty. Ajinkya

and I had been in a relationship for three or four months, but we couldn't get along. I never considered it as a relationship as it was mere attraction followed by some fake assurances. You know, your mind knows that it's not the right relationship. Your heart tells you that it is just fake, but you still take it forward without commitments. My relationship with Ajinkya was like that—in name only. I am really sorry that I lied to you, but today I wanted to tell you the truth. He is still my friend but the relationship we had never went any further.”

She stopped talking and looked at me, waiting for my response as I listened silently. I was trying to find the best answer while trying to take in what she had just said.

“I really appreciate that you told me everything. Baby, what matters to me is that you love me and you are with me. He was your past and the past is past—everyone has a past, right? That is a closed chapter, so why worry about it?” I replied holding her hands firmly.

“I thought you would go wild!” she said taking a deep breath.

“How can I?” I kissed her forehead.

“Did you have a girlfriend in your past?” she continued asking.

“No, I didn't, I swear, except that I had a crush on Shaila. But it was just a crush from my end and nothing more than that.”

“Shaila? From our college?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“Oh my God! Really?” she laughed.

She smiled and said, “Good, now that we know about each other's pasts, it feels lighter and our trust towards each other grows.”

She paused and looked at me, amused. “I still can't believe you had a crush on Shaila!”

I don't know if she was mocking me or she under-estimated me or doubted me for having fallen for Shaila. I simply smiled.

"I'll help you get her," she winked. Clearly, she was not ready to stop.

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After reaching home that day, I received a message:

‘Today was really special for me. Thank you for everything. Thank you for the wonderful gift, thank you for the lovely letter. Your words are still echoing deep in my heart, and I can’t get them out of my mind. I will always remember this day—when we took our relationship to the next level, the day we let truth control us, and the day we probably opened the door to trust. Thank you for being in my life, you mean a lot to me . . . and yes! I have to thank Shaila as well for never keeping a crush on you and leaving you for me . . . hahahaha! Love you . . . Muaah!’

Shaila was going to play a prominent role now. I had never thought about it. Rutuja’s message had love for me with a hint of humour. Her love and her feelings for me made me deliriously happy. The sense of being loved is more precious and unique than the act of loving someone. No book, no dictionary, no words can ever describe it.

‘Good to know what I mean to you. Thank you very much babe! All the while I was reading your message, I could only think of one song for you. I heard it on the television last night . . .

‘Inn aankhon mein tum,

Jabse ho gaye gum,

Sara jahaan tera chehra . . .

Preet ka ye rang

*Ab tere sang
Aur bhi ho gaya gehra.'*

Translation:

*From the time you have been lost in these eyes,
I can find you everywhere in this world.
The colour of this affection,
With you by my side has turned darker.*

“Aww! How romantic! Do you really mean it?”

“Yes, I do. No jokes when it comes to my feelings for you.”

“Thank you Aadi, you’re really sweet.”

We had become even closer in a short span of time, sooner than we had expected. The day before, we had been just friends and now, we had become soulmates. Our hearts were connected by an invisible string. It felt like God had showered happiness on us. Probably, it was the twelfth-grade child in us, which connected us or it was the immature us, which made it sound as ‘I-am-mature’ and made the relationship, a match made in heaven. We were both on cloud nine. Our relationship was growing fast, bonded by love and not just infatuation. At least it wasn’t for me and I think she felt the same. Our chatting sessions kept us awake at night and yet we were energetic enough the next day to attend lectures and private tuitions. We

were on the phone for hours. Even a minute without her seemed difficult for me.

I wanted to tell Nikhil about Rutuja, but at the same time, I didn't want to let the entire college know about us. Gossip had already begun to circulate in the college. Whoever saw us together was curious about what was going on. We both preferred being silent as we wanted our privacy. Varun was the only one who knew about our relationship. He was happy for us and went on to say that we, along with him and Shaira should hang out together sometime. Nikhil was going to return to India in a week. I couldn't wait to share my news with him. I wanted to keep it a secret until he came back and surprise him—I was eager to see his response.

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About fifteen days passed. Our relationship had picked up pace. I started getting more involved with Rutuja. Her life had become mine. We updated each other about everything—right from brushing our teeth in the morning until we went to bed at night. College was fun and it felt as if it was meant only for the two of us to spend time together. We would talk to each other the whole day, forgetting the rest of the world. We were enjoying each other's company.

It was a Tuesday morning when my mom called me from London. It was a long conversation.

“How are your studies going on?” she asked.

“Going good. Tell me about you,” I replied trying to distract her.

My mom was always concerned about my studies.

“We are good too. We will probably return to India later this year.”

“Finally,” I grinned.

It was almost two years since they had gone abroad to keep professional commitments. Finally, they had decided to wrap everything up and get back to India.

“You have lost weight. Don't you eat properly?” asked my mom.

“I do eat. When did you see me?”

“Saw one of your recent photographs on Facebook.”

This was then followed by a long lecture on what to eat and how to eat, how I should get enough sleep, keep my room tidy and not trouble my uncle and aunt. Being so far away from me didn't stop my mom from being a mom! She cared about me and was concerned about me.

"Talk to dad," she said, once she was done.

My dad continued the lecture about studies. He had been amongst the toppers back in his twelfth grade and beyond. He had ranked second in Maharashtra in his engineering competitive exam and that gave him the impetus to guide me in Physics. More than guidance, it was all about what to study and how to study. He made it a point to stay updated about my scores in the tests and about everything I was doing. He was only concerned about my studies. Food and other daily chores were my mom's domain.

The call ended with mom saying, "Your dad was a topper and everyone has a lot of expectations from you. Don't let us down."

"Yeah mom," I said.

"You have it in your genes," my relatives would always say but I had never been able to explain that I was a different person altogether. Even though I was his son, I couldn't match his talent. Till the twelfth grade it had been a walk in the park for me but now with the competitive exams and ever-increasing competition and syllabus, I had started sensing that somehow, I wouldn't clear the exams. I was doing well in the tuition tests and was amongst the toppers there but when it came to an All India level Examination, I sensed that the ground beneath me had started to shake. My instincts told me that I wouldn't be able to crack the exams. I had to live up to my parents' expectations and then prove to everyone that I had it in me. It was challenging but it stressed me out. I feared failure. I had to find myself first. I had to find out what I was good at.

Was I even good at anything? The thought haunted me.

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After the call, I headed to college. All the way I kept thinking about my family's dignity, which was at stake. All eyes were on me. I had to prove myself. It was the burden I carried as the son of a successful father.

Once I reached college, the first person I was eager to meet was Nikhil. He had returned to India a couple of days ago. I was happy to see him back in town. We had missed each other a lot. Just like the old days, Nikhil, Varun, and I spent time at the so called 'college katta'. Rutuja wasn't around that day as she had something important at home.

After attending the lectures, Nikhil and I walked back to the parking area. I decided to tell Nikhil about Rutuja.

"Nikhil, I wanted to share something with you," I said.

"What makes it so formal?" he laughed.

I looked at him and said, "You will be surprised to know that I have fallen in love."

"What do you mean? Crush on someone?"

"No, I have a girlfriend."

The words struck him like thunder. He was shocked.

"Oye hoye, party time!" he exclaimed. "Dude, I should kill you. You didn't tell me. Huh? You say I am your best friend and you didn't even share it with me. When did this happen?" He was quite excited.

“I was going to tell you, but you were in Macau. I wanted to surprise you in person.”

“Great! I am really happy for you. Finally, you’ve got someone. By the way, who is the girl? What is her name? Don’t tell me it’s Shaila!” he winked.

“No,” I laughed, “Her name is Rutuja,” I said.

“From our college, is it?”

“Yeah,” I smiled.

“Have you lost your mind? You love Rutuja! Really?”

“Yeah what is wrong with that!” my smile narrowed.

“Every damn thing is wrong about her.”

“Niks, I love her and she loves me too. What are you saying?” I asked him, a bit worried now.

“She is not your type Aadi. Just leave her. She isn’t the right girl for you,” he replied.

“What do you mean?”

“First tell me, are you really serious about her or is it just a fling for you?”

“How can you even think I’ll have a causal relationship with someone,” I said, raising my voice.

“Then just leave her.”

“Have you gone fucking crazy, Nikhil? I love her and I am serious about her,” my anger was about to explode.

“She isn’t the right girl. I know her past. She won’t ever keep you happy. She can’t! She isn’t capable of keeping anyone happy,” he retaliated.

“Forget it Nikhil, I never expected this reaction from you. I just don’t get you.” The excitement of surprising Nikhil soon vanished.

I started walking away from him but he stopped me and said, “Aadi, I care for you! I am your friend. Trust me! It will lead to nothing but problems. She just isn’t your type.”

“What do you mean by my type?” I asked.

“You are a ‘one girl’ type guy. You are a serious person. And she—she is totally my type. I know her better; girls like her are good for guys like me who aren’t serious in life.”

“Nikhil, are you drunk or something? You are not in your senses. Just let it go! Can’t you understand? I love her and she loves me too. I know her better than you do. I have been with her, I’ve chatted with her, and I have spent time with her. She is committed to me and I am committed to her. I won’t leave her and she won’t leave me,” I said, angry and frustrated.

“It’s temporary! I know girls better than you and forget girls, I definitely know Rutuja. You cannot sense it. You are innocent Aadi and my advice to you is that you stay away from her.”

“Are you interested in her Nikhil? Or is it the revenge you want to take for the day I stopped you from getting involved with Shaila?” I shouted at him, finding it difficult to understand why he was being like this.

“This is what is going to cost you. Your innocence will kill you one day. Grow up! She is a bitch, Aditya! She will use you and dump you one day. I am telling you just kick her out of your life. I have heard about her since school days. Forget hearing, I have personally experienced a lot. I know a lot about her. She is just characterless. Almost everyone in our college knows about her,” he shouted back at me.

The word ‘characterless’, echoed in my brain for a second. Rage filled me. His harsh words hurt. In fact, he had hurt both me and Rutuja. Losing control, I slapped Nikhil and held him by his collar.

“What the fuck did you say? I didn’t expect this from you, Nikhil! How dare you call her characterless? I know my Rutuja better and I don’t need assholes like you to comment upon her or my relationship with her. Just look at yourself, what are you? Who are you? Bloody characterless guy who himself doesn’t remember how many girls he has played with. You are fucking jealous and nothing more!” I shouted at Nikhil, holding him firmly by his collar.

“Enough Aditya! You don’t know what a real friend is. I tried being one for you. I guarantee you that one day you will regret this,” Nikhil shouted back.

“That day won’t come” I yelled and pushed him away.

At that moment, Varun came running towards us.

He shouted, “Guys, stop it. What’s wrong with you?” He was shocked to see us fighting and screaming at the top of our voices.

“How dare he call Rutuja characterless?” I shouted.

“Because she is,” Nikhil said, before I could complete my sentence.

That made me angrier and I pounced upon Nikhil and held him by his collar once again. I pushed him on the ground, punching him hard on his face. He retaliated and punched me back.

Varun tried stopping us and shouted, “You guys are just pathetic! Stop it Nikhil! Aditya!”

Nikhil let go of my collar and so did I.

“I am trying to be good to him, but he doesn’t care! Do whatever you want. Just go to hell with your Rutuja and don’t ever show me your face. He bloody fights for a girl who came into his life yesterday. Just fuck off,” shouted Nikhil, adjusting his clothes and dusting them.

“I don’t need a friend like you and don’t even expect that I will ever come back to you,” I shouted back, turning away from both of them.

I could see Varun trying to calm Nikhil. I was so angry that I didn't even turn back. I just strode away. Anger filled me. I was frustrated over what had happened. I sensed pain for the first time in my life. Rutuja meant everything to me. I quickly took an auto and went home.

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Reaching home, I lay on my bed, thinking of what had just happened. Questions began to flood my mind. Anger built up but the series of questions continued to invade my brain and disturb me.

Was Nikhil really speaking the truth? Is Rutuja really not worth all the efforts?

Is she really serious about me?

I took a deep breath, trying my best to keep the thoughts away but failed.

Does Rutuja really love me? Am I the only guy in her life after Ajinkya?

This was immediately followed by a raging argument inside my head.

Rutuja definitely loves you or else she wouldn't have proposed to you. Just fuck Nikhil. He is jealous. It's his way of taking reprisals for having stopped him from proposing to Shaila, said the positive Aditya.

The negative side then continued; Nikhil is your best friend. He wouldn't make things up out of jealousy, he must be right about Rutuja. Don't trust her so easily.

Positive Me: If Rutuja didn't love you, she wouldn't have proposed to you. Have you ever seen a girl as frank as he

Negative Me: And what if she is betraying you Aditya? What if whatever Nikhil said is true? Trust Nikhil, he is you

As these thoughts fought a war in my mind, I couldn't concentrate on my studies. I couldn't sleep without knowing the truth. On one hand, I had my love and on the other, I had my friendship. Whom to believe? Had I overreacted and spoilt my friendship? Or did Nikhil really deserve it for abusing Rutuja? He was certainly harsh! I wished whatever Nikhil had said turned out to be wrong. I knew Rutuja wouldn't hurt me. I believed her but it was one of those thoughts that I couldn't just let go of.

My heart said, Rutuja can't be wrong. Her love can't be wrong. Your choice can't be wrong!

But my brain said, Think wisely Aditya! You should be careful. Try and think for some time and listen to me. Shut the doors of your heart and ignore what it says.

I was drowning in confusion. Someone was trying to pluck our budding love, even before it could bloom into a flower. I decided to go with my heart. My heart had conquered my brain. Deep down somewhere, I had the feeling that our relationship was true. Rutuja was the perfect girl and even questioning her was like me questioning her love.

No sooner had I made up my mind than I got a call from Varun.

"Hey dude! Are you alright? Listen, whatever Nikhil said might go either ways. I don't know the reality behind it but all I can say is that he was harsh. The only advice I'll give you is—just because someone said something, don't let it affect your relationship or spoil it. It's you who have to decide what is correct and what is wrong for you. You are the best judge of your life. Do what you think is right—let things happen naturally. That definitely doesn't mean that you get involved with her. Get to know her first and then decide."

I listened to him carefully. All I could say was 'yes' after his every statement. Varun managed to boost my spirits. I felt better; rather he made me feel better. But somewhere in this mess, I had probably lost my best friend.



My day began with a ‘good morning’ text and ended with ‘good night’. It is pretty common to say ‘good morning’ or ‘good night’ to anyone, but it is a special feeling when you wake up and sleep, talking to the person you love. Life was incomplete without her.

We chatted throughout the day. I couldn’t bear to be without Rutuja even for an hour. The relationship we shared was growing stronger. At college, we sat together. I made it a point not to hide our relationship from anyone. I hated people gossiping and commenting behind our back—not that I cared what people thought. The only person who meant everything to me was Rutuja. I had always heard people say that one gets blinded in love and now I was experiencing it myself.

I started ignoring Nikhil and he did the same. We avoided a face off and whenever we were around each other, we pretended that the other didn’t exist.

Every day after college and before my tuitions, I had a couple of hours and spent them with Rutuja. We loved each other’s company and often ended up in McDonald’s, Domino’s or CCD after the college.

Once we were sitting in CCD and I was having my third round of coffee. I hadn’t slept the previous night as I had burnt the midnight oil for the upcoming Physics test. I needed caffeine to keep me active.

“Coffee is not good for health. I don’t want my boyfriend intoxicating himself with stuff like this,” she chided me.

“What do you mean by stuff like this?” I asked with a question mark on my face.

“I hate drinkers and smokers. Even coffee in excess is a kind of poison. So, you aren’t going to have any of these.”

I put my arm over her shoulder and pecked her on the cheek. That’s the best way you can shut your girl’s mouth, I believed.

“I love you for this,” I said and caressed her face. “I promise, I will never ever touch booze or cigarettes in my life,” I said.

She kissed my cheeks and said, “Thank you. I love the way you are. I never want you to change. I want you always by my side, the way you are. Don’t ever leave me.”

“Why would I leave you?”

“Just saying,” she smiled.

“What makes you say so?” I caressed her hair.

“It is a girl thing,” she grinned, “Don’t question it.”

“What makes you romantic in CCD?”

“Your presence,” she winked, “If people weren’t around, I would have eaten you up.”

“Mmm! The naughty side of you,” I winked and gently elbowed her.

She held my hand and said, “Promise me a few things.”

“What?”

She then made a list of promises and I had to repeat after her. It was one of those childish things and I loved it. I repeated after her:

1. We won’t stop loving each other.

2.We won't betray each other.

3.We will always be together.

4.We won't let our love life affect our studies.

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After CCD, we went to the nearest park. We wanted to be together. We sat on a bench. I lay my head on her lap and gazed at her. I wanted to lose myself in her. She was wearing eyeliner and her eyes looked ravishing. Her even teeth and her bubbly cheeks attracted me. She played with my hair as I kept looking into her eyes. I could see the innocence in her. Nowhere in those eyes could I see betrayal. I only saw the love.

“Stop looking at me like that. It sends shivers down my spine,” she said, stroking my hair gently with her hand.

“I want to keep looking at you! The longer I look at you, the more I love you,” I said kissing her hand.

She blushed and her cheeks went pink, which made her look even prettier. Her fair skin was white as milk and with those pink cheeks and dimples, she looked prettier than ever. I pulled her cheeks and said that I loved them.

We then tuned in to some music and shared the headphones. With one earphone in her ear and other in mine, and with me on her lap, looking into her eyes made it the perfect romantic moment for passersby. Some commented, some ignored us while some smiled, but we were oblivious to all this. We were in our own heaven of love.

She switched to a song and said that it was dedicated to me:

‘Tum hi ho

Ab tum hi ho

Zindagi ab tum hi ho . . .

Chain bhi, mera dard bhi,

Meri aashiqui ab tum hi ho.'

My eyes went moist. She wiped them off gently. I kissed her on her cheeks. As she bent down, her silky hair fell on me. I enjoyed every moment of it.

"I love your hair, Ru. It is soft and silky and the fragrance makes me mad," I said moving them aside.

"You make me mad," she winked with her naughty side.

"You have it in you," I winked back.

She blushed and said "And you know why I like your hair?" She paused before saying, "Because it is so rough." She teased me, stroking my hair and laughing.

I bit her finger and she yelped. She slapped me lovingly.

"Let me at least complete my sentence. I like your hair because it is rough and curly and it makes you look perfect," she teased me, "A perfect pigeon's nest on your head."

"Get lost," I said, making a face.

"You won't be able to live without me if I get lost," she continued teasing me.

"You know my weakness," I sniffed.

"Forget it, I just love this song," she changed the topic as the Tum hi ho song from Aashqui 2 was still running.

"Me too! You can find the entire album on my phone."

“I already checked your phone and I know everything that is inside it,” she laughed.

“By the way,” she continued, “Don’t ever end your life as shown in the movie. I want you with me, whatever happens in our future, however we may be, in all our good and bad times. We have to be together. One shouldn’t end one’s life. Suicide is not the solution for any problem.” Her face turned serious.

“What makes you say so?”

“Never question a girl when she is serious and in love,” she replied.

“So, ma’am, when does a guy question a girl?” I laughed.

“Never,” she grinned.

“So, promise me that you won’t commit suicide,” she added, “Anyway, only I have the authority to kill you.”

“Are you serious? Why would I commit suicide?” I laughed.

“Just say it!”

“Okay, I promise that I will never think of suicide,” I said, holding her hand firmly and almost making her shout in agony.

She shook my hand with all the power she had in her and escaped from further pain.

She shouted at me, “Just look at your hand. It’s twice the size of mine. One day for sure you will break some bone inside me.”

I bit my lip and said sorry.

She looked into my eyes again and said, “It’s okay. I can manage with some pain because it reminds me that my boyfriend is a tough guy.”

I smiled and asked her, “So what happened about the promise? You shouldn’t be quitting your life either.”

“Baby, I promise you, I won’t leave you and go, so suicide is out of the question,” she said with a smiling face.

“And you know, if I ever had to die and I had a choice between my last breath and you, I would use my last breath to say your name,” I said kissing her hand.

“Aww! So sweet but too filmy,” she started teasing me again and laughed and I joined her. We were having a good time together. It is quite strange how time passes like an express train when you are with your beloved and crawls when you are apart.

She held my hand and said, “You know why I love you? It’s your sweetness and your innocence which drives me crazy.”

I kept gazing at her as she talked. She blew out air as she talked. As she spoke, her pleasant, scrumptious, succulent, luscious lips tempted me. She probably sensed it. We remained silent for a while and then she leaned forward. Her hair fell over my face again. She bent down with my head still on her lap. The birds chirped, the wind whispered and in split seconds our breath united. Her lips rested on mine as we kissed each other passionately. The ecstasy and nervousness of that first kiss! We let the nervousness fade away and embraced the ecstasy. The moment was filled with the sound of our kiss and the gentle breeze. Every time the wind blew her hair, I thanked it for letting the silky strands caress me. Suddenly the buzz of the phone interrupted our sweet kiss. It was Rutuja’s mom. She answered the phone and I could hear her mom’s voice at the other end. She was probably in a bad mood and was shouting at her. I could hear almost everything.

“Where are you? Have you noticed what time it is? When are you going to come home? It’s very late! I want you home in five minutes.”

Rutuja on the other hand tried to explain very politely in Marathi, “Aga yete Aai, Mi Anuja sobat ahe . . . alech! (I am coming mom, I am with Anuja, will be there shortly).”

Now, who the hell was Anuja? I was completely unaware. All I could make out was that Rutuja was very good at lying. She almost convinced her mom. In fact, even I felt convinced. The sincerity in her voice made me fall for her even more.

After the call ended, Rutuja hurriedly got up saying, “I have to leave, Aadi. Mom is in a bad mood, bye!”

Before I could react, she was back on her phone. This time it was not her mom. It was someone else.

I could hear Rutuja say, “I have told mom that I am with you—say the same if my mom calls you up. Now please! Don’t start asking me questions. I’ll tell you everything later . . . look . . .” she kept speaking until she was out of the gate and her voice faded away. All I could figure out was that it was Anuja at the other end.

The day ended all too quickly but it had been a memorable one.

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The next morning, I was up at seven. Usually, I got up at five or six a.m. to study but I had overslept because of the late night chat. As usual, my day began with sending a ‘good morning’ message to Rutuja. I searched for some romantic messages over the internet but couldn’t find any that appealed. Finally, I began framing one.

‘I wrote your name in the sky, but the wind blew it away. I wrote your name in the sand, but the waves washed it away. I wrote your name in my heart and forever it will stay.

GM and have a nice day Love you . . . Muahh!’

‘Gosh! I can write,’ I said to myself as I re-read my message.

She would read the message at 10.30 a.m. as usual, when she woke up. College practicals were at noon and she would not bother waking up early. I preferred to utilise this time to study and make the most of it, so that later when she woke up, I could spend time with her.

I was getting ready for college, and was trying out different hairstyles.

‘Fuck my hair! No hairstyle!’ I said to myself, when my sister Namrata entered my room and said, “Bhaiya, I’ve been observing you of late and you’ve changed. I know someone special has entered into your life,” she winked at me.

I gave her a look and said, “Nothing of the sort. Can’t I want to look good for no reason?”

“I know, I know, there’s nothing special in your life and that’s the reason why you look into that mirror only once in the entire day!” she said

sarcastically.

“There is something called fashion.”

“Oh yeah and boys become fashion-conscious only when they want to impress someone or have already impressed someone,” she laughed.

“Whatever, bye!” I said, avoiding her.

Embarrassed by her words, I quickly went to the main door, put on a pair of shoes and waving to her, set off to college.

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It had become routine for Rutuja and me to stay back in the college after our practicals. Listening to some songs, sitting on the ‘college katta’ or sharing a bottle of Pepsi in the canteen, all we wanted was to be with each other. By this time, almost the entire college knew about our relationship. There were occasions when Rutuja and Shaila would confront each other in my presence. Rutuja knew that I used to like Shaila during my school days (just a crush) and she was fine with it. The only thing that she was insecure about was me talking to Shaila. She had warned me against talking to her and I had started avoiding her.

Once, Rutuja asked me about Nikhil.

“Why aren’t you talking to him?”

“We had a fight,” I told her.

“Reason?”

“Leave it, let’s go to Vaishali,” I said, changing the topic.

We ordered dosa and uttappam. I remembered the day when Nikhil, Varun, and I had come here and Varun had introduced us to Shaira. It seemed like a long time ago. At that point, I had been stressing over how I would propose to Rutuja and convince her and whether she would ever accept me. And here we were today. Destiny had brought us together. The only thing different was my broken friendship with Nikhil. I had probably overreacted but I didn’t have the urge to go back to him and start afresh. I wasn’t the one at fault. It was him, who ought to be sorry for what he had said. Ego won but I preferred to see it as self-respect.

“Where are you lost?” Rutuja asked me.

“Nowhere, just enjoying this dosa,” I said, coming back to the present.

“This sambar is too good. You know, the taste never changes. It is just the same since ages. Hats off to the chef,” she said proudly, with her eyes gleaming, relishing the food.

She wasn’t fussy when it came to eating. Although she seemed to eat less, she always enjoyed her food.

“Aadi, let’s go for a movie,” she said, excited.

“Now?”

“Yeah,” she said.

I checked my mobile but there didn’t seem to be any interesting movies. The only one we were eager to see was Dhoom-3 and it was yet to be released.

“Why oh why! Can’t they release it early! I am dying to watch Aamir,” she said, in a childlike manner.

She then searched for something on her mobile and said, “Why not watch ‘Mangalashtaka . . . once more?’”

“When did we watch it for the first time?” I asked her, puzzled.

“It’s the name of a Marathi movie, dumbo!” she answered.

I knew absolutely nothing about the movie and had an ‘are you serious?’ kind of look.

“I bet it’s a good movie,” she continued.

“Only for you, I can risk it,” I replied, raising an eyebrow. I was choosy when it came to movies.

“Yeah baby and as it is, are you really going to watch the movie?” she winked and I just got the gist of it.

“Alright! Let’s go!” I said.

After paying the bill, we headed towards the theatre. To my surprise, the movie was almost houseful. Holy shit, I said to myself, how did I not know about this film?

There was a long queue at the ticket counter and that made me say, “It’s definitely a hit! We can risk it for sure.”

“See, I told you, now stand here,” she said.

The queue was so long that we didn’t expect to get a ticket but Rutuja requested the guy who was first at the counter politely with a cute smile on her face, “Excuse me please. Can you please book a ticket for me as well? Please, the line is too long and I can’t stand for a long time.”

He looked at her innocent and pleading face. And after all, men are men. The guy was probably the same age as me.

He said with a huge smile on his face, “Yes definitely. How many tickets do you need?”

“Two,” said Rutuja.

She handed him a five hundred rupee note and the guy turned to the counter.

“Four tickets,” he said and turning towards Rutuja he said, “You can join us.” He was accompanied by another guy.

What the fuck? I admire your guts though, Rutuja thought.

“Ugh, really so kind of you but I need a corner seat for two,” she replied, again with a smiling face and added, stretching over the sentence, “I have a boyfriend.”

There was no need to mention it but the moment she did all his hopes came crashing down.

Rutuja took the two tickets from the guy and after thanking him, rushed to me. The guy looked disappointed.

She boasted, “This is the art of a girl. Had you been in the line, we would have definitely seen the movie a week later.”

She then nudged me with her elbow, teasing me.

“After all whose girl are you? Mine, right? You should have these qualities,” I retaliated playfully and kissed her on her cheeks. She gently hit my forehead with her fist as we continued walking in.

“I pity the poor guy,” I laughed.

“He was nice,” she admitted and laughed.

With more or less two hours of runtime, the movie was decent. We shared some popcorn, putting some into each other’s mouth, and totally enjoying the movie. I watched her watching the movie. The movie was about a relationship where a married couple separate and how they get back together again. It was an awesome plot, well written and well directed. It was shot in Pune, which for me, was actually the best part of the movie. After the movie ended I confessed, “I really didn’t know what the movie was about. I never in my dreams thought it was a love story.”

“What? Don’t you know the meaning of Mangalashtaka?” she asked with her eyes wide open.

“No,” I said as if I was declared by the judge, ‘guilty as charged’

“Dumbo . . . Mangalashtaka is a form of mantra sung in a Maharashtrian marriage. Are you really a Maratha? I have my doubts!” She said, frowning.

“Yeah, I am,” I answered.

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“Get up Aadi . . . hello?”

“Yeah, what’s up Ru?” I said, answering in a drowsy voice.

“Do you have any idea that our board exams are just three months away?” she asked firmly.

“So?” I was still half asleep.

“What so! We both have to study. You are losing your focus and I haven’t even started studying.”

“Ru, do you know what time it is? It’s 3.00 a.m.!”

“I know! All I wanted to tell is that you are going to teach me something tomorrow. Any damn subject of your choice. We will study together. Okay?”

“You called me for this! At this hour?” I exclaimed drowsily.

“He he he . . . sorry. Soh ja baccha! Let’s talk tomorrow. Bye, good night, and sweet dreams!”

“Good night and sweet dreams! That’s it? No good night kisses?” I teased her.

“No, you won’t be able to sleep,” she laughed.

“I am anyway awake now. I need those strawberry flavoured lips of yours.”

“My kiss is priceless,” she laughed.

“I think I am priceless to you,” I hit the target.

“Yeah, anyway, good night and sweet dreams,” she said, followed by the sweet sound of her lips.

It always is the best moment when you hear your love’s voice at the other end of the phone unexpectedly. A sleepless night followed. For the next half hour, I was busy thinking about her mesmerising sweet voice. Finally, after tossing and turning on my bed, I drifted off to dreamland.

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It was late when I woke up the next morning. I showered quickly and hurried to college. Life had changed dramatically since the last six months or so. Earlier the term ‘love’ had seemed stupid to me. I would explain to people that there’s no such thing as love in this world, but now I had been proven wrong.

*‘I want to be the wind that fills your sail,
The hand that lifts your veil,
The moon that moves your tides,
The sun coming up in your eyes,
The spark that lights you up.
All that you’ve been dreaming of,
And more . . . so much more
I want to be your everything!’*

As decided, after college Rutuja and I went to one of the classrooms to study.

“What are we doing today?” she asked me.

“Coordinate compounds, Chemistry,” I said.

As I opened the book and began, I sensed it might be little difficult for me to teach and for her to listen. We looked at each other.

“Don’t look at me,” I said and placing my palm on her face turning her face towards the book.

“I am listening, continue,” she replied.

It wasn’t a difficult chapter, but I was too distracted and had a tough time.

“By the way, one of my friends is here. She is in the next room,” she said.

“Ask her to join us,” I told Rutuja although deep down, I didn’t want her to be around.

Anuja was a dusky-complexioned, sweet, good-looking girl of average height and one of Rutuja’s best friends. They had gone to the same school. Since then they had been chuddie buddies. Anuja was studying in Garware College. That’s all I knew about her at that moment.

Why the hell did Rutuja have to bring her along? I wondered.

Love has its own language of communication and Rutuja guessed what was going on in my mind.

She immediately said, “She also wanted to study, so she came along. She won’t be a problem, trust me.”

I nodded my head in agreement as I didn’t want to argue over such a small issue. Anuja came over and Rutuja introduced us. The teacher I had become for the time being had turned out to be a difficult profession altogether as I had to teach my girlfriend as well as her friend now. And God knows why they had to giggle on and off! No reason—just girly things! How were coordinate compounds something to giggle about? I was sure it was something to do with me.

Anuja constantly kept eyeing me and then there were those glances she shared with Rutuja. Anuja did not have studies on her mind. It looked like she wanted to check out her best friend’s boyfriend—a topic for their late night gossip. All I wanted at that moment was some private time with my love. I wanted Anuja to notice this, but she was too stubborn or just doing it deliberately.

After some time, Anuja received a call on her mobile and left the room to talk. It was her boyfriend Animesh. I had heard about him from Rutuja. Anuja and he were fighting over cigarettes. He wanted to smoke and she hated it. Their quarrel went on and on and I finally got my private time. I knew I was being mean, but I didn’t care.

“C’mon! Now concentrate here,” I ordered Rutuja, now that we were alone again.

“Yes sir,” she teased me, holding the pencil I was writing with.

She liked such crazy things. A few minutes later, she held my left hand and started carving my name on it.

“Ru . . . I am trying to explain something to you, please concentrate, dear, it’s important,” I insisted.

“I know, I am listening, you continue, while this hand still remains in mine,” she replied, busy drawing designs on my hand with ink and at the same time letting her sweet little tongue pop out of her mouth in a very childish manner.

I definitely loved it and she looked cuter than ever. I continued saying, “These are the valence bonds . . .”

She would nod her head, each time I looked at her. I doubted she understood anything. Finally, after half an hour, I was done with my teaching and she was done with her engraving work. Anuja was still on the phone, fighting with her stupid boyfriend. I smiled looking at Rutuja and took out a tiffin box from my bag.

“What’s it?” she asked me, almost leaning over me.

“Chocolates for you, homemade ones. I struggled to make them for you,” I replied, smiling.

“Really! So sweet of you!” she said, picking up a couple of them at one go and putting the first one into her mouth. I could see from her expression that she liked it.

She continued, “I never knew you were so good at making chocolates. I swear they are really good!”

Even today as I look back, I still doubt if my effort was really worth it. She fed me one and I fed her back. I wiped off the excess chocolate on her lips with my hand. She smiled and blushed. I had decided to make these chocolates because . . .

A FEW DAYS BACK . . .

My phone rang.

(It was a call from Rutuja, late at night)

Rutuja: Hey Aadi, I am all alone in the house. I want something to eat. I am hungry. Tell me something that I can make.

I: Can you cook?

Rutuja: Not really, what would you make for me, if I was hungry and if you were here?

I: Umm! I would put in a lot of effort. I would first lay the table, light some candles, then decorate the room with flowers.

Rutuja: Fuck you! You will do everything but not cook, is it? (Laughs)

I: All I know is to make coffee and Maggi, that's it.

Rutuja: Yeah, good idea. I'll make Maggi today. That's all you know?

I: Sometimes soups too. But none of which you would like.

Rutuja: Doesn't matter, even if you give me half-cooked Maggi, I would gobble it up without any complaints. What else can you make?

BACK TO THE PRESENT (TEACHING)

The childish conversation we had had a few days ago had inspired me to learn to make chocolates. I certainly impressed Rutuja with it.

After a few minutes, Anuja was back with us. Rutuja offered her the chocolates and she took some. She was still in a bad mood, thanks to her boyfriend. Rutuja tried to talk to her, but she was in no mood to listen. I didn't have anything to say, as I hardly knew Anuja and certainly not her boyfriend.

"I am breaking up with him," declared Anuja to end the conversation.

"You should!" supported Rutuja.

The heated-up discussion soon ended and we decided to go out for lunch. Anuja had some important work and excused herself. So, we parted after exchanging contact numbers. Rutuja too had to go back home early and so we decided to eat at some place on FC Road itself. After looking at different restaurants, we landed up at Venky's again. I hated nuggets, but had no choice and joined Rutuja. It was my time now to eat anything for the sake of my love. I gazed at the way she was enjoying those tiny nuggets. The moment we were done we walked along FC Road. We wanted to spend some more time together, and decided to do some window-shopping. Neither of us had much money in our pockets. We entered the Nike showroom.

"What do you want sir?" asked the employee.

"Not decided, just having a look around," I replied.

We spent time checking out the newer trends of fashion. I was in the girls' section while she checked out t-shirts for me in the men's section. With four t-shirts in her hand, she said, "This is what you should be wearing. Now try these on."

"Why? There's no need, we aren't buying anything," I replied.

"It's okay; still try them on for me. You always wear shirts. Let me see how you look in t-shirts. Go and change!" she ordered, handing me the t-shirts.

It was sheer madness but I tried on the red, black, white and blue t-shirts she had short-listed. She loved almost all.

"This is what you should be wearing," she said again, "You look good in them."

Was it a compliment or did it mean that I looked ugly on other days?

The owner of the shop just kept looking at us. He probably wanted to shout, "You fools! Is this your father's shop? Stop touching these clothes and trying them on when you do not intend to buy!"

I smiled at him and started looking for tops in the girls' section. Rutuja too joined me. She came across a black top with full sleeves. It was more like a sweater, which looked like a t-shirt. It wasn't a sweatshirt though. I don't know what it was called but whatever it was, it definitely was the best product in the shop. Rutuja had just gone crazy over it. I could sense by the way she looked at it that she desperately wanted it. Taking the top in her hand she said, "Isn't this one beautiful? Wish I could buy it!"

"Why don't you just go and try it on, the trial room is that way," I suggested, pointing to the trial room.

"Sure," she quickly rushed to the trial room.

The owner again gave us an angry look as he was confident that we weren't going to buy anything.

Rutuja went in, quickly changed, and came out of the trial room. With her hair loose and a smile on her face, she looked ravishing in the outfit.

“How is it?” she asked.

My mouth was wide open. I was speechless. She looked like a princess. Her curves could definitely feel proud of themselves. She stood in front of me with one hand on her waist and a pout, which blew my head off. Something electric happened inside me and all I could do was stare at her, dumbstruck.

“Stop looking at me like this,” she laughed.

“How do I look?” she asked me with a naughty smile on her face even though she knew I was awestruck by her.

“Hottttt,” I said, without taking my eyes off her.

I had always liked her with her hair loose.

“Don’t you feel the top’s a little short?” I asked her as it exposed her navel, “It’s definitely not a crop top.”

“Doesn’t matter, I just love it,” she said winking at me. “But the price is too much!” she continued.

It was too much for us as we survived on pocket money. Disappointed, we left the shop.

“I could see sexual obsession in your eyes today,” she laughed.

“You turned me on,” I laughed back.

“I wish we could have bought it,” I admitted.

“Mr. Aditya, control your emotions,” she teased me.

Great! You set the fire and then you ask me to come out of it unscathed!

I wished I could see her in that top over and over again. More than that, the top made her happy. I kept thinking: how do I purchase the top for her? Where will I manage to get money from?



The next day, I continued thinking about the top. I somehow wanted to get it for her. My happiness lay in her happiness. I thought of various ways to get the money to buy it but couldn't think of anything. I searched my cupboard and double-checked my wallet, but I was still short of cash. Disappointed, I kept working my brain. Then I saw one of my watches lying in my drawer and found a ray of hope. It was an expensive gold-plated watch gifted to me by my uncle when he had returned from a conference in Dubai. I decided to sell it.

Sorry uncle, I apologised to him in my mind and immediately called Varun.

I: Hey Varun, I need your help.

Varun: Ha bol na, kya hua? (Yes, tell me, what happened?)

I: Listen, umm, I was planning to gift Rutuja something but I don't have the money, and so I want to sell my w

Varun: Dude! Are you crazy? Don't sell anything.

I: I have no choice buddy. I am a bit short of money and I can't ask my uncle and aunt. They are already doing

Varun: Still, man! Don't sell it. You can do one thing; take money from me. No need to return it. This is the least I c

I: Thanks a lot buddy, but I don't want to trouble you. I want to do this myself.

Varun: No trouble at all! Now, what can I say when you have already made up your mind? Meet me today. We will



It was about 11.30 p.m. when I called Rutuja.

“What are you doing?” I asked her.

“Missing you and nothing else.”

“I am always with you. We meet every day,” I said.

“I need you 24 x 7.”

“I’ll invade your dreams tonight,” I laughed.

“I want you now, with me,” she cried.

I laughed.

“Don’t laugh. I seriously need you,” she continued.

I looked at the wall clock. It was almost midnight. Earlier that day, I had successfully managed to sell my watch. The bag with the top was by my side.

Ending the call, I quickly put on a sweatshirt. It was November and winter had just begun. Tiptoeing, I latched my room door. I checked to make sure that my uncle and aunt were asleep.

Thank God, they are asleep!

I checked my sister’s room. Her door was locked from inside and I quickly walked to the main door. I grabbed the bike key and the house key and

latched the door. I went down the stairs to the bike in the parking area. As luck would have it, the bike was not ready to start.

‘Fuck!’ I shouted.

God definitely knows how to play with someone. He loves making situations difficult and considering that my past record with God was not so great, how could He be kind to me now? Anyway, I wasn’t going to surrender so easily. Rutuja’s house was two kilometres away and I decided to cover the distance on foot. Zipping up the sweat shirt and bag in hand, I sprinted over. It was freaking cold outside but who cares when your destination is worth the struggle? I ran down the alley to the main road. The only thing I feared were stray dogs. They go fucking crazy at night! I kept running and soon reached my destination.

Panting heavily, I sat on the footpath outside Rutuja’s house. Wiping off the sweat with the arm of my sweatshirt, I dialled her number.

“Yes?” she said, answering, half asleep and in the drowsiest of voices.

“What if I say that I am standing just outside your house?”

“That’s not funny! I am damn sleepy.”

“Just peep from the window before I shout your name and wake up your parents as well as your neighbours!”

She disconnected the call. She couldn’t believe it. I kept staring at the window on the third floor, expecting her to peep out. A couple of minutes passed and I could see the light go on in her room. Soon, I saw her open the window.

“What are you doing here?” she whispered. She was shocked to see me standing outside her house.

“Tell me how to come up,” I said, rather loudly.

“Shh!” she whispered, “Are you crazy? My parents might just hear your voice.” She looked around, afraid, and then asked, “What are you doing

here?”

“I have come to meet you,” I whispered back, “Tell me, how do I get to your room?”

She couldn’t believe her eyes. “Wait there, I am coming down,” she said, gesturing with her hand.

She quickly closed the window and went to the mirror. She was happy but at the same time she feared her parents. She was still in shock. She looked in the mirror and checked if she was looking good. Tying her hair with a ribbon, she hurried to the ground floor. Her eyes quickly scanned the ground floor. Ensuring no one was around, she opened the main door and then tiptoed to the main gate and opened it. It immediately made a creaking sound, which made her nervous. She slowly opened it.

“Come in,” she whispered, motioning to me.

I went in and she closed the gate after me, making another creaking sound.

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It had taken a lot of courage to climb up the stairs to the third floor without being noticed or making a sound. The moment we were in her bedroom, she latched the door. I took off my shoes.

“I still can’t believe my eyes,” she admitted.

“You wanted me and here I am!” I boasted.

“I was just kidding. I never expected you, though.”

“Okay then! I’ll go,” I turned away.

She held my hand. “Stop being a girl,” she laughed.

“Girl?”

“Yes, girl! Only girls are fussy,” she added.

“So, you admit that you are fussy,” I winked.

“Shut up!” she hit me with her fist.

I looked around. Her room was all done up in pink. Right from the bedspread to the teddy bear staring at me, everything was in pink. Above all, her room was tidy. Towards the right was the bookshelf with romance novels stacked in the most appealing fashion—arranged size wise.

Who arranges books with such perfection, I wondered.

“All romance books. Do you want any?” she asked me, as she found me staring at the bookshelves.

“Ugh, no!” I laughed at the thought of reading a novel. Not that I didn’t like to read but it had been ages since I had read a novel or was interested in reading one.

“This is one of my favourites,” she said pointing towards one of the books.

“Isn’t it the one we bought from Crossword?” I asked.

“Yes, during the book signing event,” she said and her eyes shining with joy.

“You know, the story is about the author’s love life,” she continued.

“Did I ask you?” I made a face, least interested.

“Baby, I desperately wish for a bestseller to be written on me and featuring on the shelves in Crossword and other major bookstores.”

“Write a book on us,” she added after a pause.

“Not again!” I remarked.

“Okay forget it! What’s in the bag?” she asked me.

That’s when I realised I hadn’t yet gifted her the top.

“Guess what?”

“I don’t know,” she said.

“See for yourself,” I said.

Excited, she quickly grabbed the bag from my hand.

What next?

“Oh my God!” she screamed.

“Shh!”

“Oops,” she bit her tongue. “Seriously, you got this for me? Really?” she was super-excited but was forced to whisper.

“No, I bought it for someone else,” I teased her.

“Fuck you,” she hit me with the bag.

“I just can’t thank you enough, though,” she said, happily.

She quickly hugged me. With her arms around me, she kissed my cheeks and whispered in my ear, “I love you so much. You always make me feel so special.”

Kissing her ears, I said, “Wear it and make it more special.”

“Here?”

“I don’t mind,” I winked.

“Pervert!”

Taking the top, she said, “I have a washroom to change.” She winked and disappeared inside, closing the door, teasing me for probably the hundredth time.

Master bedrooms suck!

I went to the bookshelf. I don’t know why but I was attracted to it. I browsed the books. All were by bestselling Indian writers.

How do they get the time to write? I thought.

I randomly picked up a book and read the synopsis. Aditya and Riya were the names of the lead characters. The name now attracted me. The author claimed that it was his own story.

Are there so many love stories in real life?

How cool to pen something of your own, another thought followed the previous one.

The books in her shelves motivated me to write, for the first time ever in my life. It wasn't that I had wanted to publish a book or desired to see my book on these shelves. I had never even considered it. It was definitely not on my bucket list. Writing a book was furthest from my mind, so publishing one was out of the question. But I just wanted to note down the feelings I was going through. I wanted it to be inked somewhere, so that a few years down the line I could read them and relive the happy moments. That's when the thought of maintaining a personal diary crossed my mind but my thoughts were soon interrupted as Rutuja entered the room again.

She looked stunning. She wore a pair of blue denim shorts under the top, and with her captivating looks, she smiled at me. I gazed at her from top to toe. She walked towards me slowly, absolutely alluring in her attire, awakening the libido in me. I was enthralled by her as she came closer. I was ogling at her. As she wound her arms around me, she set my heart and body on fire. Her buttery soft cheeks touched mine as she kissed my cheeks again. We could hear each other's hearts thundering in our chests. In the silence of the night, a pleasant breeze waltzed in from the window. It rustled her hair and strands of it fell on my face. The fragrance of her hair captured my senses. She looked into my eyes and then slowly closed them. We drew closer to each other and our breaths mingled. Our lips touched. Her luscious lips delicately embraced mine. With her hand running over my back, she kissed passionately. It was the best kiss we had shared so far. We were both aroused and we kept kissing each other, slowly undressing each other. Love and lust were in the air and there was no stopping. Suddenly there was a knock on the door.

We quickly drew apart and grabbed our clothes. There was another knock.

"Rutuja!" someone called out.

The voice startled us.

"Who is it?" I gestured.

“Mom,” she whispered.

A third knocked sounded on the door.

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8 JUNE 2014

What about the feelings that have been knocking at the doors of my heart? As the lambent moon cast a shadow on the crumbling walls, I opened the diary. Lighting another cigarette, I adjusted the diary so that the moonlight fell on it. I was drunk but my eyes tried to read. The empty bottles of alcohol, a few crushed to pieces by my rage, were evidence of my agonised heart. The more I drank, the more my body wanted me to intoxicate itself. The liver was probably pitying me over my stupidity to shut it down forever and eventually, someday it would have—with the alcohol running in my blood. The alcohol was becoming a threat to me but who cared, when it could shut down the heart temporarily.

Hatred filled me. I was laughing at my own defeat. The sleepless nights and alcohol were proof of how difficult it was for me to overcome everything, People cry out of pain to get over all the agony but for me, pain was finding its way to escape into my body in the form of alcohol and act like a poison.

*I feel so strong when I'm with my heart,
full of love and joy around you.
You're like my guardian angel,
watching over me all the time,
I feel like I'm in heaven, surrounded by angels,
I know, deep in my soul, we belong together.
I love you more than the stars above us.
You make my eyes shine brighter than the sun.*

*When I'm with you,
I know everything will be okay.
You're there for me when I need you.
You hold me and tell me everything will be okay.
Your arms around me keep me safe.
I wish you put your arms around me forever.
And never let me go.
You keep me warm and happy;
our hearts belong to each other.*

How easy it is to say our hearts belong to each other! Easier than actually falling in love! Love, these days, has become as easy as changing the Facebook status from 'single' to 'in a relationship'. This four-letter word 'LOVE' is the most selfish and complicated of all words. According to the dictionary, love is an intense feeling of deep affection and sexual attraction for someone. So, according to the meaning, love should end after intimacy. I am sure the guy who compiled all the words and wrote the dictionary for the first time doesn't know shit about love.

Kill those people who defined true love and made us believe in it! Hang those who wrote about true love and convinced us that there is something called affection for the other person. My intoxicated brain was not ready to accept what had happened. The same diary which had these poems written in them—with the larger than life past inked in them—prided itself for being called a pleasant ride of our relationship. It had no inkling of what was yet to be engraved upon it.

Cry for love! Die for love! Shout for love! Someone was saying to me. I shouted, I cried and probably it was time to die. Deep down even though I

was dead, the Almighty up there was definitely not going to help me. He was enjoying the show!

Was I making any sense?

Who cared when there was no sense left in life?

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The knock at the door was alarming.

“What shall I do?” I whispered.

“Hide under the bed or inside the bathroom. Quick!” she whispered back.

I was freaking out. Without a second thought, I ran to the washroom. I had hardly shut the door when I heard the door to Rutuja’s room open. Petrified, I held my breath and leaned against the wall.

“What took you so long?” asked her mom.

“I was sleeping!” she said, pretending to be drowsy, “What is it, mom?”

Her mother took a quick look around. I could hear the sound of her feet moving around in the room. The sound came closer . . . right outside the washroom door.

Fuck, I exclaimed to myself.

“What is it mom?” asked Rutuja again.

“Were you talking to someone?”

“Now?”

“Yes now!”

“Yes. Anuja called me, sometime back.”

The suspicious look on her mom's face horrified Rutuja. Meanwhile, I could only hope she wouldn't open the washroom door.

"This girl will spoil you," began her mom, "Is this the time to talk over the phone? And what is it that you have to talk at midnight?"

Rutuja stood silent.

"It's your twelfth, better spend time studying!" she began.

"Mom!" she sniffed, "I just talked for a minute or two!"

"I don't know," said her mom and pausing, looked around once again. She said, "I am being kind to you. If your dad gets to know that you talk over the phone at night, he will take away your mobile. Better study or simply sleep."

Turning around, her mom warned her, "Not a word now, straight to bed!"

Perplexed over how to react, Rutuja stood silent. She just wanted her mom to leave the room.

"Sorry and good night, mom," said Rutuja, shutting the door and latching it from inside.

She was quiet for a while to ensure that her mom wasn't near the door. Then she whispered, "Come out! She's gone."

I sighed with relief. Peeping out of the washroom and double-checking with my own eyes, I stepped out.

"Gosh! I was damn scared!" I admitted.

"I am all freaked out," she imitated me.

"Why?"

"Nothing," she said and sat on the bed. Silence reigned until she decided to break it.

“You should go now! I can’t risk this. We will meet in college tomorrow.”

Finally, the night had to end! The essence of romance that had just built up had culminated in a way we had never expected. Her mom had abruptly cut the strings of passion that were just about to evolve or probably take the relationship a step ahead into a physical relationship. Creeping out of the room, I somehow made my way to the main gate. Rutuja kept an eye on her parents. Making sure I was out of the house safely, she heaved a sigh of relief.

And then the saddest part of the day was that I had to sprint back to my house and enter yet another house without getting caught.

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A few days passed. Then came the day we were supposed watch Dhoom-3. It was a special movie for us. We had been eagerly waiting for it for quite some time. It was definitely one of the most awaited films of the year for a lot of people. We were no different. I had pre-booked two tickets and was loitering outside the theatre, waiting for Rutuja. As usual, she was late. I called her up several times and finally at my tenth attempt, she picked up my call.

“I am coming! Hold on!” she said.

She had this bad habit of being late for everything, and I found it annoying. After another ten minutes of waiting, I saw her walk up to me. Dressed in a black tank top and blue denim shorts, she carried the perfect charisma. Her cleavage lured me. Seeing her cute smile as always, made my frustrations disappear in a second.

“Sorry . . . sorry, sorry!” she said in quick succession as she pranced over.

“Now, be quick, I don’t want to miss watching Aamir’s entry,” she was super-excited as she took my hand and pulled me inside the theatre. Armed with popcorn, Coke, and two sandwiches, we took our seats. The movie began on a promising note. I actually didn’t care about the movie; all that mattered to me was her presence. I had my eyes on her. Through the corner of my eyes, I watched her. From Aamir’s entry to each and every punchline he delivered in the movie, she would look at me with a cheerful smile, her eyes full of praise such as:

•‘He is so good! ‘

- *‘What a dialogue!’*
- *‘There’s no one like Amir.’*
- *‘Just admire his rippling muscles!’*

It was just, ‘Aamir, Aamir, and Aamir!’

The movie progressed as we sat there, with our fingers entwined. She looked into my eyes every now and then but we didn’t utter a word. We hesitated . . . but enjoyed the silence and the satisfaction of being together! I put my arm around her and she leaned her head on my shoulder, quickly giving me a light kiss on my cheek. She looked into my eyes again with her hair falling on her face. I gently tucked it behind her ear. I kissed her forehead while she put the popcorn in my mouth. Lost in each other, we did not pay attention to the movie. We didn’t care if the thief was caught or assassinated or about the climax. People sitting near us had some good entertainment too, watching us.

Winking at her and touching her cheeks, I said, “They are so soft!”

She smiled, almost blushing. She touched my face and we had our foreheads against each other’s. She closed her eyes and I understood what I had to do next. The distance between us diminished as I closed my eyes too. Soon our lips were almost touching and our warm breath mingled when there was a rude shock. There was a deafening sound from the screen. A car crash—not one but many! Romance ended in a second and we sat back, just in time to see the final chase. I could see Jay and Ali (Abhishek Bachchan and Uday Chopra) come to a screeching stop on their bikes as the cars continued to topple.

“Thank you, mummy,” said Uday Chopra in his own style for saving them both. He thanked someone but left me wondering, whom should I curse for another fucked up intimate moment between us?

The cat-and-mouse chase was on as the two of them set out to hunt Aamir down.

Wasn't Aamir with Katrina, a few minutes ago? I thought.

It was hard to believe that the end of the movie was close. We had hardly watched the movie! Rutuja was again lost in the screen and I silently cursed fate.

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On reaching home, I received a text from Rutuja.

‘Oye Samar, what’s up?’

‘Samar?’ I was puzzled.

She sent me a laughing emoticon. It took me a few minutes to recollect that Samar was the below average character played by Aamir Khan in the movie.

I: Better die! :D

Rutuja: Lol, When? Where? :p

I: Anywhere.

Rutuja: Nah! You won’t be able to live without me, fattu!

I: Fattu?

Rutuja: Couldn’t even kiss me in the theatre :p

I: It all happened because of the cars toppling and the chaos that followed it. Forget it! If you think even after

Rutuja: Blah, Blah Blah, Whatever! Sarcasm at its best!

Our chats were silly at times, but after all, relationships in junior college days are all about being childish. She always complained that I was childish, but the real child was in her. And I was enjoying every bit of it.

I wanted these happy days to go on forever. I felt like saying ‘time-please’ to destiny. Yes! I always believed in destiny and I still do! It brought us together and probably is responsible for every good or bad thing that happened to me. The way she looked at me, the way she smiled, the way we teased each other and all the physical moments we shared had to be saved somewhere. Ever since I had visited her house and gone through her bookshelf, the idea of maintaining a diary had been on my mind. It was fascinating that it was me who thought of writing something. Never in my dreams had I ever believed that I would pen something.

After ending the call, I fetched a diary from the pile of unused books in one of the rooms. I wiped off the dust and opened it. Picking up a pen, I spent fifteen minutes thinking about what to write. A novel was definitely not my goal. I named the diary Aadi-Rutuja Diary.

I re-lived the days right from the day she had proposed to me. I jotted down the date and that was day 1 of my diary.

Day 1- Rutuja proposed to me.

Day 2 – Date at Venky’s.

.
. .
. .
. .

*Day * - Our first kiss!*

It was all in bullet points. I didn’t have the ability to elaborate any of the moments we had shared. I just jotted down things childishly and in broken English. The only thing I was probably good at was poetry. Poems need emotions and at that point of time, my heart was flooded with them.

***‘Ishq aisa karo ki dhadkan mein bas jaye,
Saans bhi lo toh khushboo usi ki laye,
Pyaar ka nasha aankhon pe chha jaye,
Baat kuch bhi ho par naam usi ka aye.’***

Translation:

***Love somebody so much that she resides in your heart,
So much that you breathe
and you can smell her fragrance,***

So much that your eyes get inebriated with love,

So much that you find her in everything.



31 December arrived and it was time to bid goodbye to 2013 and welcome 2014. This new year was definitely going to be different from the ones I had experienced till date. With Rutuja by my side, the year had ended on a good note.

I wanted to welcome the new year with her but to my dismay, she had different plans for the night. She was going to spend time with her school friends. I tried to convince her against it, but she told me that they had planned it in advance and dropping out at the last moment would annoy them. Left without a choice, I had to agree. Disappointed, I spent some time listening to romantic songs that night. Then the phone rang. It was a call from one of my friends, Saniya.

“Hey,” she said.

“Hey, how are you?”

“I am good. Well, Aadi, I was wondering if you’ve planned something for the night.”

“Not really,” I said.

“Oh, well I am in town . . . how about hanging out together?”

Ugh, I thought and she could actually hear it.

“Only if you haven’t planned anything already,” she stressed.

“I have no plans, as of now. Can I call you back?”

“Yes, sure,” she said and we hung up.

Hanging out with Saniya wasn't a bad way to celebrate New Year's Eve but my heart yearned for something else. It wanted Rutuja! I wanted to make sure that she had not changed her mind before confirming to Saniya. I called Rutuja.

"Yes?" she answered, a bit rudely.

"Let's go out together. Just let go of your friends," I said.

"Grow up, Aadi! I just can't give up on the plan at the last minute. Moreover, we always spend time together. My friends and I hardly meet."

"Okay," I replied sulkily, which she obviously couldn't see.

"Well, one of my friends Saniya from Mumbai is in town. She just asked me out."

"Go then!" she said, before I even finished what I was saying.

"But I don't want to, I would rather . . ."

"Then don't go," she said, cutting in, even before I could say I want to go out with you.

"Fine, I'll go. I guess I have no choice because I don't want to spend time getting bored on New Year's Eve."

"Okay," she said, sounding disinterested. I hung up realising she wasn't really interested in continuing the conversation. Maybe it was one of those girly mood swings or maybe she was bugged with me.

After the call, I called up Saniya and told her that the plan was on. Later that evening, I showered quickly. I had been longing to wear my Zara jacket for a while now. I paired it with a white V-neck t-shirt and black jeans. On my way out, I informed my sister that I was going to hang out with a friend.

"At least comb your hair," she said and I turned crimson with embarrassment. I had just combed my hair some time ago but it didn't look like it. I hated my hair.

Ignoring her and my hair as I knew it would lead to nothing new, I left. As planned, I met Saniya at the University Road junction.

“Hey,” she greeted me, stepping out of her BMW.

“Hi, good to see you after ages” I said and hugged her.

“Get in,” she said.

She was wearing a blue top and black jeans. We were meeting each other after almost a year. Saniya was from Mumbai and we had met each other at the dance classes I took during my tenth grade. We had become good friends. Her dad worked in Dubai and visited India every year. She lived with her mom. Her dad had never let her feel his absence, providing her with the best of amenities that money could buy.

“Driver mama, KP chalo,” she instructed.

“So, how are you? How is college and how are your studies going?” she asked, turning towards me.

“I am good. Studies—at their best! 2013 has overall been a great year. How has it been for you?” I asked her, smiling.

“Not that great, failed in the term exams,” she replied, showing her evenly sized small teeth.

“By the way, what brings you to Pune?”

“Ugh, I came yesterday to meet some old friends. Mom’s gone to Goa with her kitty party gang and here I am, all alone. I hate her partying all the time,” she said, smiling, although there was a hint of sadness in her face. She probably hated her life. Money alone cannot give you peace and happiness.

“Did you watch any movies recently?” I asked her, changing the topic.

We chatted about various things ranging from studies to career. We talked about films, and then music, finally heading to politics and current affairs.

We discussed our friendship and how we missed each other until we reached our destination. The O Hotel, it said. Situated in the suburbs of Pune, the ambience was just the way I had expected it to be on New Year's Eve.

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“Here we are,” she said, as we stepped out of the car. She had planned the destination and she had kept it hidden from me until the time we arrived there.

Being New Year’s Eve, the place was packed. I saw a few couples in the lobby holding each other’s hands and waiting for their turn. There were friends and families, all eager to get a table.

“So, how is your love life going?” Saniya asked me, raising her eyebrows as we waited in the lobby for some time. Saniya had already booked a table for us. The receptionist told us to wait for a few minutes.

“Nothing much happening, really,” I smiled.

“Oh, so who is the girl you shared a picture with recently? Your crush?” she winked.

Damn, I was caught!

I didn’t want to reveal my relationship with Rutuja to anyone. When it comes to that personal zone of my life, I prefer to be tight-lipped. I am a private person who somehow doesn’t like sharing certain things. I have a ‘no entry’ board to those.

“Just a good friend,” I replied.

“Oh, that’s strange. She didn’t seem like just a friend though,” she teased, “So, my little studious friend! Sometimes, it’s better to have a life besides books. Get yourself a girlfriend.”

“Okay, leave it! Look here,” she said, starting the camera on her phone. One-two-three-four-five, her selfies just didn’t end. I was in a few, while the rest had her making weird faces.

Before her selfies could madden me, we had the receptionist calling out our name. We got a table in the corner of the restaurant. Comfortably seated, I looked around. To our left was a group of college boys screaming and enjoying their moment. They kept abusing each other and having a good time. I tend to be the same when there are boys around, but now I was with a girl and all I could say was, “How disgusting these people are! There are elders and kids around.”

“Disgusting! Mannerless creatures!” she exclaimed.

Later, we ordered chicken tikka, a non-veg platter, a Coke for me and for the main course, a non-veg dish—the restaurant special for the evening. It was lot of food for two, but when it was non-veg we could both binge.

She soon untied her hair and it shifted my attention to her. Not that I was watching her; I was really thinking of Rutuja. I always loved to see Rutuja with her hair loose. I was missing her. I wanted her to be with me. A part of me knew that I could not expect her to be around me all the time, but the other part of me wasn’t ready to accept it. It wasn’t that Saniya’s company was boring, but I don’t know why it wasn’t enough.

“Hey, where are you lost?” she asked, interrupting my thoughts, waving her hand in front of my face.

“Oh, nowhere,” I replied, coming back to the present, mentally.

“Look, what I was saying is . . .” she continued, picking up a piece of chicken tikka with her fork.

I was back to my thinking mode.

•*Is Rutuja missing me too?*

•*Should I call her up?*

•*No, it wouldn't be appropriate to call her when Saniya is with me. What will Saniya think?*

•*Should I text her?*

•*No, let it be. She is with her friends. Let her enjoy.*

Thoughts constantly flooded my mind. However, I kept talking to Saniya, responding to her questions and statements, with no idea of what she said.

‘Well, how about vodka?’ she asked me.

“No, thanks I don’t drink. You go ahead, I don’t mind,” I replied.

•*What must be Rutuja doing now? my thoughts continued to interrupt.*

•*Was going out with her friends more important than me?*

•*Leave, it, I'll make a call. I need her now. I want to talk.*

I called up Rutuja, and to my dismay, there was no response.

She must be busy with her friends, leave it. I'll enjoy here, my thoughts went on.

It was later that I noticed that Saniya was high.

“Oh shit!” I exclaimed.

“Whattt? Do you want to trrrrryyy someee?” she asked me, with her tongue slipping.

“Are you drinking for the first time?” I asked.

“Nooo re baba, second timeee,” she said in a drunk voice, smiling.

“Last timee I hadd jusss a glasss of whisky,” she continued.

“What was the need to drink so much today?” I asked a little loudly.

“Don’t shouttt! I wantt to enjoyy. Sooo . . . you have a sip!”

“No, I don’t want to and please stop,” I grabbed the glass from her hand.

“Finish your food and then we will go,” I added.

“I am done”, she said, after a while.

After paying the bill, we exited the restaurant. She was drunk and unable to walk. She looked like she would fall asleep any moment now. I helped her to the car and opened the door for her.

She kept murmuring, “You know thiss brand wass goood and you . . .”

The driver understood the situation and said, “Aap hotel se thodasa dahi leke aao (Get some yogurt from the hotel)”

I went back to the hotel for a bowl of yogurt and returned to the car. I fed Saniya some and she slowly regained consciousness. We then left. As we drove, her head kept lolling on my shoulder. I tried lifting her head up but in vain; it just dropped back on my shoulders. Finally, I gave up.

In the next fifteen minutes, we reached her apartment. We took the elevator up to her room. I left her a note before letting myself out.

‘Call me when you wake up. Spent a fantastic New Year’s Eve with you! It was good to see you again! You really weren’t in your senses, and yeah before I could wish you, you dozed off. Wishing you a happy and prosperous new year.’

I shut the door and took the elevator to the ground floor. I met the driver and convinced him not to say a word about her being drunk to her parents.

“Don’t worry sir,” he assured me.

I thanked him profusely.

Something inside me made me walk back to her apartment again. I ensured her door was latched properly. I came back to the car and the driver told me that he would drop me home. Sitting in the car, I checked the time. It was almost 12.20 a.m. I wished the driver a happy new year.

Why hadn’t Rutuja still called me? my mind questioned itself

She must have seen my missed calls. Why didn’t she call me back?

I dialled her number again to get the response, ‘the number you are trying to reach is currently busy. Please stay on the line or try calling later.’

I disconnected the call. Seconds later, I received a few messages and calls from some of my friends to which I responded. I called up Varun.

“Hey happy new year buddy,” I said.

“Thanks bro! So, how was your 31st?” he inquired.

“Good enough. How was yours?” I asked him.

“Ekdam mast bhai, spent some quality time with Shaira. Hey, I am still out, I’ll talk to you later bro, sorry.”

“It’s okay, enjoy, bye,” I said and hung up.

I tried calling Rutuja again but got the same response, ‘the number you are calling is currently busy.’

Disappointed, I had no choice but to wait for her call to end. I checked my mobile for messages that I might have missed. There were none from her. I checked my WhatsApp, Messenger and Hike, but I was disappointed. My heart yearned to wish my girlfriend—who seemed to have forgotten to wish me a happy new year,

Nikhil came to my mind. I hadn't wished him either.

Leave it, we are no more friends, my mind said.

Minutes later, I felt that it was new year, a new beginning and that I should leave behind the past. I opened our WhatsApp chat and typed a message.

'Happy new year, Nikhil. Wish you a nice, prosperous year and a good future ahead.'

All I had to do was click on the 'Send Message' button, but then the horrific past replayed in my mind and erased the courage I had somehow mustered to message him. With hatred taking control, my fingers managed to press the backspace key. All sorts of thoughts flooded my mind—probably an alarming sign.

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I was home in the next twenty minutes. I thanked the driver, went upstairs and rang the bell. I wished my uncle, aunt, and my little sister and quickly headed to my room. The next minute, I received a call from my parents. It was still New Year's Eve in London. We wished each other and chatted for a while, after which I hung up.

One call I was eagerly waiting for was from Rutuja. I called her up again and got the same response. I checked the time again. It was 1.30 a.m.

•Now, who the hell is so important that she had to talk to for more than an hour? my heart cried.

•Didn't she even think of me and realise that she hadn't wished me?

•Didn't she check the missed calls?

•And forget those missed calls! She should have at least thought of me and called me once.

•Don't I hold any importance in her life?

Anger raged inside me. Changing into my nightwear, I banged my fist on the wardrobe. I kept checking my mobile every five minutes. Every second, I thought of calling her again and every nanosecond, I was thirsty to hear her voice.

Fifteen minutes later, I called her again and this time her phone rang. My indignation was at its height. Another couple of rings later, a sweet voice filled my ear.

“Hieee, Aadi, happy new year! Wish all your dreams come true.”

I wanted to shout. I wanted to make a fuss. I wanted to bombard her with the questions that were drowning me and had kept me disturbed for some time but her melodious voice dissolved it all. People madly in love would agree that the sweet voice of the person you love is enough to cool down your temper. I don’t know what happened inside me. The anger somehow disappeared. It was as if I had enough bullets in my pistol and wanted to fire but they just didn’t propel out when pressed the trigger.

“Happy new year, Ru.” I wished her in a calm voice.

“You didn’t even think of wishing me! You were so busy over the phone!” I continued in a softer voice.

“One of my old friends had just called. I had to speak. He just wouldn’t stop. Sorry!” she said again sweetly, emphasising the word sorry.

“It’s okay, never mind, so how was your party?” I asked her.

“Ek dum mast, I am at my friend’s house. We are making it the best of times. It’s full-on party mode, you might just be able to make out with the noise around,” she replied in a delighted voice.

“Definitely, party hard and enjoy it to the fullest. So are you . . .?”

“Hey, I am getting another call, talk to you later, bye, miss you,” she said, before I could complete my sentence.

“Okay, bye,” I said, but the call had already been disconnected.

It was certainly not a great start to 2014—not the way I had expected it to be. I had a gut feeling that something was odd. I could sense it instinctively.

Why was this happening?

I had no idea. A week ago, we had been watching Dhoom-3 and now things had somehow changed. For no apparent reason, the monotonous flow of thoughts just didn't end.

Maybe she is really busy. She needs her personal space. No need to panic! said my heart.

But then, why didn't she call you? In spite of those missed calls it was you who called her up again before she picked up your call! What made her wait for so long? Definitely something is wrong! said my brain.

Without a conclusion, both the organs debated involuntarily. For the first time since I had fallen in love, I felt distressed. 2014 had definitely welcomed me with worries. Fretting over the unexplained moments, I dozed off with the question in my mind.

Was this a sign that something bad was going to happen in our relationship?

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New day, new year, a new date on the calendar, and new hopes! I woke up. As if the previous night wasn't enough, the brain kept troubling me all the way, until I brushed my teeth and washed my face. It looked like it had taken up the duty of agitating me with the disturbing questions on my mind.

I opened my diary and wrote, '31st December was different. 2014 is the weirdest. It's horrifying as I sense something bad is about to happen.'

Later, I checked my phone and found a message from Saniya, with a couple of missed calls. The text went:

'Thanks, Aadi for your time. I too had a great eve with you after a long time. Really needed one! So sorry I was drunk! I might have irritated you with my behaviour, and I apologise for it. I don't remember a thing but still, thank you again for tolerating me. Anyway, I know you might be reading this text with sleepy eyes, so I'll keep it short. Happy new year dear! Now you can sleep again :p'

Every day, after I woke up, I usually felt like dozing off again. The body definitely doesn't like welcoming a new day and prefers to wrap itself in a quilt. But today was different! The urge was missing!

With Rutuja on my mind, sleep was out of the question. Saniya's text had managed to bring a smile to my sad face. I immediately called her and then we spoke for the next fifteen minutes. Our call ended with her saying, "New year, new strategies my dear friend, study hard, medical entrances are not that easy!"

It just shook me from head to toe. It awakened the sleeping studious Aditya. It reminded me of my studies and the days left for the entrance exam. I had

to focus. I had to buck up, complete my pending work, complete journals, and be regular. I had to improve my marks in the exams and in the tests that were conducted in our tuitions. With a lot to do, I jotted down certain points and made a new timetable. The strategy to crack the medical entrance was penned down on a chart paper soon.

Spend limited time with Rutuja till the exams. You cannot afford to waste a year if you don't get a seat. Spare the weekends for her and during the weekdays, study hard, my mind guided me.

It was hard for me to be decisive, but I had to do it. Studies had to be a priority. I needed her support too. I hoped she would back me up by saying something like, "Don't worry Aadi, you study, I too will study and we won't disturb each other. We will excel together."

That day, I focused on studying all day. I tried my best to kept Rutuja out of my mind. The moment I ended up solving a Physics problem, I would check the mobile for her WhatsApp messages. Then dismayed, I would forcibly try to focus my mind on the next Physics problem. I diverted the anger, the worries, the disappointment, and almost all my feelings to my studies. I succeeded in keeping her away from my mind until it was evening. Then I could wait no longer. I ended up calling her.

"Hi," I said.

"Hi!"

"What are you doing?" I asked.

"Nothing."

She was not in the mood to talk. Her lame answers frustrated me. I told her about the previous night; how Saniya and I had partied, and how I had missed her.

"Great!" was all she said.

"What's wrong, Rutuja?" I asked.

“Nothing,” she replied.

“Why aren’t you talking?”

“I am talking!”

And her replies irked me even more.

“Say something!” I stressed.

“I am,” she said and was again quiet.

The most difficult situation is when your love speaks in monosyllables and you’re eager to have a conversation. It’s easier and more convincing if she doesn’t speak at all or shouts at you and points out something she’s annoyed with. But it is heart-wrenching when she doesn’t let out anything and prefers being silent, leaving you wondering what happened.

Speak up! Say something! Scold me; beat me if I am wrong. Share your problem if something is disturbing you! my heart shouted.

It later wondered,

Did I commit some mistake?

Why is she behaving different?

What happened, all of a sudden?

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Days passed. I would call up Rutuja and we would either end up with another insipid conversation or she would simply not answer the call. The messages would pop up after waiting for days together. She was avoiding me. I had no clue or justification for this change. I was so involved with her. She meant everything to me. The personal space I had spared for her was about to be invaded by my obsession. It was what my heart wanted; my body thirsted for her. Irritated, I wanted to shout at her and question her for her behaviour, but my emotions and the love I had for her handicapped me. I controlled myself with endless excuses:

She must be worried about the approaching exams or maybe she wanted to study and that is difficult with our day and night chats.

OR

She might be going through some family problems or something that doesn't allow her to shift her attention to me.

I came up with many such excuses to calm myself. There were days when I would call her in the morning and she would call me back in the evening, after almost a dozen missed calls. There were days when she wouldn't reply to my messages at all. Many times, I would call her and she would say that she was busy and would call me back later, and that 'later' would be

forgotten. I was truly frustrated by this. The devil inside me was looking for a way to burst out in anger, but I would suppress him, continuing to make excuses.

Her mobile might be on the silent mode, so she might not have seen those missed calls or messages

OR

She might be busy studying and so didn't attend any calls.

OR

She might be with her family and so was afraid of attending my calls.

OR

There might be no credit in her mobile.

And that 'might' logic would go on and on, with no real answers. Many a times, I had questioned her on her changed behaviour and all I would get was:

•*Where am I behaving different?*

•*I am just the same.*

•*Arrey, I was busy.*

•*I was with my friends.*

•*I was studying and so I had kept my mobile in one of my drawers, and I couldn't hear it ringing.*

•*My mom had taken away my mobile, so that I study.*

She gave many nonsensical excuses and I believed them to an extent. I don't know if she was fooling me or whether I was fooling myself by making excuses for her. The tight control I had over my anger was diminishing day by day. After the many excuses she had already made, I was in no mood for more. Now, whenever she didn't speak properly or avoided me, I started shouting at her. I started becoming a rebel.

"I don't give a fuck! Talk to me or just leave it, I don't want to talk," I said once.

"Fine, bye," she replied and aggravated my frustration.

I had just crossed my limit! I shouldn't have shouted, my mind said moments later.

Did I just mess it up?

I called her again and the phone rang itself out. I kept trying and then the mobile was switched off. It troubled me even more.

Why was she doing this to me?

Other days, whenever the call got connected, I kept asking her questions and reasons behind her changed nature and that annoyed her even more. The pillars of our relationship had turned shaky. The bonds of love had started to weaken. I still loved her, but that love was now turning into possessiveness. More than my girlfriend, she had now become my obsession. I couldn't afford to lose her. I made it a point of keeping track of what she did every day, not by following her or by keeping a watch on her secretly, but by directly asking her.

- Where were you?*
- What did you do today?*
- Whom were you talking to?*
- Why didn't you pick up my call?*
- It probably annoyed her even more. And now, I feared losing her.
- AND LOSE HER FOR WHAT?***
- No reason for it.*

I tried to recall a day when I might have said something to hurt her, or troubled her by the smallest of my acts, but I couldn't come up with anything. Thinking about her and our past, and finding the reason for our changed relationship, I ended up neglecting my studies. My scores in the weekly tests were low. That shattered my morale. The bottom ranks in these tests shook me, and our failing relationship added some fresh fuel to the fire.

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One Sunday, as usual, I had three tuitions back-to-back. I was in no mood of attending the classes, but I had to, as I knew I must study if I wanted to become something in life. Also, this was the only way I could meet my parents' expectations. Already well aware of the genetics—the so-called son of a topper dad, I had my own fight against my relatives who kept saying, 'You are Rajesh's son. You should be a born topper. You have it in you.' The pressure of failing was killing me from inside but how could I explain it to them? It is an honour and pride to be the son of a brilliant father and a blessing to be born with a silver spoon, but the real struggle begins from the day you are expected to match your father's achievements. I was getting overshadowed by his achievements, and that had now turned into my insecurity.

That day, as I was just entering my Physics tuition class, I received a call from Rutuja. It was unexpected and I was happy and equally curious to know what she had to say. I immediately picked up her call.

She said, "Hey Aadi, what's up?"

Her sudden change in attitude was something of a shocker to me.

"Let's go out, I want to eat pani poori," she added.

Now I was really puzzled by her call. She had not called for almost fifteen days and had also been avoiding me for no reason. The depressed me wanted to go out with her but to my dismay, I had a test that day for which attendance was compulsory. On top of it, the professor was strict and would phone our parents or guardians if we were absent for the tests. I had no option but to say no to Rutuja.

“Let’s go! Fuck the tests. We haven’t gone out together lately,” she insisted. Realising that I had no choice, she gave up.

“Let’s go out tomorrow,” I said to pacify her but she did not respond to that.

I appeared for the test and then attended the tuition classes for the other subjects.

I reached home at 10.00 p.m. and called her.

“Hello,” she said, and I could hear a lot of noise in the background—cars honking and noisy crowd.

“Hello, where are you? Sorry, I couldn’t make it today,” I said.

“Aa . . . no problem, well I am out for dinner with Ajinkya, my friend. Talk to you later, bye,” she replied in a hurry.

Before I could say anything, she hung up. I didn’t like the way she treated me. Calling her again would have annoyed her and so I started texting her. She replied much later.

For the first time, I felt that she was giving more importance to someone other than me. I deserved her attention. I was important in her life—I was her boyfriend and I should mean something to her. Obsessed and equally afraid of losing her, my mind started playing games, again.

•*Couldn’t she have waited till tomorrow?*

•*Was it so urgent that she thought it better to go out with Ajinkya than wait for tomorrow, so that we could hang out together?*

•*And all she had said was pani poori and how did it end up with dinner?*

•*Didn’t she even think of asking me or think about how I would feel after knowing that my love was having dinner late at night, not with me but with*

her ex-boyfriend Ajinkya, and was too busy to text me, saying she was out with him?

•Was he her boyfriend or was I?

Thoughts like these flooded my mind, bringing out the violence in me. I slammed the doors of the room and stopped myself from calling up Rutuja and abusing her. I knew I was getting over-possessive about her with each passing day, but she too was responsible for this. I didn't like her hanging out with guys or talking to people who were flirty. I had talked to her many times asking her to stay away from such people, but she hardly listened. She was the master of her own life. Nothing was wrong in being the master of one's life but the relationship we shared probably gave me some right to at least question her for going out with her ex. One can call it insecurity but I don't think there was anything wrong in being insecure, considering her changed attitude. She was my gem and if anyone dared to touch her, I don't know to what extent I would hurt them.

Today, she had hurt me in so many ways. By her act, her behaviour, and her speech, she had shattered me to pieces. Finally, I lost control over my anger and called her up.

She picked up and said, "I told you right? I'll call you later, I'm busy."

"Oh, so you are busy! Ajinkya has become more important to you overnight, right? You didn't even find it necessary to tell me that you are going out all alone with your ex? Did you even stop to think about how I would feel?" I shouted.

There was silence and then I continued, "And forget today, why the hell are you avoiding me? Can I ask you that? All of a sudden you don't pick up my calls and don't even think it necessary to call me back. What did I do? At least point out my mistake."

"You know—you are getting too possessive! Stop questioning or interfering with my private zone! I have the right to decide what to do, I am

independent,” she replied, with a hint of anger in her voice.

Private zone, wow! I thought. I had never expected such a response.

She continued, “And it’s not necessary that I should be attending your calls, day and night. Ajinkya is my best friend and I don’t need anyone’s permission to hang out with him. Your problem is that you are getting too involved with my life. When you go out with Saniya all alone—how is that okay?” she shouted back at me.

Ajinkya was your ex-boyfriend and now you call him your best friend. What’s going on? I wanted to ask.

She hurt me by what she said. There was no reason to defend Ajinkya and fight with me.

With eyes welling up, I replied, “If you remember, I had asked you before spending the evening with Saniya and you said that you were fine with it. Apart from this, you have been avoiding me for no reason. I have nothing to be guilty about.”

I wanted to hear something like, “I’m sorry—you are misunderstanding it, Aadi. It will not happen again, calm down,” but that was just my brain playing games. Instead all I heard from her was, “Look, if you think you are so great, you can go to hell. It’s up to me to decide whether I should answer your calls or not. Well, let me tell you that with your possessiveness, your excessive involvement in my life, I am no more interested in being with you. To be honest, I don’t want you in my life anymore. You are free from today.”

I was completely shocked and petrified. The ground beneath me started to move. I fell short of words. With the breakup, my hands were trembling and then my whole body shivered. I felt a lump in my throat as my mouth turned dry and the adrenaline rushed through my body.

I remained silent and she resumed talking, “And if you think it’s all of a sudden, you are wrong! I have never liked your possessiveness over me. You know, you don’t love me; you just want to own me. I am not for sale—

keep this in mind! Also, let me tell you that I went for a movie with Ajinkya, so now do you want to question me for that? I have my freedom and I am an individual, don't try and rule over me. The truth is that I am over you. Now and today, I am ending our relationship. I don't think we gel properly. We can be friends if you want, but I don't want anything more than that, you understand?"

Another long silence followed. I just had no words. Tears flowed down my cheeks.

The words You don't love me, kept echoing in my mind and stabbed my heart. The pain it caused was like the pain of a stabbing knife. Her harsh words echoed in my mind over and over. I was confused about whether I should end the call or try to talk to her. She eventually hung up on me. I couldn't believe what she had just accused me of and said about our relationship. I was not sad over her going out with Ajinkya, but what really hurt me more was that she had interpreted my love for her in the wrong way. My caring nature had become my possessiveness; and my questioning her had become my involvement in her life. What struck my mind later was, if she loved me, she wouldn't have ever thought of breaking up.

- What happened to the promises?*

- Was our relationship just a one-sided commitment?*

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RUTUJA – LETTER ONE!

‘He came like a prince and lifted her spirits by falling in love. Never had she believed in true love before. For a child whose dad worked in the police department and a mom who slogged at the bank, love was something, which had been missing since childhood. The girl had always looked to her colleagues and their parents wistfully. If they could give their children the time, then why couldn’t her parents do the same? Why was she deprived of happiness? Where could she find her love? She tried finding love in novels. They connected with her in the best way and thus began her journey of fantasy. She found her peace in her friends. Love probably meant everything to her.

Years later, when she believed love didn’t exist or could have never existed, especially after her past, which she didn’t allow to invade her life again, she met a guy in college. He was curly-haired, broad-shouldered, had a smiling face and wore glasses that suited him . . . she met her prince. Afraid of falling for him, she let friendship govern her. It was with time that she sensed she had feelings for the guy. Studious but not so charming, it was his kindness that attracted her the most. He was not extra-ordinary, but he was sincere and authentic. Like her, he too was battling against life. It was his struggle against his fate—the fate of being the son of a studious father. She felt connected to him and thought she loved him.

Days passed and she sensed that he felt the same about her. Gathering confidence, she proposed to him. She feared rejection but wanted to give it a try. And guess what? The guy was all hers. Extremely happy, she dreamed about a future with him. She was ready to be his. He gave her gifts and

made her feel special. It was something she had never received from her parents. He made her feel blessed to have him as her boyfriend. They promised never to leave each other!

But what next? As the year came to an end, her life became complicated. Her past came back to the present. Something she hadn't expected or wished for had just come back into her life. Over everything else, what added fuel to the fire was that her love had decided to spend time with his friend on New Year's Eve. Not that he hadn't taken her consent, but it was something she was not happy about. There was nothing wrong in being with a friend and she allowed him to spend time with her. That day, she spent time with her friends too. She was having a great time and missed his calls. When she did notice them, she got busy with calls from her cousins wishing her at midnight. She had to hurriedly disconnect the call and wish her boyfriend, and then again attend to the other calls. However, her boyfriend was not in the frame of mind to listen to her.

As 2014 commenced, she was confused with the situation. She had two paths in front of her now. She could go back to her past or lead a life with her boyfriend. She was in a dilemma and wanted to be left alone. That's when her boyfriend kept calling her and questioning her about the sudden change in her attitude. How could she explain to him? How could she share a past, which she had kept hidden from him? How could she answer his questions? She decided to avoid his calls sensing that it would at least keep her away from his repetitive questions. He irritated her now. What if someone keeps hounding you about why you are the way you are, all the time? What would you reply to him? He too might have been irritated and once said, "Fuck off! I don't want to talk."

"Fine, bye!" that's all she said. Then, fed up with all of it, she stopped attending his calls.

Fifteen days later, she sensed she just couldn't avoid him anymore and wished to turn things normal and asked him out for pani poori. She had started getting over the confused mind and the past that had kept haunting her. To her dismay, he had his Physics test. Was the test so important to him? Didn't he miss her? Didn't he want to be with her? Puzzled and equally bored with spending the day all alone, she called up her friend and

asked him out. He immediately agreed unlike her boyfriend. She was happy that someone was there to relieve her of boredom.

Dressed in casuals, she went out with her friend for dinner. Just when they were settling down her boyfriend had called her up. She told him that she was busy and that she would call him back but he was persistent. He kept calling her. Couldn't he understand when she had said she was busy? Couldn't she have her own time apart from being with him? She couldn't always be his! She had her own space as well. Annoyed, she retaliated a bit harshly but never expected him to insist on knowing why she had changed. He was back to square one and was repeating the same questions. She had believed that he had moved on from that day, but he hadn't and what came next was unbelievable: he argued with her for hanging out with her friend. He was loud and angry. Didn't she have her freedom? Why was he so obsessed with her? Why did he want to control her and ask, "Why didn't you pick up my calls?" He has to understand that she can't be his 24 x 7.

Furious over his attitude, she felt that he just wanted to own her and she knew she wasn't for sale. She had her own life, her own decisive mind, and her own ambitious heart. The guy was no more her dream guy. Her heart was shattered to pieces. Destiny had again punched her hard. Agitated, she said it was the end! It was difficult for her, but she had to take a call. She just ended their relationship in the fraction of a second.'

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God only knew what was happening and why was it happening.

What should I do? How should I get out of this problem? I kept thinking.

The mere thought of our breakup and the fear of Rutuja's absence from my life made me weak. My heart wept. If I was a tree, the flowers that added essence to my life had been plucked forever, taking away all the reasons of living. My head ached with the mental trauma the breakup had caused. It felt as if my life had come to a standstill. I did my best to distract my mind by watching one of my favourite shows on television or by listening to songs but it did not work. Each time I tuned in to some music, it just made me cry rather than relieve the pain. Television shows and movies made me visualise Rutuja and me in each of the scenes. I could relate to the characters.

I felt wounded and aggrieved by whatever was happening in my life now. As was my habit these days, I closed my bedroom door and sat on one corner of my bed. I had never faced so much pain in my life. My tears were triggered easily. I put my head between the pillows and tried to control myself. I felt helpless. My mind was flooded with all the good memories of Rutuja and me. I wanted those happy days back. I yearned for them. The way we held each other's hands, the way we attended lectures together, our dating, our chats, the way we looked at each other, and the way we would cuddle with each other—I missed it all desperately. Time stopped—life stopped for me. Maybe the pain would fade away with time. For now, I was reduced to crying and expecting that someday she would be back in my life.

The more I cried, the weaker it made me. I could barely eat and that aggravated the physical weakness. Each day began with me hoping she would call or message but nothing came my way. During college hours, she

avoided me and made sure that I got no chance to interact with her. She had formed her own group of girls and the moment I tried to initiate a conversation, the group would help her leave the place. With every passing day, the situation became worse.

One day, I stopped her in the corridor.

“I need to talk to you,” I said, as she started climbing down the stairs along with her friends the moment they saw me.

“I need five minutes, just five minutes, please, Rutuja,” I begged, catching her hand and stopping her.

“Let go of my hand,” she replied, with a hint of anger. All eyes turned on us.

“Hey, you can’t do this,” said one of the girls in the group.

“Just stay out of it and mind your own business,” I said arrogantly and the girl backed off, muttering something. She was definitely abusing me.

“What is it?” asked Rutuja, so that she could get rid of the eyes that had turned to us.

“Can we go out somewhere and talk?”

“No, just finish it here,” she replied.

I looked into her eyes and gathered confidence. I said, “Rutuja, I know, I was wrong but you see, I definitely don’t deserve this treatment. My heart hurts when you don’t talk to me and treat me like a stranger. We can very well end this like any other fight and give our relationship a chance. I love you and I can’t live without you. I am sorry for whatever happened.”

I controlled my tears and my emotions in front of the twenty-odd people who were enjoying the scene.

She looked at the floor and then setting her hair behind her ear and looking past me, she said, “Look Aditya, just get over everything that happened

between us. All I can say for your own good is that I am not your type and you will get a better girl than me. Just move on.”

She had said ‘move on’ so easily and that hurt me even more.

How could she so easily move on?

“I want you; I fucking want you,” I shouted, looking straight into her eyes, catching her by her arms.

“Stop creating a scene here and leave me,” she shouted back.

“Are you still angry?” I asked, apologetically.

“No, I have forgiven you. Happy?” she replied.

“But what about us?”

“There is no us, Aditya!” she shouted, looking irritated.

“But why? What went wrong?” I asked, unhappily.

“Just leave it, bye,” she said and walked away from me.

“Rutuja!” I called out and ran after her but in vain.

“Rutuja, just stop!” I kept saying as she hurriedly walked off to the parking area, irritated and furious.

“Just let go of me!” she joined her hands before me out of frustration. Her face turned red as she again started walking. This time I just couldn’t follow her. The image of her joining hands before me kept flashing in my mind and stopped me in my tracks. People on the campus were watching me. Some laughed, some gossiped, a few enjoyed the whole scene, a handful felt bad for me. The single ones were thankful for they now had a chance to woo the college’s hottest chick. With my feelings devastated, my eyes fell upon Nikhil, who was watching me from across the street. For a minute, there was silence and then sensing the discomfort, he walked away. I was helpless. And alone.

*‘Aankhon mein sapne leke koi zindagi mein aata hai,
Unhi sapno mein gum deke woh chala jata hai,
Khwabo ki iss duniya mein woh ishq ke par fehlati hai,
Pyaar mein udte hue iss aashiq ko
zameen par wohi girata hai,
Hazaro sapno mein ek sapna wohi dikhata hai,
Inhi sapno ko todkar kabhi woh chala jata hai,
Jana hi tha aane wale ko toh pehle ye sikhake jata,
Ki use khone ke bad jiya kaise jata hai!’*

Translation:

*Somebody enters into your life
fulfilling your happy dream,
And leaves you someday, making it a sad dream,
In this hallucinating world of dreams,
he blesses you with the wings of love,
And someday, makes you fall hard on the
ground from the sky above,*

*Among thousands of dreams,
he becomes your one dream,
Yet he leaves you someday,
shattering your heart and dream,
If he had always wanted to go someday,
he could have taught one thing,
That how should one live after losing him.*

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'It's easy to fall in love but difficult to get out of it. Oh, thank you, my life, for being so kind to me! Thank you, destiny, for the eternal love and for making me feel as helpless as ever. Thank you, God, for showering your blessings upon your child! Thank you everyone for making me absolutely nothing!'

I wrote in my diary upon returning home. All I had wanted was her and no one else.

How could she call off our relationship with such ease?

Mr. Aditya, you meant absolutely nothing to her! spoke my inner voice.

She had felt no pain. The casual way in which she had called off our relationship was just evident on her face.

But why? What was my mistake? Was it only because I had questioned her for spending a day out? Was it because I was possessive? Was it because I loved her more than myself? Was it because I gave her due importance in my life? Was it because I showed commitment? And what about the calls she avoided? Was she entirely blameless? Was it only me who was responsible for everything? Forget all this! I apologised to her as if I was the only one at fault, as if I was responsible for everything and made a mockery out of myself! Isn't that what true love is all about?

Life didn't get any easier. With the ups and downs it had set up for me, I was overwhelmed. I decided to end my life. I had been blinded so much by her love that she was all I wanted and without her, my life was nothing but a desolate land.

The same night, after reliving what had happened and torturing myself mentally by recalling every little thing over and over again, I dashed to the small box I had in one of my drawers. With tears rolling down my cheeks, heart crying in pain, I took the box out of the drawer and emptied it on the floor. I hurriedly went through all the tablets. I had read somewhere earlier that an overdose of Paracetamol can be fatal. I quickly grabbed a water bottle and popped almost ten tablets in quick succession. Next, I drank an entire bottle of Asthalin expectorant. I was completely out of my senses and couldn't think straight. Deeply intoxicated with the emotions of pain, I actually felt that the present had turned so evil that the only way out was death! Crying uncontrollably, I didn't care about the outcome of the drug overdose. I just wanted a quick and painless death!

Fifteen minutes passed and I could sense my feet turning numb. I lost all sensation. My hands became cold and clammy. Sweat rolled down my forehead, and later I could feel the body heat escape out of my nostrils. The numbness in my body slowly increased. The room started spinning. Actually, it wasn't the room but it was my head! My legs started shivering and a chill set in followed by body ache. I could feel my legs cramping. Above all, I still managed to cry as the mental pain had not subsided yet. In spite of having taken the fatal dose of drugs, it was actually the relationship, which was destroying me. I kept looking at one end of the room, even though the darkness had begun to set in. That was when my mobile rang and I could see Rutuja calling displayed on the screen. In spite of the drugs, it was the only thing I managed to make out.

I picked up her call and I could hear her shout, "What have you done? What was the need? Are you fucking crazy?"

She was shouting at the other end.

"What?" I said in a feeble voice choked by my tears.

"Why have you attempted suicide?" she asked me raising her voice higher.

I remained silent. I was startled as she mentioned the word 'suicide.'

How did she know?

“Answer me, Aditya!” she shouted. I had changed from Aadi to Aditya now!

“I didn’t,” I lied, but my voice was suggestive of the lie.

“You just texted me now, saying you wanted to talk to me for the last time and that you are ending your life, only because I am not with you anymore,” she continued. I could sense the panic in her voice.

What! I exclaimed to myself.

I tried checking the inbox messages and ended up disconnecting the call. My hands were shivering because of the overdose and I could hardly read the text. I could just make out that I had texted her something. Completely unaware of when I had texted her, I was surprised and shocked with my own message. I had probably covered myself so much with the blankets of pain that my fingers had just about managed to type a message to her. I couldn’t believe myself.

In the next two minutes, Rutuja called me again and shouted, “Listen Aditya, you are not going to do anything. Please stop!”

There was a long pause. I could hear her cry but couldn’t utter a word.

She said in a teary voice, “Please tell me whatever you said was just a prank. Say you haven’t taken anything. Please for my sake, stop it! We can be good friends and remember, I don’t want to lose you. Please, please, please! Do something, go to the doctor or tell someone in the house please! I beg you Aditya . . . Are you there? Hello?”

“I . . . I love you Rutuja, I don’t want our relationship to end,” I still managed to say as I stood up.

My legs wouldn’t support me. Darkness began to spread in front of my eyes. I tried to walk but stumbled. I tried to hold on to something for support but was still unable to stand steadily. The mobile phone slipped off my hand and fell on the floor. I tried picking it up as it fell for the second time. I could hear Rutuja’s voice on the other end.

“Hello—hello, Aadi . . . Talk to me . . . please,” she said.

“Yeah,” Just as I managed to place the phone on the ear, I collapsed on the floor.

“You’d better get some sleep, Aadi! Or call a doctor, tell someone at home, but please, I beg you to stop. Don’t do this to yourself! Life is precious. I can’t think of a way out; I am totally confused and I don’t know what to do right now. Please take care,” she said, sounding tense.

I was becoming breathless and tried to take a deep breath.

After a long silence, she continued, “Are you there? Hello? Say something, Aditya!

“Yeah, I am fine, don’t worry,” was all I could say, still taking deep breaths.

She kept talking. I could neither hear what she was saying nor understand her clearly. My body had turned cold and began to ache. I can’t remember whether I fainted or dozed off.

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RUTUJA – LETTER TWO!

‘Life had never been easy! How could it suddenly be this time? He had been following her in college for a while now. He wanted to talk to her. She had over fifty pending messages from him. She wasn’t in the state to reply to him. She was avoiding his calls as she was going through a phase.

She knew that her actions were probably painful and disturbing to him but she was left with no choice. She was filled with confusion. How could he keep on irritating her by messaging her day in and day out, she wondered. She too had the right to get annoyed with his constant bugging after she had called off the relationship. Couldn’t he understand that it was a ‘no’ from her side and a ‘no’ was going to remain a ‘no’? He had to understand!

She too couldn’t get him out of her mind but she knew she couldn’t be his! She had her own restrictions. To get over her relationship, she made it a point to dress up well and hang out with girls in the college. She decided to remain fashionable, but it was definitely not to attract him or anyone else. She was just being herself and was hiding her own mental pain and diverting her mind by focusing on external beauty. She made her own group of girls in the college to keep him away. But how could she ever imagine that her being with the girls wouldn’t help her from keeping him away? He had guts and he didn’t care about anyone.

Once, he stopped her mid-way at the corridor. He held her hand right in front of all the teachers, students, and the group of girls she was with. How dare he? Hadn’t she told him that they were done? Agitated, she turned

towards him and was going to burst out but she just couldn't. The guy had tears in his eyes. People around mocked him but he hardly cared. "Leave my hand," was all she could say. She just couldn't insult him in front of everyone. Moreover, his eyes welled up on seeing her and that melted her heart.

"Just give me five minutes," he had pleaded and she couldn't stop herself from avoiding him anymore. She listened to him and he apologised for his mistake. How could she tell him that it wasn't his mistake? It was just that she couldn't be with him anymore. She was avoiding him because she couldn't take the relationship further. It was 'the end' for her but how to explain it to him? No! He pleaded that he wanted to be in a relationship even when she told him that she wasn't the right girl for him and that he should move on with his life. He kept bringing up the topic of their relationship and that just frustrated her even more. Why the fuck couldn't he understand? She couldn't be with him anymore! Agitated, she rushed to the parking area and rode her moped back home after joining hands before him and telling him to leave her alone.

If that could have helped her keep him away from her, she would have been happy. But what came next terrorised her. The person she had loved once had attempted suicide. He had sent her a message. Panicking, she called him and pleaded him to stop. He couldn't talk and she could hear him fall. He was about to face death. She just couldn't lose him! He did mean something to her. If not her boyfriend then, he was her boyfriend once. She had always cared about him. Within minutes, he was going to leave the planet and go away forever. It made the ground beneath her shake. That night, after the call disconnected abruptly, she kept dialling his number but he didn't answer. Was it too late? She messaged him a couple of times but there was still no response, and that worried her even more. Definitely, it was too late, she felt.

Tears poured down her cheeks. Her hands shook at the thought of having lost him. She sobbed. The pain had struck her again. She couldn't bear the agony of losing him. What if she found him dead tomorrow? The mere thought scared her. That night she couldn't sleep. She was restless.

She decided if she found that he was okay the next day, she was definitely going to erase him from her life, forever! She was done with him. He deserved no friendship; a relationship was out of the question now. Bloody coward, he was nothing but a loser who couldn't face the real side of life. He just couldn't face challenges; he was taking the cowardly way out by ending his life. And for such a person, she never wanted to set eyes on him again, ever.'

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The next day, I woke up a little late. It felt like my bones were paining and I could sense my entire gastrointestinal tract burn from inside. I was having a tough time with frequent urination followed by dysentery and dehydration. I searched the internet and found out that Paracetamol can cause hepatic and renal failure. In simpler words, it meant that it could lead to liver and kidney failure. It was related to drug metabolism, first order kinetics, and extensive bioavailability. I learned later, while doing my MBBS that it was the amount of drug that was available to the body after absorption. The rest, which is not available, is excreted in urine. Now since, Paracetamol had 90% bioavailability upon oral administration, it scared the hell out of me. It meant that 90% of the drug had the potential to create havoc in my body. Now that I hadn't faced death, the thought of organ abnormalities for a lifetime or the drug's side effects petrified me. I preferred death over leading an abnormal life.

I remembered everything that had happened the previous night. I wondered why the overdose hadn't proven fatal for me. Probably, the dose was too low or I had been saved by God's grace. I cursed God for it. How could He just save me? Over the years our connection had always been weak, so how did it become strong this time?

Later, I checked my mobile, and found twenty-eight missed calls and multiple messages from Rutuja. Some were at 3.00 a.m., followed by more at 4.00 a.m., which meant that she hadn't slept. I felt bad for her. I cursed myself for disturbing her with my actions.

How could I trouble her!

Before I could call her back, I saw Rutuja calling displayed on the mobile screen.

“Thank God, you picked up! Are you alright? I was worried all night. Why didn’t you answer my calls?” her voice was heavy. It suggested that she had cried the whole night.

“I am good Ru, don’t worry! I dozed off to sleep, sorry,” I replied.

“Okay, never mind. Meet me today in college, see you! Bye,” she said immediately and hung up.

I took a shower and got ready for college. The hangover of the drug made my entire body sluggish. There was abdominal discomfort and a burning sensation, which irritated my entire system. I feared taking ENO fruit salt, though it might probably have helped me get over the gastric irritations and the bad taste in my mouth. I had severe body ache and I was fatigued but I set off to college.

The whole day, I could hardly stand during the practicals, but I somehow managed to complete them. As decided, later, I met Rutuja in the parking area.

She again asked me, “How are you feeling?”

“I am okay,” I replied, without making eye contact. I was embarrassed by my own behaviour. How could I face the girl for whom I was about to commit suicide? I desperately wanted her but then in my innermost mind, I knew whatever I had done was absolutely wrong.

She walked towards me and stared at me. With the anger coming out, she shouted, “What was the need for all this? Only because I don’t want to be in a relationship with you? I told you that I didn’t like your possessive nature, and so I took this decision to end it here. Even after that, we could have been friends but you chose to attempt suicide.”

Her eyes blazed with anger. Her face turned red and she was frowning in frustration. I let her speak, without interrupting, for I knew I was to blame for whatever I had done.

She looked at me as I hung my face in despair. She continued, “Did you ever stop to think how I would have felt? Did you ever think how much tension you might have given me? Forget me, did you even think about your family? Obviously not! All you thought about was you. You love yourself and no one else. You are nothing but a selfish coward! Face it! Life isn’t easy. You could have convinced me or you could have given me some time and space to think about us. But now there will never be an ‘us’! You have fallen in my eyes. I have no respect for you!”

I tried to take her hand but she shook it away. I went close to her and said, sincerely, “I am really sorry, Ru,” but she was in no mood to listen.

“Ru, I just couldn’t think of a way out at that point of time. I was blinded by obsession. I am sorry, I know I am wrong, but it all happened because of our failed relationship. I just couldn’t find a better way out. I know I was wrong; I am really sorry,” I added.

“There’s no use saying sorry now. All the trouble that you had to cause to yourself and me is already done. Your apology won’t change anything now,” she said with teary eyes.

“You know what could have happened because of the overdose? You might have lost an organ or become paralysed or it could have even proven fatal,” she added, agitated by the thought.

She was crying. I came forward to hug her but she pushed me away and slapped me.

She shouted at me, “Why, Aadi why? Don’t other people come out of relationship problems? Why are you so stubborn? I am not the right girl for you. Please find someone else. You deserve a better girl than me.”

“No, I just want you Ru, please! I am sorry, everything will be fine, just forget everything that happened during the last fifteen-twenty days,” I said, still adamant.

“I know nothing, all I can say is I can’t be with you anymore. This relationship is over and so is our friendship. Come out of it, forget

everything, and lead a good life, bye.” She turned away from me.

She was in tears and sat on her moped. She hurriedly started it and without even looking at me, drove out of the campus. I stood there in agony. I had not only lost the relationship but also our friendship.

What have I done! I repented but it was too late now.

Life became tough for me. I wanted her, but couldn’t find a way to get her back. No matter what I tried, it turned out bad.

Once in a while, she would call me, just to make sure I was alright and would say, “Don’t call me or text me, try to be independent and forget me. Just get over everything. Don’t even expect me to call you henceforth. Lead your life—be strong.”

She motivated me.

- Why was she doing it when she never wanted to get back to me?*
- Why was she being nice to me?*
- Did she still think about me?*
- But then why did she call me each time and motivate me and remind me that she was not going to come back to me?*
- Why did her presence matter to me?*

She was probably still in shock and didn’t want me to commit the same mistake again. It was out of humanity that she kept a check on me.

I understood that I had committed the biggest mistake of my life. I wanted our relationship to return back to normalcy. I cried for it, but could do nothing other than cribbing. The positivity I could take out of everything

was to remind myself, she does call you once in a while. You at least get a chance to interact with her and if you give her some time to think about, she might just get back to you. It was just a fantasy coupled with hope. I could think positive, but couldn't beg her to get back to me. I did want more than friendship, but all I could hope for at that moment was friendship.

With a heavy heart, I got on with my life and accepted the situation for what it was. Each day seemed endless and gruelling, but I decided not to cry over our breakup. I tried to brush her off my mind, often failing but I kept on trying. It was not easy to forget the fond memories. I managed to be optimistic and remained calm by reminding myself that I was giving her time and one day she would definitely come back to me. It was torture to keep expecting and waiting but I had no other choice than to just wait.

Meanwhile, I just kept writing in my diary every day.

‘They say, they warn, they opine . . . love is nothing but death, a punishment. No one knows where it ends but definitely those who have reached the end have never managed to get back successfully. It's nothing but a demon which buries you in a grave of your own creation!’

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ONE MONTH LATER . . .

Mentally and physically knackered, I still expected her back. It was a month since she had last called or messaged me. I missed her but I engrossed myself in tuitions and tests. My scores were low but the pain inside me made me work harder. I had to meet my parents' expectations even though my own expectations were a mess.

I was still waiting for Rutuja's call, her text, even a blank one would have been helpful. Nothing happened until one day, when she called me again to ask how I was doing.

"How are you?" she asked me.

"I am good, how are you?" I was as polite as I could be.

"I am good too, thanks for asking," she said, formally.

It was followed by a long silence until she decided to break the silence, "Aadi, I am sorry for everything that happened."

Her words gave me goose bumps. Adrenaline rushed through my body.

•*Did she just apologise?*

•*Does it mean I could get her back? Or at least try?*

There was again a long silence. I could sense that she was thinking. I could hear her take a deep breath and continue, “I am sorry for slapping you, I am sorry for the way I behaved with you, I am sorry for the way I treated you and for avoiding you. I am sorry for everything.”

•*Why was she saying all this today?*

She said, “I just can’t afford to lose you, I want you.”

My heart skipped a few beats. My eyes welled up in shock. Was it a dream? No, it wasn’t! I pinched myself. Her apologies echoed in my mind and then happiness filled me as I heard her say again, “I need you, Aadi.” It assured me that something good was coming my way.

“Say something,” she said, later.

I was speechless with joy and nostalgia. I had missed her like hell. I had missed every moment we had shared.

“I am sorry too,” I said in a shaky voice. My hands trembled and my legs wobbled as I spoke.

“I can’t lose you as a friend,” she said.

It was definitely one of the best feelings to get everything back on track. Yes, Rutuja meant everything! Although it was just friendship that I was getting back, I was content with it. It was at least a chance to interact with her.

As the days passed, we began chatting like before. Normalcy returned slowly after the rough patch.

I was happy she was back. Though she kept saying, ‘we will be friends’ she didn’t behave like a friend. Nothing had changed—except that we did not end our conversations with ‘I love you’ or ‘baby’. Everything else remained the same. I was happy as it gave me the hope of a relationship with her again.

The only thing I feared was expressing my feelings to her. I couldn’t gather enough courage to propose to her again. It might just lead to another rift, I felt, as she kept saying we will be friends. I didn’t want to lose her as a friend but at the same time I wanted her back as my girlfriend. So, one day, I invited her out. A date might just help her recall the old days, I thought. I never made it sound like a date though. I was playing safe.

I insisted that we go to Barbeque Nation. With no prior booking, we just walked into the hotel. It was the hotel’s anniversary. The place was decorated with glitter and flowers. The musicians at one end struck the right chords on their guitar. The lady on the mic spread love with her melodious voice. Everyone danced to the music. Flowers and candles all over the place created a pleasing aura. The ambiance added to my happiness.

Rutuja wore a thigh-length blue lace dress. I found her irresistible in her eyeliner and lip gloss, and her brilliant smile. Her heels made a sound as she walked and all eyes were on her gorgeous legs.

We greeted each other. Unsure about whether we should hug each other, we just shook hands and I escorted her to a table amidst the singers.

I was enjoying every moment. It always seems ethereal to be with the person you love, especially after a fight.

“So?” she said, breaking the silence.

“Nothing . . . I still can’t believe we are here, after all that happened,” I said, feeling as if I was in a dream.

She smiled and replied, “You know what! Quarrels sometimes bring two people closer.”

Was that a hint?

Did it mean we could be in a relationship . . . again?

“You are right. My love for you has increased tremendously. I love you even more, Ru,” I said, holding her hand. Something in me just made me admit it.

My response made her blush, as if she was hearing it for the first time. She didn’t reply and changed the topic to chicken and starters, then to the music.

C’mon now! Don’t tell me that you were serious when you said we will remain friends, I thought to myself. I wished to hear her say ‘I love you too’ but she didn’t and instead, changed the topic to the mundane stuff.

She was probably teasing me with those tantrums. I could sense that she wasn’t over me and had the same feelings for me but I wondered why she was pretending to hide them.

“Eat less Aadi, look at your tummy,” she said, suddenly, out of the blue.

I was gaining a lot of weight, thanks to the tests and unending syllabus. Someone had to mention it to me.

“I and fat?” I asked confidently, as if I was the next Tom Cruise.

“Yeah! Why don’t you join a gym? I like muscular people. Get six packs,” she said with a wink, biting the straw and hardly sucking a drop of coke. It still made her look cute.

I don’t know why girls like teasing their boyfriends.

Hold on! I still considered myself as her boyfriend.

Yeah, so why do girls like teasing their boyfriends? They know that not all can be Salman Khan, but that does not stop them from expecting it.

“Me and gym! No way! I hate it,” I remarked.

Then, inspired, I added, “If you come along, I can probably think about working out.”

“No way! I know you very well, Mister doctor-to-be! You will just stalk me in the gym,” she winked.

After a pause, she added, “And I don’t need to work out, because I know I am hot!”

Now another girlish quality showing off!

No doubt that she was hot, but I didn’t want to acknowledge it for she had called me a fatso.

“You have a dirty mind!” I winked back and laughed at her thought.

“Now you are really getting dirty . . . well, I didn’t mean a workout on me,” she replied, laughing as if she had read my mind. I joined in and she blushed, her cheeks pink.

“Do I need permission?” I continued with my nonsense.

“Oh please! Aadi, not again!” she said and brought me back to reality. I was just a friend, she seemed to remind me.

“You’re pathetic!” she added with a bit of laughter, later.

•*Why is she confusing me?*

•*What am I to her?*

•*What exactly is our relationship now?*

•*Why is she teasing me when I am just her friend?*

•*Is it a hint?*

It was definitely a memorable evening after a long time. With romantic Hindi tracks playing, we were lost in each other. I kept looking into her eyes, while she sometimes rolled them and sometimes looked back into mine. I held her hand and she didn't mind. I played with them, forgetting that we had to finish our dinner. As I looked into her eyes, they seemed sexier than ever before. The black eyeliner was the cherry on the cake. Her silky hair, her pink lip gloss, and her earrings made her look hotter. I didn't say it though. It was for the first time I had been staring at her so deeply. Paying no heed to people around, all I could see was Rutuja.

“Stop it Aadi, kiti bagshil majhyakade? (How long are you going to stare at me?)” she said, munching three gulab jamuns in quick succession.

It was her favourite sweet and part of the buffet, which made her divert her appetite from the main course to only gulab jamuns. I hated them and she knew it. It gave her another reason to mock me. She fed me. Girls are just beyond comprehension. She found it fun. God only knew what made her happy! Maybe it was my resistance to gulab jamuns and then her deliberate insistence on feeding me.

She thanked me for making her day special as we paid the bill. Even though I didn't want to, she insisted on splitting the bill. We walked towards the parking area. It was time to go home but I was missing something. There was a long silence before I took a step. I went close to her and I hugged her. I had missed her a lot. It was a spontaneous reaction from me. She was taken aback by my sudden action. She didn't hug me back but she didn't move away either. I didn't let go. I hugged her tight. Moments later, I could see her lift her hands and hesitantly place them on my back. She ran them over my back and then curled them tightly and hugged me back. We stood like that for almost two minutes without saying a word. She rested her head on my shoulder. Neither of us wanted to let go of each other. I was emotional and my eyes filled with tears. I had always believed that I had lost her forever and now that I had her in my arms, I couldn't control my emotions.

“Never leave me and go,” I said, still embracing her and stroking her head with my hand.

“All I need is you, I love you more than I love myself. I know I was wrong, but I didn’t mean to hurt you. You make me complete; your love gives me strength. A day without you is difficult for me—I had to spend more than a month without you, always hoping that you will come back to me some day. Please come back. I love you. Please don’t leave me,” I continued and a drop of tear fell on her shoulder.

After a small pause, I continued, “Sorry for being possessive. It was only because I care for you more than you expected. I felt insecure. I never want to lose you. The fear is somewhere inside me. I trust you and all I want is you.”

“Hmmm . . .” was all she said and caressed my face. I could make out that she was about to cry. She controlled herself.

After another long silence, she said, smiling, “Chal mere Shahrukh, senti mat ho, ghar nahi jana? (My dear Sharukh, don’t get emotional, don’t you want to go home?)” It managed to bring a smile on my face.

She wiped off my tears and pecked my cheek. Tears didn’t suit me, but I couldn’t help it. Her eyes filled up too as she caressed my cheeks to soothe me. I smiled back, staring at her and getting more emotionally attached to her.

‘Kuch rishte anjane mein hi ho jate hain,

Pehle dil, fir zindagi se jud jaate hain,

Kehte hain uss dour ko pyaar,

Jisme log zindagi se bhi zyada pyaare ho jaate hain.’

Translation:

***Some relationships happen unknowingly,
First the heart and then your life, they connect,
People call this journey love,
Where people become more precious than your own life.***

After returning home, the moment when we had had the longest hug of our lives kept playing in my mind. Her touch was divine. Love was in the air. It was altogether a special feeling for me.

Overnight, songs became the backbone of my life. Correlating romantic songs to our relationship and singing them aloud, dancing like the worst dancer, forgetting the whole world, hardly paying any attention to what was happening around me, and texting only one person, was what I did.

I maintained my diary regularly. I had written a beautiful quote after the moment we had shared. It made me understand the definition of love and real emotions, when two lovers hug each other.

***‘A girl’s head is always down because she considers her
boy to be her world and gets lost in it.***

•
•
•

.

***While a boy's head is always up so that no other guy
dares to look at his girl!'***

For the next couple of days, we met each other in the college and studied together as our board exams were only weeks away. The same guys who had gathered around in the college when I had tried convincing her were now speechless.

Each day after college, I taught her something and she in turn would mock me with 'did-not-understand-a-word' kind of a face. Teaching her something always helped me brush up the concepts.

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A couple of days passed and it was the 7th of February—Rose Day. I was confused over whether to gift her roses or not. Above all—should they be red or yellow? Was she merely a friend or my girlfriend? Bewildered, I decided to play it safe. I texted her.

‘Suppose there are 100 red roses in this world, I will still be able to give you only 99 . . . because one is busy reading this message. Happy Rose Day.’

I got an instant reply,

‘Oh . . . then I want those 99 from you today so that I can own all 100.’

That said it all. She had given me the green signal. I could get my girlfriend back. I decided to propose to her again. I was confident. My instincts told me that she too had feelings for me. Cooking up something, I asked her to meet me in the college. She made excuses. The fear of exams approaching in a week kept her from leaving the house. Above all, we had our Biology practicals the next day. In spite of all the exam tension, I kept insisting and finally she had to give in.

As decided, I was going to meet Rutuja at college. I would have preferred somewhere else, considering the significance of the day, but the exams ahead didn’t allow us to waste time. With the usual traffic and the noise on the streets of Pune, it took me some time to reach our college. She was sitting in one of the lecture rooms, busy completing her journal.

Why did she have to bring the journal along? I thought.

She was unaware that I was watching her and I thought she looked cuter than ever. Without a care in the world, she was engrossed in her journal. She didn't even look around. Her loose hair covered her right eye and she kept trying to tuck it behind her ear. It was then that I walked to her and sat next to her. She noticed me and remarked, "Hey when did you come?"

"Just now. You were so busy that you didn't even notice me!" I replied.

"Just completing my journals," she grinned, "Why did you want to meet me, all of a sudden?"

Oh! How girls will be girls! As if she didn't know what the day was all about, especially with all the texting that morning. She pretended as if it was a normal meeting, as if she had no clue what I was up to. That made me want to keep things hidden and test her patience. Each time she asked me questions like 'Why are we meeting today? Why are we wasting time and not studying?' I would smile and say, "I felt like meeting you and so I called you here. Don't you feel the same way?"

She would then smile back and silence would prevail. Sitting together, we discussed the approaching exams. Each time she bent a little forward and let her hair fall close to my face, the fragrance of her hair pleased my senses. Her hair was a little damp and I wondered if she had shampooed with L'Oreal. I could no longer control myself and fidgeted with her hair. She interrupted saying, "Aadi, let's get going. Exams are approaching, I am very nervous."

She got up to leave and began packing her bag. After she was done, I pulled her to the next room, which was empty and gave me the privacy I wanted. She kept asking, "Where are we going . . . hey . . . why?" until we reached the room.

"I have something for you," I said and her eyes gleamed in excitement. Silence surrounded us and she looked into my eyes. I put my bag on the floor and held her with one hand. By then I had managed to grab the roses from my bag with my other hand. The ribbon held the roses together. I took one out.

“This one is for you,” I said.

Her eyes shone and she started saying, “Thank you”, but I took another red rose from the bouquet and said, “This one is for your sexy eyes, which make me go crazy every time I see them.”

Then I took the third rose and dedicated it to her cheeks, pulling them with my fingers. She blushed and her cheeks turned pink. Taking out the fourth rose, I said, “This one is for your luscious lips. I just love them.”

She accepted the rose and her eyes welled up in joy. I immediately kissed her lips. “I just love them,” I repeated.

The next rose was for our friendship. Each rose had a significance of its own. She was overjoyed by all this. It was unscripted and spontaneous—the real art of love.

Gifting her eleven roses, I was about to say ‘I love you’ but before I could say the words, she hugged me tightly and said, “Thank you Aadi. Till date I have never felt so special or so delighted. You make me feel my importance in your life and fall for you even more. I definitely know what you mean to say.”

There was a small silence. Our eyes met and silence once again prevailed. She continued, “I am always yours; I love you.”

That was all I had been waiting for. Blissful, I felt like a king. She hugged me once again. It was tighter than the first one. I held her by her waist and she lifted her head to look at my face.

“I love you too,” I said and held her face. With my fingers gently running over her lips, love was in air. She held my hand as our foreheads touched. Our eyes closed and our heartbeats accelerated. We could feel each other’s warm breath. Soon, our lips touched erotically, sending currents down my spine. She opened her mouth and the kiss became passionate. I clutched her hand and she bit my lip.

“Ugh! That hurts,” I said, backing off.

“So, does your hand! It’s twice the size of mine,” she retaliated.

“Sorry,” I said, grinning and releasing her hand from mine.

The next few days, everything was balanced. We appeared for our practical exams in the morning and celebrated ‘chocolate’ and ‘teddy’ days in the evening. Definitely, it was a combination of both the brain and the heart. Brain for the exams and heart for the days we celebrated. For the first time both were in sync, working together without complaining about each other.

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14 February arrived. With exams lined up, we couldn't make a formal plan but we could definitely spare an hour for ourselves. Hence, we landed up at the Goodluck Cafe, one of the oldest and most renowned restaurants of Pune. 'Since 1935' it said, with pride. It was the ideal place to spend time. Frequented by the British during the pre-Independence era, the restaurant's history in itself was inspiring and thought-provoking.

We took a seat inside the cafe and ordered some snacks and coffee. We had come here directly after our practicals, and were quite exhausted.

"Aadi, I still fear for your life. The suicide attempt has left me shaken. Promise me, you will never even think about suicide, leave alone attempt it," she said, with fear written all over her face. She took a bite from her burger and looked at me, waiting for an answer.

"Ru, I promise, I won't. I am so sorry for what I did that day. I will never attempt suicide again, trust me!" I replied, emphatically.

"That's good. Love you," she said, kissing my hand.

I fed her some pizza, very well knowing she didn't like the seasonings over it. I did it on purpose remembering the day she had force-fed me gulab jamuns.

"Mmm . . . bas! (Enough!)" She exclaimed, refusing to eat more.

After an hour, we left. Her parents had restricted her from using her two-wheeler during the exams, considering the Pune traffic and her safety. I decided to drop her home in the black and yellow three-wheeler I hired every day—the auto rickshaw!

“I have news for you,” I said to her. She made a questioning face, suggesting that she was genuinely interested in it.

“I have started writing,” I said.

“Writing what?”

“I mean I am keeping a diary”

“What sort of a diary?”

“Here, take a look,” I said, and unzipping my bag, placed a black diary in front of her.

She opened it. The first page said The Aadi-Rutuja Diary, which delighted her. Her eyes said it all. She quickly turned the pages and went through a few of the initial poems and one-liners I had written. Her eyes welled up as she came across the rough days of our relationship.

“Go to the last page,” I said and she did so immediately.

There were a few photos there.

“Oh my God!” she exclaimed.

“The first time we went on a date,” I said pointing out the picture, followed by a few other photographs.

“The first time I taught one of my weakest students. I still remember, it was ‘Coordinate Compounds’,” I grinned, pointing to the next picture.

“Fuck you!” she punched me.

“That’s when we kissed for the first time,” I said, indicating a picture of us.

“The barbeque night!” I said pointing out another photograph.

“That’s so sweet and romantic,” she said. She was beaming.

“Look here,” I said later and clicked a selfie with her.

“What is this for?”

“It comes next in the diary,” I smiled.

“Aww,” she said and held my arm.

“Something more,” I said and taking my pen from my bag, I opened a fresh page and wrote:

‘14th Feb – I promise Rutuja that I will never attempt suicide, ever.’

“Thank you so much,” she added, “Why don’t you publish it?”

I was taken aback. “Who publishes a diary with one liners and pictures?”

“No, convert it into a novel.”

“I am not an author, it’s just a personal diary that only the two of us should read.”

“You should try converting it into a novel.”

“No, I can’t!”

“At least think about it,” she insisted.

“Now, you are giving me a déjà vu.”

“As in?”

“The same very feeling that I can write and I should, while we travel in the rickshaw once again. It has happened before,” I grinned.

“Whatever, just give it a thought.”

I was about to reply when she said, “Aadi, I’ll go from here. Bhaiya, ruko!” The rickshaw was just a few meters away from her place.

She still feared her parents. She got off the rickshaw. I paid the rickshaw driver and followed.

“Why are you getting off?” she questioned me.

“Shouldn’t we talk for while?” I asked her.

“Not here,” she said.

She led me away from the road into a small lane. We stopped under a tree.

I held her hand and bringing her closer to me, put my arm around her. Our foreheads met.

“I love you, Ru,” I said.

“Oh really! I didn’t know that!” she teased me and laughed.

“Not here, public place!” she said as I was about to place my lips on hers.

“Okay,” I said.

“It’s not over yet,” I added.

“What do you mean?”

“Wait a minute!” I exclaimed, as I opened my bag, once again. It had turned into a magic box, which came up with something new each time I put my hand inside it.

“This is for you,” I said handing her a box.

“What is it?” she asked me.

“Find out!” I replied.

“Wow! It’s so cute. Love you, Aadi!”

She happily hugged me closer.

“I really wanted a bracelet, you do know how to make me happy,” she continued.

She rested her head on my shoulder and I stroked her hair. She then held my face with her hands and kissed my lips.

“Public place, right, Ru?” I said, backing off.

“I don’t care now,” she winked and kissed me again.

“Okay now, I’ll stop or else you won’t be able to study when you get back home,” she said, with a naughty smile.

“You are cute!” she said, turning away from me.

“You’re going?” I asked her.

“Exams dear! Go and study! You don’t want to fail because of this, do you?” she replied, laughing.

I remained silent, smiling.

“Okay bye!” she said. She twirled around with the bracelet in her hand and smiled, looking at me. The perfect moment, I would have liked to capture. Turning on the mobile camera, I clicked a picture of her.

She walked away from me and I watched her until she reached her place.

It was more than a year since we had met and gotten into a relationship. I felt blessed to be with her.

The day we met—it was during the exams last year—flashed before my eyes. We had become friends, texted each other, come closer, and eventually started our relationship. It was not just a union of two hearts but also an amalgamation of individuals with different dreams, from different castes, ideologies, and pasts. We had had our good as well as bad times. We had spent quality time together, teased each other, laughed at the silliest jokes, fought with each other, broken up and now, were finally back together.

I had heard people say that after a rough patch in a relationship or even temporary arguments, love becomes stronger. I had started to experience it. Not only had our love for each other grown but we had also become more mature. A new promise had been added.

‘I will never commit suicide no matter what happens.’

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Finally, it was the day of the first board exam. English was our first paper and we really didn't have much to study.

I was happy with Rutuja when Varun called with bad news. "Hey Aadi, did you know, Nikhil is suffering from kidney damage and he can't appear for the exams. He is in hospital now."

The news came as a bolt from the blue and made my blood run cold. I hadn't been on talking terms with Nikhil since our fight and so, had no idea of what was happening with him. I told Varun to meet me in fifteen minutes and we decided to visit Nikhil at the hospital. For the moment, I forgot the past and all I wanted to do was see Nikhil.

As decided, we reached the hospital and hurried to Room 12 in the medicine department where Nikhil was admitted. Deep inside in my mind, I was battling with the discomfort of facing Nikhil after a long time. We entered the room to see Nikhil on the bed, staring at the ceiling. A saline bottle hung on the stand with the tube connected to the needle inserted in his hand. His face was pale and he looked weak. He heard us enter the room and his eyes turned towards us. Varun enquired about his health and the nurse said that he was fine. Some calcium oxalate kidney stones had been surgically removed. Varun had misinterpreted it to be kidney damage. I sighed, relieved that he wasn't suffering from kidney damage but kidney stones.

Varun took a couple of steps towards Nikhil, with me lagging behind.

In spite of his weakness, he managed to smile at us. I was fumbling to make conversation as I didn't know what to say. I wondered how should I react? I

pretended that everything was normal and just stood there with a smile on my face. Varun could sense my discomfort.

He initiated the conversation, followed by a long silence. Finally, I broke the silence to ask him, “How are you feeling, Nikhil?”

“I am fine, just a bit of surgical pain but that’s bearable,” he replied, smiling, as if he too held no grudges.

Guilt over slapping Nikhil made the situation weird for me. It was easier to fight but difficult to amend things later. The anger had faded long ago, but I still felt uncomfortable.

Gathering courage, I said, “Hey buddy, I am really sorry for whatever happened.”

He looked at me and with a soft smile said, “Chuck it, Aadi! I don’t even remember it any more. I am already over it. I suggest you too forget it.”

“I shouldn’t have slapped you,” I continued.

“Dude! I told you right? Just forget it. I understand. Now tell me, how is everything between Rutuja and you?”

“Everything is good. We’ve had our differences along the way,” I said recalling the day Nikhil had watched me run after her in the college. I added, “But we are back on track now. It feels good to have her in my life. I love her.”

“Happy for you,” he managed to say, trying to sit up. Varun helped him lean back on the cushions.

I sat beside him.

“Finally, we are back! You two dare not fight again,” Varun interrupted and we burst into laughter.

“Let me get rid of this bed and we will go party. It’s been more than a year!” Nikhil joined in.

“Definitely,” I cheered and Varun went on to say, “It’s the perfect moment for a group picture, what say?”

Varun jumped up from his seat, mobile phone in hand. We posed with Nikhil and snapped a selfie.

I, definitely, was going through the best days of my life. Rutuja was back with me and now Nikhil was back too. I felt on top of the world.

We hung around, cracking jokes and abused each other like we did in the old days.

“It definitely feels good. Nothing is as good as the three of us together,” Varun said, grabbing an apple from the table.

“I can bet on that,” I replied, to which the two of them nodded in agreement.

We chatted for almost an hour. Realising it was time for us to leave, Varun and I got up. It was a great disappointment that Nikhil would not appear for the boards and would have to write them in mid-October. He was disheartened.

We tried to boost his morale, saying, “Bro, it’s just six months. They will fly soon.”

We knew it was easier said than done, but the least we could do was encourage our friend.

The Board exams had begun. Physics followed English and then came Mathematics; Chemistry, and Biology in quick succession. Rutuja and I had the exam centre in our college with hardly a gap of ten students between our exam seat numbers. Shaila too was with us. She wished me luck before each exam and I, aware of the distance created between us, would just manage to wish her back, without further conversation.

I gave my best during the exams, often helping Rutuja with answers to some questions. Each day after the papers, she would thank me profusely

for helping her out. After all, our love story had started in the exam hall, so how could we not relive the same days again? After the exam, we would go home without wasting time to study for the next paper. We burnt the midnight oil, rather she burnt it more, as I preferred waking up early to prepare.

I remember when she had called me at 2.30 a.m. the night before the Physics paper. She was my alarm clock. She shouted at me for sleeping and not studying. With no choice and with her constant calls, sleep was out of the question. Thanks to her, I was forced to study, which proved beneficial at that time.

Not all papers were good for us, but we definitely had managed to reach the distinction mark in half the subjects and a little less in the rest. Varun had also fared well and so had Shaila.

Time flew quickly and we were done with all the papers. On the last day of the exams, everyone was happy. Not that I was a free bird like most of the others as I had my NEET exam on the 8th of May, which was just two months later, but I still joined them in celebrating. Rutuja wasn't appearing for the NEET exam and was all set to enjoy herself. She was jubilant that the exams were over and literally jumped with joy! She was dancing and screaming happily like a toddler.

Now that the exams were over, we spent time together, eating pani poori and dabeli from the tapri outside our college. Knowing I had my NEET exam and a couple of other medical entrance exams, she asked me to focus on them. She encouraged me. After talking for a while, we headed home.

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Tuitions, tuitions, tests and more tests—I was flooded with them. From one tuition to another, I appeared for at least three to four tests every day. When I got home, I either prepared for the next test or revised whatever I was weak at. I had a crash course in my tuitions, which drove me crazy on a daily basis. With no time to think about the rest of the world and being busy with studies, I still managed to find time for Rutuja. Not that we met each other, but we did talk on the phone.

When it comes to medical college, one has to appear for a number of entrance exams before being placed in a college. I had a double dozen in my kitty. As if revising for the exams wasn't enough, I had to even keep a record of my exam seat number, exam date and exam centre to avoid missing out on an exam. My first exam was Wardha-CET.

I was disappointed that I could hardly meet Rutuja. Over the last one and a half months, our phone calls had reduced drastically. I missed her but with back-to-back exams and tuitions, which lasted for ten hours at a stretch, my schedule was busy. The strange thing was that she didn't even think of calling me. Not that she didn't send me a 'best of luck' message before exams, but that was it. She was difficult to understand. She had her mood swings. Some days, she would talk for hours together while there were days when she wouldn't even text me. I continued to focus on my studies. I knew the NEET exam was of utmost importance to me. My parents would keep calling me to encourage me and boost my spirits. During one of the calls, they had told me they were soon returning to India. It would take them a month to wind up their work in London but the preparations had begun.

One day, after a tiring afternoon and after revising a few chapters from Biology, I received a call from Rutuja.

“Hey, what’s up? Seems like you have forgotten me,” she said.

“No, not at all, just so busy with the exams. I’ve called you many times, but you hardly respond.”

She had an excuse as usual.

We then chatted for a while before hanging up. Before ending the call, she said, “Miss you Aadi, love you,” which rejuvenated me and motivated me to keep studying.

29 APRIL 2014

After appearing for my Manipal entrance exam, I reached home. I was tired but I had to study for the mega exam—the most important one being on 8th May. With barely ten days left, I was apprehensive. The tension was mounting, and I kept studying.

I had appeared for almost ten exams in quick succession, but still wasn’t confident enough for the NEET exam. Starting with Physics, I shifted to Chemistry and ended with Biology that day. It was around 4.30 p.m. when I felt like I really needed a break. I called Rutuja.

“Hello,” I said.

“Hi, how are you?” she asked, delighted.

“I am good, you tell me, how are you?”

“I am good too, hanging out with Anuja in a little while. Was pretty bored so . . .”

I was bored too, but didn’t suggest meeting as she already had plans. After talking for a while, I hung up. I later called Varun and we decided to spend some time together. He too was going to appear for the NEET exam.

In the next fifteen minutes, he came home to pick me up. We rode without a destination in mind. We looked for a place to intoxicate ourselves with coffee and stimulate our brain cells. We had limited time on hand before we could get back home to resume studying. So, we decided to go to Café Coffee Day and were there in the next ten minutes.

“Grab a table, I’ll park the vehicle and come in a minute,” said Varun, dropping me at the entrance.

I nodded and asked him to hurry up. I entered the café and searched for a table and soon found one. It was quite crowded.

I think everyone is fed up with medical entrance exams, I thought.

Placing my mobile on the table, I looked around. I browsed the menu and then looked at the entrance. Varun was still not there. I checked my mobile and then randomly looked around the café again. Diagonally opposite me was a couple. The boy hugged the girl and kissed her cheeks. I couldn’t see the girl as her back was towards me. Then the guy got up and sat next to the girl, putting his arm around her shoulder. He kissed her again.

Rutuja, I miss you, I said to myself.

I kept staring at the couple. As my eyes fell upon the girl’s hair, my heart skipped a beat. I sensed a lump in my throat. I couldn’t see her face but I could make out that it was none other than Rutuja. My heartbeats rose. The guy held her hand in his and kissed them. My eyes practically popped out of my head. Feeling restless, I got up from my seat. I didn’t know what to do next—I prayed it wasn’t her. I dialled her number and what happened next was a rude shock. I could hear her mobile buzz, as I kept an eye on the girl. She looked at her mobile and disconnected it. The same moment, the call got disconnected at my end. My hands turned numb and my body started shivering. Sweat rolled down my forehead. My mobile began to slip from my hand. I called her again and this time she answered.

“I am out with Anuja, talk to you later, bye,” she said.

It was her! My legs trembled and it felt as if my entire world sank before my eyes. I could no longer stand and sat on the chair in a state of shock. As the girl turned left to kiss the guy's lips, I could see it was Rutuja. The reverberation it created left me staggered. If the heart was made of glass, it had already shattered into pieces. I couldn't believe what was happening. Feeling completely lost after what I had just seen, the mental trauma was chipping off my head from inside. After about a minute or so, I managed to get up and started walking towards the couple on shaky legs. I had almost traversed half the distance when I sensed a hand on my shoulder. It was Varun.

"Where are you going?" he asked me.

I looked at him and without replying, looked at the couple. Varun saw them too and his mouth fell open in shock.

Almost in tears, I was confused over what to do. Varun recovered first and dragged me out of CCD. Lost in my own thoughts I don't remember how I managed to walk out.

"Did you see that . . . Varun . . . that was Rutuja, probably with Ajinkya," I stammered multiple times. My face turned pale and tears were flowing down the ridge of my nose.

"Yeah, I know, he must be her friend," Varun replied, even though he knew the reality was something else.

"But it doesn't seem so! Didn't you see how . . . he held her hand . . . and kissed her . . . he is obviously more than that," I said, with fear in my voice.

"Dude, stay calm, even if he is Ajinkya or someone else, it doesn't matter. She will always be yours," he sounded stupid.

He continued, "Yaad hain na kayinat bhi hum hai, aur zarria bhi hum hi hai, itnoko bhagaya hain, toh yeh kis khet ki muli hai."

He said it in a filmy tone, hoping it would bring a smile on my face and cheer me up, but it didn't work.

He was shocked too, but tried to be calm, making light of the situation. His attitude was suggestive of everything being in our control.

“Let’s have some juice there,” he suggested.

“No, I don’t want to,” I replied miserably.

He kept insisting and changed plans from juice to a milkshake to a pastry. He even suggested coconut water and a banana. Finally, he offered me a burger and a bottle of Coke. I unwrapped the burger and took a bite, still in agony. He tried changing the topic to movies and Goa plans after the exams. I was deeply hurt; I just couldn’t stop her thoughts from invading my mind.

“Let’s go back home,” I said, abruptly. I wanted to be left alone. The pain inside me was erupting. I wanted to cry loudly and bang my head somewhere.

Varun kept talking all the way home but I hardly paid attention. I remained silent.

“Take care and chill. I’ve already told you . . . we will handle that guy and nothing will happen to your relationship. You just cheer up and study properly. Don’t let all this affect your exam. We will see to it after exams,” he said as I got off his bike.

“Yeah, lets’ see, chal bye,” I replied waving and walking away from him.

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Reaching home, I immediately went to my room, ignoring my sister. Furious and wounded, I locked myself in my room and landed on the bed. I looked up at the ceiling. I couldn't believe what I had just seen. Tears then rolled down my cheeks. I was agitated.

After almost an hour, restless for answers, I called up Rutuja.

"Hey," she said.

"Hi," I said.

"Where are you?" I asked.

"Just reached home."

There was dead silence. She said something but I didn't answer.

"Hello, are you there?" she went on.

"Yes," I said, mentally absent.

"Do you love me?" I came straight to the point.

"Yeah! But why are you asking, all of a sudden?" she asked sweetly.

"Thought so—but maybe you changed your decision."

----- (Silence) -----

"Will you ever betray me? What would you do if you had to choose between me and some other guy?" I asked in a brittle voice.

----- (Silence) -----

“Why are you suddenly asking such questions? Are you drunk or something?” she enquired, sounding puzzled.

“I was probably drunk all these days,” I said gruffly.

“If you love someone else, it’s better to admit it than betray someone,” I continued again.

----- (Silence) -----

“Stop it!” she said.

“How about you dating Nikhil from tomorrow or how about Varun or your Ajinkya? Or someone else?”

----- (Silence) -----

“Say you don’t love me. The truth is all your promises were fake, you never cared about me; you never loved me. You just pretended,” I burst out in anger, “You avoided my calls and hurt me. I loved you, but you didn’t respect that either. You are fake, your love was fake. It would have been better if you had left me forever instead of coming back to me. I was blinded by my love for you.” I shouted at her and let out the agony, “Say you don’t love me!”

“Yeah, I don’t love you,” she said in a grating voice, “What do you think of yourself? You accuse me of whatever you think and I’ll still say I love you? Get lost!”

“Then how about saying, I love you, Ajinkya! Hold his hand, hug him, kiss him,” I broke down, “Bloody fuck him! Fuck yourself!”

----- (Silence) -----

“At least admit it now!” I thundered.

----- (Silence) -----

“Okay, fine, I love Ajinkya. I always have.”

“Was I a fucking toy for you?” I cut her down mid-sentence.

She said, “Calm down first and stop abusing me.”

“What should I do? Bloody celebrate that my girlfriend is dating someone else?” I cried over the phone.

The silence as usual prevailed before she went on to say, “Listen Aadi, my feelings for him are not recent . . . I have always had feelings for him even though you and I were together. It is not in my control. I liked you too, but then I felt like shifting back to him.”

----- (Silence at my end) -----

She had used the word ‘shifting’

- Was it a business trade for her? Was it just like transferring from one place to other? I thought. She made it sound so casual. She made me feel worthless.

“Why did you even approach me?” I asked her.

“I said it was not in my control. I don’t say that I don’t love you. It’s just that . . .” she stopped.

“Just what?” I asked.

“You won’t understand” she said.

“I fucking understand everything,” I shouted, “Answer me, you *****!” I abused her with a word I probably shouldn’t have used. It just came out.

“Fuck off Mr. Aditya,” she said and I banged the mobile on the mirror in front of me. The mirror now shattered to pieces just like my shattered heart. Anger took over and I shouted at the top of my voice and let out all the pain.

“What happened bhaiya?” my sister came running, hearing the loud sound of glass breaking.

“Nothing. Just stay out of it,” I let out my anger for the second time and slammed the door in her face.

Was it this easy for her?

How could she say it?

I fell back on my bed. The tears wouldn't stop. I broke down loud. I cursed fate. I cursed myself.

•*How could she do this to me?*

•*If she didn't love me, why did she ever say she loved me? Why?*

•*How could she forget me and never see my love for her?*

•*If she had always loved Ajinkya, didn't she betray him too, by accepting me and spending time with me with fake love?*

•*Was this her idea of true love?*

I cried my heart out. I silently screamed. For the first time, I prayed as well as cursed God. I prayed for relieving me of the pain and cursed for having given me the pain. Was this the end of everything? Was this how I had to suffer for loving someone selflessly?

I checked my Facebook account and could no more find her Facebook profile. She had blocked me. Same with my WhatsApp number. It made me cry even more. I banged my head on the door closest to me. I then hid my face between my pillows and kept on crying. Life had become complicated. My chest hurt in anguish and the more I cried, the more breathless I felt. It

felt as though my life had come to a sudden standstill. In fact, life had ended for me.

What should I do now?

What can I do? The answer to my own question was: Nothing.

I was helpless. The happy memories of our relationship flashed in front of me and made me cry.

•*Whom should I tell?*

•*How could you do this to me? How, Rutuja?*

The moment I opened my mobile gallery, our pictures stared back at me, bringing back the tears. I would look at her photos every day and cry, hoping she could sense the agony I was going through. In her photos, her eyes depicted innocence but the present would overshadow it. Studying for the exam was becoming difficult but then my parents' faces would flash in front of my eyes, urging me to study.

On the 5th of May, I received a call from Nikhil.

“Hi, how are you, Aadi? Varun told me . . .” he said and fell short of words.

Nikhil had been discharged from the hospital almost a fortnight ago.

“It’s all over Nikhil! All my dreams, my emotions are shattered to pieces. I am completely lost in agony.” I said.

“Nothing’s over mate! Concentrate on your studies first. Achieve your academic goals first. Get admission into a medical college and trust me everything will change for the better. I know you love her and we will try our best to get her back, but only after you have excelled in the exams. Please concentrate on your studies. I know it is easier said than done, but

you just have to. Don't think of her. Flush her out of your mind, if not forever at least for the next three or four days. Your success in the exams is the real success for us. You've worked hard for it for the past two years. Don't let her be the cause of your failure. Focus!"

Nikhil did his best to motivate me.

"Yes, definitely, I will," I said. We talked for a little while longer.

I was fortunate to have a friend like Nikhil. For the first time, I felt and valued his importance in my life. I did get a little boost, but it was short-lived. Every now and then, I'd think of her. I tried my best to keep these thoughts away. I switched off my mobile after deleting her messages. These were the hardest days of my life. Somehow, I still managed to study.

At night, I cried. I woke up in the morning with swollen eyes and studied. Even though it was tough, I gave it my best. After all I had it in my genes—the son of an MPSC topper, Rank 2 in Maharashtra!

The D-day of my life finally arrived. As the sun rose on the 8th of May, I switched on the mobile and the first call I received was from my parents.

"You can do it, son," said my dad and then my mom too joined in.

"You seem to be low. What's wrong? Don't take tension beta, you have studied for two years," added my mom.

"Nothing, just a bit . . ." I bit my tongue mid-sentence.

"Bit what, child?"

"Nothing, leave it, got to revise one last time."

"Don't worry, you will excel. You won't let anyone down. We will be home soon," said my mom. It was her way of motivating me.

"I don't study for others. I don't care what our relatives expect out of me. I am what I am! I am fed up of the genes' thing," I was loud and clear, rather harsh, and stopped myself from using the 'F' word just in time. What I

really thought was I don't give a fuck for what our relatives expect out of me.

"I know Aditya! Don't get me wrong. We are proud of you and will always be. I won't take your time. Best of luck for the exam," said my mom.

"Thank you," I said and hung up.

Later, my uncle and aunt did the dahi-shakkar ritual—yogurt with sugar—before the exam and wishing me luck, my uncle dropped me at the exam centre. It would have made my day if Rutuja had messaged or called to wish me as she knew how important the exam was for me but she didn't bother. Carrying the burden of our breakup, I appeared for the exam. I answered as many questions as I could. I left out a few out of fear for the negative marking system. Our batch was the first to appear for the NEET exam. Unlike the earlier medical CET exam which comprised of two hundred questions based on the twelfth board textbooks and no negative marking, the NEET consisted of 180 questions with four marks for each correct question and minus five marks if the answer was incorrect. As if that wasn't enough, the exam syllabus included everything from the NCERT books of the eleventh and twelfth grade and not the Maharashtra board textbooks. The exam board had done its best to make it as tough as possible for us. Somehow, I managed to complete the paper.

After the exams, the first news that came out was that the government would be continuing with the old medical CET exam from the next year and this was the only batch that they had experimented with NEET.

So that's how my luck was!

After the paper, everyone was jubilant about now being free but I had no reason to rejoice. Varun sensed my pain and he felt sorry for me.

Later, on the 11th of May, I appeared for the BVP-CET exam—the last one on my list of entrance exams. Finally, I was done. On returning home, I felt lonely. Thoughts of Rutuja and our broken relationship had again started bothering me. It was 11 May 2014, 7.30 p.m. and I opened my diary. The one-liners and poems I had written, coupled with the unending pain

provoked me to open another diary. I picked up a pen and wrote the first few words of a story, which I had no intention of converting into a novel or publishing. It was something I was writing only for myself. It was my way of letting out the pain and probably seeking my revenge. “You wanted me to fucking write a story, right? Become an author? I’ll become one,” I wanted to yell at Rutuja. I wrote the words in bold italics and underlined them twice:

U n M e . . . I t ’ s C o m p l i c a t e d !

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At one end, the exams ended and at the other, my relationship with Rutuja. And with this, my happiness, joy, dreams, liveliness—almost everything came to an end. My tears wouldn't stop. Eyes swollen, I would lie upon my bed all day. Varun and Nikhil invited me out for dinners and movies but I refused to go and eventually, they let me be. I had decided to cover myself with the blanket of gloominess.

Why was I crying for a girl who had betrayed me? Ditched me?

I had no answers. The human heart is weird. It values the person who doesn't value it. I wanted to get out of the pain and flush Rutuja out of my mind, but I couldn't.

Why did you do this to me? Why only me? I shouted, crying at the same time, and addressing the Almighty.

Please somebody help me. Please get me out of this! I would continue crying.

I tried calling Rutuja many times and my calls either went unanswered or were rejected.

- *What was my fault?*
- *Was loving her my biggest mistake?*
- *Why can't I stop crying?*

She has betrayed you, she has just pretended to love you, faking everything. Why do you want someone like that in your life? Don't waste your tears on her, she isn't worth it, my mind would say.

I hardly ate. It was affecting my health, making me weak.

To distract my mind, I had started reading books, but that didn't continue for long. I would go out for a walk all by myself, hoping it would bring a change. Physically, I went everywhere but mentally I was absent. Listening to songs made me cry even more. One of my favourite songs then, sung by Atif Aslam, shattered what was left of me into pieces.

'Teri yaadein . . . mulakatein,

Main kaise bhoolun, chahat ki woh barsatein

Teri yaadein . . . mulakatein,

Mai kaise bhoolun, chahat ki woh barsatein . . .

Tu hi mera dil hai,

Tu hi meri jaan.

Tu hi mera dil hai,

Tu hi meri jaan.

Kabhi toh pas mere aao,

Kabhi toh nazrein mujhse milao,

Kabhi toh dil se dil ko milao . . . ohh jana!

Meri jaan palkein yuh na jhukana,

Meri jaan mujhse dur na jaana,

Meri jaan mujhko bhool na jaana . . . ohh jana!’

Translation:

Your memories . . . our meetings!

How can I forget those showers of love . . .

Your memories . . . our meetings!

How can I forget those showers of love . . .

You are my heart and you are my life

You are my heart and you are my life

Someday do come back to me,

Someday do meet your eyes with me,

Someday let the heart connect to the heart . . . my love!

My life, do not lower your eyes,

My life, do not go away from me,

My life, do not forget me. . . my love!

The places where we had once hugged each other, and held hands, and looked into each other’s eyes, were all the same. What had changed were the couples sitting there. What I prayed for at the moment was these lines from the song.

‘Mujhe lauta de woh mera pyaar
Mujhe lauta de woh mera pyaar . . .’

Translation:

Give me back my love

Give me back my love.

I remembered the days when I made excuses to my family, sneaking out late at night just to meet Rutuja. On the pretext of lending a book or notes to each other, we would spend time under a tree or in some isolated place. That tree was still there—what had changed was there was no Aditya or Rutuja sitting under it. We had done silly things like checking each other’s palms for fate lines or drawing something on each other’s hands. Now, there was no hand left to hold or to draw on.

‘Main tera hi deewana hoon,
Teri baatein, kabhi main
bhool na paoon
Main tera hi deewana hoon,
Teri baatein, kabhi main
bhool na paoon . . .

Tu hi mera dil hai,

Tu hi meri jaan,

Tu hi mera dil hai,

Tu hi meri jaan . . .

Translation:

I am crazy about you,

I am unable to forget your words

I am crazy about you,

I am unable to forget your words

You are my heart

You are my life

You are my heart

You are my life.

I spent time writing my diary. This time it wasn't one-liners or poems. I switched to pages of prose. Each time I wrote what I was going through, I would turn a few pages back to relive the happy days we had spent together. Our small fights, our teasing each other, our smiles—every moment flashed before my eyes. The promises we had made in the park were now meaningless statements.

- 1)We won't stop loving each other - I continued, she stopped!
- 2)We won't betray each other - she did!
- 3)We will always be together - we aren't!
- 4)We won't let our love lives affect our studies - It did affect mine.

‘Ohh yaara, kyun khaafa ho mujhse,

Ohh yaara, kyun juda ho mujhse,

Ohh yaara, mera pyaar hai tujhse,

Ohh jaana . . .

Tere bin dillagi hai adhuri,

Tere bin aashiqui hai adhuri,

Mujhe milna hai tujhse zaruri,

Ohh jaana . . .

Mujhe lauta de woh mera pyaar,

Mujhe lauta de woh mera pyaar.’

Translation:

Oh beloved, why are you angry with me

Oh beloved, why are you away from me

Oh beloved, my love is for you . . . my love!

Without you my joy is incomplete

Without you romance is incomplete

I need to meet you . . . my love!

Give me back my love

Give me back my love.

Each and every day now dragged and felt like years. Without her, life became pointless. In spite of the pain she had caused me, I wanted her back in my life. I was ready to forget everything, but getting her back was difficult as I knew she didn't love me and she had faked it all. I wished I had never met her and there would have been . . .

- no need to impress her,
- no need to want her
- no need to love her
- no need to cry over her
- no need for pain or tears
- no need for forgotten promises
- no need for her to act as if she cared about me.
- no need for everything she had done to make me feel absolutely worthless.

It was with Varun that I first tasted alcohol. Soon, this was followed by cigarettes. I vomited at first, but with time, my body adjusted and wanted more. Even when intoxicated, I could not abuse Rutuja. I just couldn't. But the pain found its way out in the form of anger. I acted like a maniac. I would yell at people without reason, drink for hours together, break things, punch the walls with my fist, light up a cigarette at night, and stare at the dark sky. I was becoming self-destructive. Nikhil and Varun cursed her, but I couldn't utter a single word against her. All I did was shout and cry. My heart wept. I don't know if it's the memories that make you cry or the person's absence and the bitter truth that you won't be able to build any more memories with the person again.

***‘Aashiq wohi gaane dubara sunta hai aur unhi galiyon
mein bhataкта hai jahan kabhi kisi zamane
mein usne aashiqui ki hoti hai.’***

Translation:

***A lover listens to the same songs and roams in the same
lanes where once upon a time he had fallen in love.***

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8 JUNE 2014

More than a month had passed, but I was far from forgetting Rutuja. I had no interest left in anything and that depressed me. I didn't bother to shave or get a haircut, preferring to look unkempt. Depression, long hair and beards have always had an age-old, deep connection.

On 8th June, I woke up late just like any other day. I got on with my daily routine at a slow pace and dozed off again in the afternoon. Sleep helped a little, as it made me forget who I was and what I was going through.

5.00 p.m.: I woke up and spent time thinking of Rutuja, sang songs, and listened to some Hindi tracks.

6.00 p.m.: I called up Varun. He was out of station, writing the JIPMER exam. I asked him about his exam and he said

8.30 p.m.: I called Nikhil and our conversation went something like this.

Me: Is everyone forgetting me? No one calls me these days; I am all alone.

Nikhil: No dude, nothing like that. We thought we should give you some time to come out of your problem. Look

Me: Hmm . . .

Nikhil: Forget everything. Burn her as if she were a poster and nothing more. I didn't want this to happen—I had

I was not in a state to ponder upon what Nikhil was trying to tell me. It made no sense to me. He was probably right—but I was so blinded by love that all I could see and think about was, Rutuja is not with me.

Me: I don't believe in God anymore. If He had ever thought of me, He wouldn't have let me suffer like this. My life

I hung up after sometime. Nothing went into my mind in spite of Nikhil being philosophical.

10.00 p.m.: In pain and unable to resist the thought anymore, I decided to end my life. I thought of getting drunk and

*'Khwab adhure hi sahi,
Khwab tumhare toh hai,
Khwab jhutha hi sahi,
Khwab aapse jude toh hai,
Jaise taise khat rahi hai zindagi,
Tum hamare na sahi,
Hum tumhare toh hai.'*

Translation:

*Although my dreams are incomplete,
They still have you in them.
Although my dreams are fake,
They are still connected with your soul.
Dead inside, my days are somehow passing by.
Although you are not mine,
I am still yours!*



NIKHIL

6.00 p.m.: “Hey mom, can you make me some coffee?” I asked. Soon, mom brought me a cup of coffee.

I was watching a movie on my laptop. It had been a while since I had come home from the hospital. I felt a little depressed but had to somehow confront the bitter truth that I had to repeat the entire year to appear for the CET exam next year. I felt bad about being left behind, with my two besties Aadi and Varun moving ahead. I was happy for Varun, but I was worried about Aadi. His relationship problems with Rutuja might affect his exam results, I felt. He had always been good at studies. Even when he was in a relationship with Rutuja he had always managed to excel in all the exams. But ever since their breakup, he had lost it. Studies had taken a backseat and I feared it would affect his career.

I knew Aadi and Rutuja very well and if I had to sum up their relationship in one word, I would hold Rutuja guilty as charged. I am not being biased because Aadi is my friend, but I am sure he wasn't guilty of anything.

8.30 p.m.: I received a call from Aadi, just when I was about to enter my room. We talked for a while. He seemed to

He should never have gotten into a relationship, I said to myself.

I later emptied a pack of juice from the refrigerator into a glass and continued thinking. I wanted the old Aadi back. Varun and I were both missing him.

What must Aadi be doing now? Did he really agree with whatever I said and decide to take action? I wondered.

10.30 p.m.: I was distressed and had a sense of disquiet. I thought of calling him again and dialled his number, only

He is probably asleep, I thought.

Suddenly, I was filled with horror, recalling what Aadi had said last. ‘Varun and you are the only friends left in my life, and I’ll probably see this world from your eyes, henceforth.’

Henceforth? What did he mean, henceforth? I was shaken. I rose from my bed and dialled his number again. No response. My instincts were on high alert and I had a bad feeling. His obsession for Rutuja was boundless and a mad lover can be dangerous at times.

- What if he decides to harm her?
- What if he does something to Ajinkya?
- What if he harms himself?

I ran towards the entrance door. Hurriedly, I put on my shoes.

“Where are you going?” my mom asked after me.

“Going to Aadi’s place. Most probably I’ll be late . . . don’t worry, bye, mom!” I replied, already running towards my bike.

I rushed towards Aadi’s house. The tension was mounting in me. I could sense something wrong was about to happen.



11.00 p.m.: I reached Aadi’s house. I composed myself and rang the doorbell, remembering that I might have to face

“Hello Nikhil, how come you are here at this time?” Aadi’s aunt questioned me.

She invited me in. I took off my shoes.

“Is Aditya here, aunty?” I asked.

“Beta, he just left, saying that he was going to your place. Didn’t you see him?” she asked, worried.

“Oh . . . in that case, we probably missed each other! Don’t worry aunty, I’ll head back,” I said, with a fake smile. I was freaking out inside. Aunty tried calling Aadi and got the same automated response saying that the mobile was switched off.

“It’s switched off,” she said.

“His battery might have drained,” I said.

“Okay Nikhil, do let me know when you reach home. Ask him to call me,” she said, trying to hide the worry on her face.

I sought her permission to go into Aadi’s room with the excuse that I wanted some notes. I really wanted to check if he had left a note before he had gone.

“Sure,” she said and offered me a glass of water before I went to his room.

I checked for a note, but found none. I searched through all the drawers and cupboards. In one of his drawers, I came across a black diary and I opened it. U n Me . . . It’s Complicated! was written in bold letters. On the first page, the first line said, Aadi-Rutuja Diary. I realised that he had been writing a diary and this was just an extension of the first one or maybe a detailed book regarding his life.

So where was this diary?

Was he writing a novel?

Yes, the black diary was probably a novel.

I searched for the other diary but couldn’t find it anywhere.

I opened the one I had in my hand and quickly scrolled through a few pages. It was all about him. He had been writing in it almost every day. Though it was written in the format of a novel and would take me time to read everything, I got the gist of what he was saying. I turned a few pages without reading them and found Rutuja written on one of the pages. Probably from there on, the next half of the diary was all about his relationship. I was about to go through it, but Aadi’s aunt was back in the room and I hid the diary under my shirt.

She said in a shaky voice, “I tried calling Aditya again but it says the mobile is switched off.”

“I told you Aunty, his battery must be dead,” I replied, hiding my fear.

I walked out of the room, taking a few random papers, pretending that I had found the exam notes.

I hurried down to my bike and sat on it.

Where could Aadi have gone? I wondered.

He might have gone to Rutuja’s place, my thoughts continued.

Knowing where she stayed, I rode to her place. I was worried for him. I was worried for her as well. Love often makes people do crazy things. I soon reached. With the streetlights on vacation, it was all dark. I looked for her

house and finally found it. I peeped in but couldn't find Aadi anywhere near her house. As it was almost midnight, I didn't want to call and make things worse. I went back to my bike and sat on it, thinking.

Next, I called Varun.

"Hey when did you last talk to Aadi?" I asked him.

"Not recently. What happened?" he said and filled with disappointment, I explained everything to him.

"I'll try to reach out to him. Don't worry, he must be alright," said Varun, unaware of the intensity and depth of the situation. I tried calling Aadi and all I got was The number you are trying to reach is either switched off or is out of coverage area. Please try calling later.

Without the streetlights and with no sign of Aadi, I opened his diary and turned on the flashlight of my mobile. I went through the diary. I was not an avid reader. How could I finish my first ever novel in such an emergency? I quickly skimmed through the diary, hoping he might have left some clue in it. I skipped the first few pages and read some random pages. I read about his suicide attempt. It horrified me and I could feel a lump in my throat. I feared he might go that way again. I flipped to the last page and got the shocker of my life. Aditya had written a note about ending his life.

My hands started sweating, my heartbeats increased, and I began to think the worst.

•*What should I do?*

•*Where should I look for him?*

•*Is he alright?*

Finding no answers, I went from one location to another as fast as my bike could take me. I visited our college, then his tuition classes, and finally the various isolated places one can find in Pune, but there was still no sign of him. It was 1.00 a.m. and I felt helpless. My mom kept calling me and I told her that I was with Aadi at his place. When Aadi's aunt called me, I told her that he was at my place. She wanted to talk to him, but I told her he was asleep. Confusion prevailed everywhere. Varun called me to enquire if I had managed to find Aadi and I had to regretfully answer in the negative.

I then thought of heading back to his house as my instincts told me he might be somewhere close by. I went to the parking area and again wondered, where should I find him?

I received another call from Varun.

"Hey did you get him?" he asked me.

"No," I replied, worried.

"Where did you search for him?" he asked me in a tight voice.

"At his house . . . then at Rutuja's place . . . some nearby places . . . then our college . . . FC Road . . ."

"At Kamala Nehru Park?" he enquired.

"I did! And it's closed now," I replied, taking a deep breath.

"Where did this guy go then?" he remarked.

"How do I know?" I shouted, frustrated.

Silence followed. I wished and prayed to all the Gods I was familiar with.

“Did you check the building under construction, near his house?” Varun asked me from the other end.

“Which building?”

“There’s a building under construction nearby. Head towards Symbiosis College—it is the one to your right. I forgot to tell you that Aadi and I had been hanging out there lately to booze.”

“Are you crazy? How could you forget this?” I shouted and disconnected the call immediately

With hopes rising once again, I raced in the direction of the building. With no knowledge of where it was, I kept looking based on Varun’s description. Soon, I found it. Hurrying up, I entered the construction site.



ADITYA

It was 2.00 a.m. and I could see the moon shining in the dark, watching me. God! Who is He? People believe in God, worship Him, but there's no God in my life. I left Him long back; rather He left me when I needed Him the most.

I was drunk and several bottles down, but my body still craved more. The pain inside me just wouldn't subside. I had the original diary with me. Reading the Aadi-Rutuja Diary for the umpteenth time, I got up unsteadily. Stumbling a couple of times, I walked towards the end of the terrace. The sky was dark and the moon shone above me. Down below, the city lights twinkled. But my heart was filled with darkness. With a bottle of whisky in my hand, I took a step forward. I stood at the edge of the terrace. One step and I would fall off from the tenth floor. I looked down. I was here to end my life. I threw the bottle on the terrace and watched it smash into pieces. Before jumping off from the terrace, something made me switch on my mobile. I searched through the photo gallery. The first photo was of me with my uncle and aunt. I swiped left and the next was with my sister. I cared about her and loved her, but the situations life had created overshadowed everything now. Next came a few pictures with Rutuja and it aggravated the pain inside me. I swiped left to see a picture of Nikhil and Varun. I was leaving behind my friends. It hardly mattered now. I cared about nothing and no one at this point. I swiped again for the last time and this time it was a picture with my parents. Tears began flowing down my cheeks. I just couldn't say that I didn't care. I cried loudly. I was going away from my parents as well.

No, I can't give away my life. My parents won't be able to live with the agony, said a voice inside me.

Minutes later, I don't care. I am done with life, said the same inner voice.

With two minds, my feet were on the verge of taking another step. I spread my arms. I closed my eyes and took a deep breath, feeling the cool breeze on my face.

Sorry Dad! Sorry Mom! I said. Raising my foot, I was ready to jump off the terrace. That's when my mobile vibrated in my pocket. Had I not switched it on, the call wouldn't have reached me, I thought. The curiosity in me made me answer the last call of my life.

My eyes opened wide in the darkness—it was my mom.

“Hello Aadi,” she said, delightedly as I accepted the call and brought the mobile close to my ear. The tears started again at the sound of her voice.

“Hello mom,” I managed to say.

“Were you asleep?” she asked me, probably because of my voice.

“No,” I said.

“Anyway, we have landed in Mumbai!”

“What??

“Yes, wanted to surprise you. We will reach Pune soon.”

I was speechless. My tears were choking me, making it difficult for me to speak.

“Love you, beta. See you soon,” said my mom cheerfully and hung up.

For the first time, the ‘love you’ in her voice felt unique and special. It was selfless love, which only a mother can give her child. For the first time, I

thought, why was I giving away my life for a girl when there was a better person in my life to love me?

- *Is love only relevant to girlfriend, wife, or fiancé?*
- *Why is it that parents don't flash in front of one's mind when one thinks of suicide?*
- *Why is the person always blinded by the love he has for his girlfriend?*
- *My parents have the first right over me. Why am I placing so much value on a girl who entered into my life a short while ago?*

I stood at edge of the terrace. There was a thin line between life and death. One step forward and it was death while one step backward and it was life. In two minds, I teetered between life and death.

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NIKHIL

I stepped off my bike and rushed to find the stairs. Soon, I came across one without side railings. Debris and building material cluttered the place. Without lights it was difficult for me to navigate the under-construction site. A couple of dim bulbs gave the site a haunted look. I switched on the flashlight on my mobile and increased my pace. On reaching the seventh floor, I called out, “Aditya . . . are you there? Can you hear me?” I got no response.

I kept climbing and soon reached the terrace. There was hardly any light here. All I could see was another bulb at the other end of the terrace. I rushed, stepping over the construction material, stumbling. I could make out somebody standing at the end of the terrace. As I drew closer, the shadow grew in size. He sat with his face between his knees and his hands around his head. Yes, it was Aadi.

“Aadi!” I called out to him a couple of times but he didn’t respond. Petrified, I placed my hand on his shoulder and he slowly raised his head.

“Why are you here?” I asked him.

I lifted him up but he still didn’t respond. I shook him a little and found that he was drunk. I noticed the couple of empty whisky bottles and a few packs of cigarettes lying around.

“Aadi, what are you doing here? I am talking to you,” I raised my voice.

“Everything’s over, Nikhil!” he said in a hard voice and then burst into tears.

I placed my hand on his shoulder again and said, “Nothing’s over, Aadi, what are you saying?”

“She left me! I don’t want to live now. Everything is over. I want to . . . but . . .” he took a deep breath and continued, “But . . . I can’t.”

“She wasn’t worth your love, Aadi. Why can’t you understand?” I gripped his shoulder tightly and shook him, “I told you, forget her. She isn’t worth your tears.” I snatched the bottle of alcohol from his hand.

“Everything will be alright. I know you loved her, but this is not the way out. Were you here to end your life?” I continued.

He didn’t reply. I was furious.

“Great! Well done, Aadi! You know, you are nothing but a coward. C’mon go ahead! Jump from here, go! Let me see, how you end your life,” I shouted. I spotted another diary lying on the ground, with Aadi-Rutuja Diary written on it. I added, “Maintaining a diary and reading it every day is not going to help you. Throw it away! You are giving yourself nothing but pain. Face it! She left you, she was wrong, but suicide is not the way out. Why are you giving her so much more importance, even more than your life? She is just not worth it. Do you feel that your action will change things or make a difference to her? No dude, she does not care! If at all there had to be a change, it would have happened when you had attempted suicide for the first time.”

My words stunned him. He stared at me with eyes filled with grief. He was probably undecided.

“The people who truly care for you are your parents, your uncle and aunt, your sister, your friends—did you even stop to think of them? This girl came into your life just a couple of years ago and you care for her so much! What about your family who have been with you all your life? Do you even care about them?” I burst out, raising my voice once again.

“But then she hurt me and broke all her promises, was that right?” he questioned me.

“I said, what she did was not right. You loved her, but she didn’t care and she is never going to. She just wasn’t your type. You can’t change the past and neither can you change her nature. And you cannot change yourself either! All you can do now is forget her with time. Think of her as just a bad experience and move on in life,” I replied.

I looked into his eyes and he seemed to listen to whatever I said. I made him sit on the floor and I sat next to him.

“Alcohol and smoking, committing suicide are totally the wrong ways out. Lead your own life. Don’t be dependent on others and waste it. Just for a moment think about this. If things were the other way round, would she have attempted suicide? The answer is ‘no’. She doesn’t even care. She is happy at this moment. She is playing with you and you are no football! If the guilty have no guilt, there’s no need for you to cry over it, and waste your energy and time. Coming to promises, even if she broke all of them, you are breaking one today. You had promised her that you wouldn’t attempt suicide in your life. I read it in your diary. If you love her, you shouldn’t be breaking your promise.”

It made him re-think. He muttered, “I was going to attempt suicide but . . .”

“But what?”

“Mom called me. My parents have landed in Mumbai and they will be here in Pune by morning,” he broke down, “And . . . and . . . I can’t welcome them with my dead body. It will destroy them. And I love them.”

He stood up and I kept staring him as he paced the floor. I sighed with relief as he was no longer thinking of dying. That was more than enough for me. After a while, he said, “It’s difficult, but I will definitely try to get out of it. No more Rutuja now!”

I had been waiting for this.

“That’s the spirit! Woo hoo!” I gave him a high-five. I hugged him tightly.

“Thanks Nikhil, for always being there,” he said.

“Dude. I am always there for you, and I know you are a tough guy and that you will definitely win this battle against yourself,” I continued, with positivity.

“Man has the power to control his thoughts. You can accomplish whatever you wish to—all you need is keep your sights on your dream and think positive, and good things will always happen,” I added.

“Oye! Astha channel ke Maharaj, bas ho gaya! I understood everything. Apna gyan dena band kar . . .” he laughed. Finally, I had my old friend back. I hugged him again. It was wonderful to see him smiling and laughing after months.

Moments later, my phone buzzed. I had a couple of missed calls from Varun. This was his fifth call.

Varun: Hey did you find Aadi?

Me: Yes, he is with me, safe and sound.

Varun: Abey b*****! Who will tell me? Couldn't you call me?

Me: Sorry, I am sorry. He is fine now. You come back to Pune and then we all will party together.

Varun: Let me talk to him!

Me: Calm down! He is fine now. Speak to him once you are back.

I hung up. Aadi was still looking at my face.

“Aunty is worried, let’s go home,” I said and together we set off.



ADITYA

Sunrise was different the next day. The heavy burden of pain decreased with time. I was prepared to forget Rutuja and close the chapters of our relationship forever. It was going to take time but I was ready for it.

My parents arrived from Mumbai. I rushed to hug them as soon as I saw them. I needed them the most now. Finally, they were back in India. We went out for dinner and it cheered me up.

Once, when I rested my head on my mom's lap, I broke down.

"Mom, I am sorry," I said.

"What happened?" she asked me, caressing my hair with love.

"I was about to . . ." I stopped myself.

"What happened? Say beta."

"Nothing just missed you a lot," I said and let the tears flow. I didn't want to worry her with what I had been about to do. I let it be a mystery hidden in my diary.

Over the days, I learned there is no eternal love like the one your parents shower upon you. I continued writing my story in the form of a novel. However, I still had no intention to publish it.

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ONE MONTH LATER. . .

Life was getting back to normal slowly. The results were out and the admission procedures began. Getting admission in one of the finest medical colleges of India was a new beginning for me—a new life. This time, when I entered the college, I no longer looked like an IT personality like my first day at junior college. It was not just the beginning of a new phase in my life but also a time to make new friends. I could definitely write another book on this!

One day, I was attending the Physiology lecture. Everything seemed to be going my way until God decided to test me again. I received a message from Rutuja! Her name on the screen sent shivers down my spine.

Why is she messaging me?

What could be the message?

Should I open it?

Restless and curious, I opened the message to find, ‘Congratulations Aadi! I came to know that you’ve managed to join a medical college. All the best for your future!’

The past once again flashed in front of my eyes. The message disturbed me. I wish I had deleted the message without reading it. The unanswered questions of our relationship still haunted me. Agitated, I could no longer focus on the lecture.

I still remember telling my friend, Tappi, “Proxy laga meri (be my proxy),” before leaving. She had agreed, smiling.

‘I want to meet you,’ I texted Rutuja.

‘In fifteen minutes near my house,’ she replied.

Why did I want to meet her?

Why was I still restless?

Was it so important to get my answers?

Couldn't I have ignored her message and blocked her?

I drove my new car that my parents had gifted me. Expertly navigating the Pune traffic, I reached her place well before time.

I could see her on her two-wheeler with her scarf covering her mouth. I could recognise her even then.

“Hi,” she smiled, taking off the scarf.

“Hello,” I said and there was silence.

“New car?” she asked me.

“Yes,” I said. More silence followed.

“Congratulations for both—your admission and the car!”

“Thank you,” I was still tight-lipped.

“So?” she said, after a while.

“Nothing,” I replied.

“Okay, I have to go,” she added and was about to leave, when she found me standing in her way.

“You can’t always just leave.” My eyes were red with fury.

“Huh?”

“How can you always walk all over my heart and just leave?” I tightened my grip on her arms.

“You are hurting me,” she cried.

“Nothing compared to how you hurt me all the time.” I held her face. There was hardly any distance between our faces.

“People are watching us,” she said.

“Fuck the people,” I shouted.

“Listen Aadi, let me go, please!” she said.

“It’s over between us,” she added.

The word ‘over’ unhealed the scar.

“You just can’t walk away from my life every time.”

“Stop it, Aadi!” she said.

“Why did you message me again? I was over you! You cannot keep playing with me,” I shouted.

“I didn’t call you here,” she said, in fear.

“But why did you initiate a conversation? Why can’t you let go of me?” I shouted.

Tears poured down my cheeks. I didn’t care about people staring at us.

Hands joined before her, I pleaded in a low voice, “Please leave me! Please stop invading my mind. Please let go of me. Please release me from this prison.”

My voice cracked with tears and my grip over her arms loosened. Looking into her eyes, I cried, “Block me forever. I can’t get back to you. You cannot come back into my life. I know you might not want to get back into my life, but I cannot see you with someone else. Please release me from this pain. Please don’t message me, please don’t contact me, block me from all sites and go away forever.”

Her eyes welled up on seeing me. She said, “I am sorry. Best of luck for your future.” Before turning back to her two-wheeler, she handed me three letters.

“What is this?”

“Read these. Hopefully you will have the answers to your questions, bye.” She left without turning back. I watched her go. This probably ended our story. Taking the letters, I drove back home.

Reaching home, I went straight to my room. I drank an entire bottle of water and then, splashed cold water on my face. Wiping my face with a towel, I sat on the bed. After some time, I opened the first letter and read it, followed by the second. Seeking answers to the confusion and complication in our relationship, I finally opened the third letter.

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RUTUJA – LETTER THREE!

There was a time when she was attracted to him. She had had boyfriends in the past. Still, each time she fell in love, it was unique in its own way. Later she understood it was not love but attraction. Before falling for Aditya, she had been dating Ajinkya. In Ajinkya's case it had been true love for her. Everything had been sailing well until he had dumped her for someone else. She became dejected and agitated, and wanted to take revenge. She wanted a new boyfriend to make him jealous. Aditya was the key to making Ajinkya jealous but she had not really expected to fall for Aditya.

On New Year's Eve her past came back to haunt the present. She had never expected him to be back. She had never wanted to set eyes on him again but destiny had something else written for her. He pleaded with her, eyes full of tears. He apologised for hours together. Firm over her decision, she was not going back to him. But he kept calling her daily and kept saying he was sorry. How could she accept him? She couldn't ditch Aditya. But who could define love? If someone had, there would have been no problems in the first place.

She decided to distance herself from Aditya. After all, wasn't her primary aim to use Aditya to make Ajinkya jealous? So, how did it matter now? Ajinkya proposed to her again and she accepted him but never in her dreams had she expected that Aditya would attempt suicide. Fearing for his life and respecting the friendship they had shared she had met him at BBQ. That day he had cried for her and that tore her heart apart. She was juggling two guys. Her mind was confused. That day he proposed to her

with red roses, and she realised that she meant a lot to Aditya. Never had Ajinkya made her feel so special.

Actually, she was completely unaware of what true love was. Till date, it had all been infatuation. How could she decide on one guy? How could she stick to one guy? Both were unique in their own ways. But she couldn't hurt either of the two. Her true love was Ajinkya but Aditya made her feel special.

She was in a dilemma. That day when Aditya called her out for a cup of coffee, she had already made plans with Ajinkya. How could she tell Aditya that she was going out with Ajinkya? Instead, she lied that she had plans with her friend Anuja. But she had never expected in her wildest dreams that she would be caught red-handed! She deserved to be caught because she knew she was in the wrong.

When Aditya shouted at her, she felt it was time to call off their relationship and stick to one guy. She knew her decision would hurt one out of the two guys. She chose Ajinkya over Aditya, after all he had always been her true love and first love. Her relationship with Aditya had always been complicated.

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6 MONTHS LATER

EPILOGUE . . . THE PRESENT

IN NIKHIL'S WORDS

Six months had passed and everything had changed. It wasn't easy for Aadi to get over Rutuja but with time, he did succeed. He started looking at life with a positive attitude. Don't know what happened with Rutuja and her Ajinkya. I hope she sticks to him! What's more important for us is that Aadi is now leading a happy life. He did mention her name once or twice whenever Varun, he, and I met during the last six months, but Varun and I would always change the topic. It did help him to recover!

He once called me up randomly and shouted, "Party time Nikhil! I am completely over her." It was the happiest day for us and we did party. Although not in the same college, both Aadi and Varun got admission into medical college. We partied over their success too.

Some might say, that the Aadi-Rutuja love story has a sad ending, but I totally disagree. What happened was for Aadi's good. Although he had Rutuja in his life for a couple of years, the end was good for his future. He cursed God months back for losing Rutuja and today he is thankful to the same God that she is not in his life anymore. She betrayed him in the early stages of their relationship and later, really crossed her limits. So, everything that happens is for the best. Some breakups do make a good start!

The biggest change for Aadi is having Rutuja out of his life. The immature Aadi has been replaced by a wiser Aadi, though I think there is a hidden child in him. He has become more focused and determined in life than he was before. Suicide is out of his mind and he has realised it as one of the biggest mistakes a person can commit.

However, some things remain the same—he is still short-tempered. Another thing we cannot tolerate about him is that he is still so filmy! He comes up with some punchline or the other, mainly the SRK one, “Hamari filmo ki tarah, hamare zindagi main bhi end main sab thik ho hi jata hai . . . happy ending, aur agar yeh na ho, toh yeh the end nahi mere doston, picture abhi baki hai!”

We immediately try to bury our heads somewhere, join our hands before him and shout in unison, “Bas kar pakkau!”

One of the biggest achievements in Aadi’s life is that he has taken up writing as his profession besides medicine. You just need a broken heart to inspire you!

Varun and I changed too! Varun gave up alcohol and smoking. I gave up my flirty ways and the so-called timepass attitude I had towards girls. I just can’t play with anyone’s feelings anymore.

With a bunch of exuberant friends and the changes in their lives, Aadi and Varun go to their respective colleges while I am still struggling with my twelfth grade.

Somebody help me!

IN ADITYA’S WORDS

There is always a start after an end! Nikhil was absolutely correct! I did change. I forgot the bad Rutuja, but the good one still remains in my memory. I hold no rancour against her. How can I hate her when at some point in life I loved her? I am thankful to God and Rutuja for a past that helped me discover the writer in me. God probably gave me the talent for writing and Rutuja gave me the reason.

I had never planned on publishing a book. It happened after Diwali 2014 when I had written down everything and a few of my friends had read it. They encouraged me to find a publisher and begin my journey. Completely unaware of how the publishing industry works, destiny managed to get two bestselling books out of me. Currently, I am two down and working on more.

It was also in Diwali 2014 that I found a new reason to rejoice. Diwali is not just about fireworks, it's about a new start as well. Leaving behind the past, I tossed the Aadi-Rutuja Diary, which had the one-liners, poems and our photographs into a bonfire. I let the past be past!

People and characters come and go in my life. But was it the end? Or was something more left to come? Maybe it will be U n Me . . . It's not complicated! Certainly, a sequel to this book! Who knows!

MESSAGE TO RUTUJA

'We haven't been in contact, so I don't know where you are and what you are doing in life, but my good wishes always stay with you. I might have been wrong and arrogant, unknowingly. My heartfelt apologies to you! I hold no grudge against you but at the same time, I hope you will not betray anyone in the future. Rather than it being U n Me . . . It's Complicated, our relationship was more like U n Me . . . It's Confusion. Confusion over our feelings! I wish you all success and I hope you achieve your life's goals. Stay happy always.'

'And yeah, I forgot something Ru . . . I should thank you for the two most important things you wanted in me. One, becoming a writer and second the six-pack abs. I have achieved one and I am still struggling with the second :p'

MESSAGE TO MY READERS

Irrespective of whether you are a boy or a girl, never hurt someone's feelings. If you have a boyfriend or a girlfriend and are happy, I wish you all happiness. If you have broken up, what are you waiting for? Grab your mobile right now and dial his/her number and try to save your relationship, but only if the other person is worth it. If you have hurt someone, pick up the phone and apologise to that person. Trust me – it does feel better!

One should always be committed when it comes to loving a person. Even thinking of another person when you are in a relationship with one is wrong. Please don't betray anyone in your life.

Those who are contemplating suicide, slap yourself right now. I tried it and it's the biggest mistake of my life. And I hope you don't hate me for writing the harsh truth here. It's the worst thing you can do. Love your parents, they have the first right over you. Give them a hug tonight and let them know how much you love them. Problems are nothing but a temporary phase of life. You will definitely come out of them. Give the scar some time to heal completely. Life is very sweet and not worth wasting.

Live to love, love to live! Give love and take love, that's all you need in your life. Life is too short to waste on hatred!

'Relationships are like books,

They take a few seconds to burn,

But

It takes years to write one

So, write it carefully

and

Never let it burn!'

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5 YEARS LATER

Done with the book-signing event at the Delhi airport bookstores for *Until Love Sets Us Apart*, Nikhil and I made our way to the boarding gate. Nikhil was irked as the flight had been delayed by an hour and a half, but I was dancing in my own shoes as the book had made it to the bestsellers' section at almost every bookstore across India. How desperately Rutuja wanted me to write a book! Though, *U n Me . . . It's Complicated!* was the first story I wrote, I had tasted success through *Until Love Sets Us Apart* as I hadn't published the former yet. And so, I was here to have a word with my publishing team. I had discussed the story at length and was waiting for their response.

"Good evening sir, welcome onboard," said the air-hostess as an email notification popped up. It was the publisher.

'Hey Aditya, Congratulations! We like the story and we are ready to take this forward. We shall begin with the editing process soon. Also, it is good to see that it's not just a love story coupled with hope, destiny and the journey of a non-reader to an author but also about a non-medico to doctor. The cover can flaunt 'Dr. Aditya. R. Nighhot' with pride. Think about it!'

Overjoyed by the response, I shared it with Nikhil, who was sitting beside me. I had to wait for five long years before the story could see the light of day. Finally, Rutuja and my dream was about to be fulfilled. As an immediate response to the message, I closed my eyes and thanked the Almighty. Next, I sent a thank you note to my publisher.

Soon, the much-delayed plane made its way to the runway and was about to take-off just like my dream. At one end my happiness was boundless, when my phone buzzed. My eyes dilated and I could feel a lump in my throat. Nikhil looked at me with shock and I kept staring at him.

"Sir, please switch off your phone. The flight is about to take off," said the air-hostess.

“Sir, please switch off your phone,” she repeated, bringing me back to reality.

“Huh . . . yes!” I nodded, lost.

I waited for the call to end and then switched off my mobile. The aeroplane took off and I closed my eyes and dozed off in no time, only to wake up when the meal was served.

Done with the meal, I switched on my MacBook Pro and opened a document and typed . . .

*‘Unse milkar hum jaane the pyaar ko,
Bichadne par roye the gale lagakar yaar ko
Dil ke darwaze karke band rote rahe hum rat bhar,
Kalam ki nok par kitabo mein hi sahi,
bana diya iss rishte ko amar
Ishq se pyaas na bujhi toh mandir nikal chala,
Socha shikayat karu teri khuda se,
par khuda bhi tera aashiq nikla
Barso bad ruthe iss dil ko manakar aage badne laga,
Zindagi ke iss tede mod par firse
tujhi ko pakar ye dil uljha!*

Translation:

*After meeting her, I discovered the love trend,
On separation, I cried hugging a friend
Closing the heart doors, I cried for nights together,
With the help of the pen tip,
I made her mine in the book forever
Thirsty without love, I made my way to the temple,
Thinking I could complain about you to the Almighty,
but found his love for you ample
Years later, leaving behind the scars,
I consoled my heart and moved on,
On the windy road of life, this heart found you again
and mad it had gone!*

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THE BOOK SAYS

Gosh! You have just made it to the end of this complicated relationship story. I hope you enjoyed my company till the end.

Have you ever been in a complex relationship? Could you connect to the story? The characters? The scenes? Did you experience love and friendship, have a good laugh, cry and get inspired in this journey? Don't hesitate to share your experience with me. The author would love to hear your response.

Click a picture with me in my beautiful dress and post a review on Amazon or any social media site using the hashtags #adityanighhot #unmeitscomplicated and tag the author. I am sure you will flaunt me and I promise to stay with you and never leave you, unlike what happened in the Aditya-Rutuja love story :P

MERCHANDISE – T-SHIRTS

To avail merchandise do visit our store at

www.adityanighhot.com or [amazon.in](https://www.amazon.in)

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ALSO BY THE AUTHOR

UNTIL LOVE SETS US APART

REVIEWS

‘The story is engaging because of the mushy romance and a heartbreaking incident that happens in the lives of the protagonists. It will instantly connect with the youth and the way they perceive the emotion of love.’

– *Sakal Times*

‘A novel which will make you cry, laugh, and fall in love.’

– **Radio City 91.1**

‘Until Love Sets Us Apart becomes my new travelling partner.’

– **Amandeep Sidhu**

(Actor, Yeh Pyaar Nahi To Kya Hai,

Sony Television)

‘You know the story is not real but the author holds the ability to make you cry with a fake story.’

– **Chill’s DNA video review**

‘Until Love Sets Us Apart is an addiction you would not like to break from.’

– **Kshitij T.N Chavan,**

Founder & CEO, Pen Paper Tales

‘Until Love Sets Us Apart offers you a lot of mystery, romance & tragedy.’

– **Salisonline.in**

‘Aditya Nighhot makes it a page-turner, credits to his writing style, plot, character framing, and sequencing incidents with coherence.’

– **Aruddha (Blogger)**

REVIEWS ON AMAZON

‘The author has made a mark on the readers’ hearts through this book, no wonder he is an award-winning author. I recommend people to read this one.’

‘The author has explained each and every incident so clearly that you can imagine yourself in the character’s place. I had goosebumps, I cried, I laughed, I smiled while reading.’

‘A complete package of romance, friendship, and culture. Must read!’

‘Astonishing experience to read a book by an author who is pulling on age twenty, sketching a true love story with delicate psychological touch.’

‘What a great book! Just like one of those entertaining Bollywood films.’

‘There were so many instances in the story where, as a reader, I was taken down the memory lane and they brought a smile to my face as I could relate the scenes with my college days.’

‘Throughout the book, the author has gripped the readers’ attention in a very precise manner, ending with a strong message.’

‘A gripping storyline brilliantly written with poetic interlude & perfectly synchronized words.’

‘A really thought-provoking piece that the author has penned down in a hope to spread the good message for the betterment of all.’



With Love
Aditya Nishhat

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Aditya Nighhot lives in Pune and is a doctor by profession. He completed his MBBS from a renowned college in Pune. He started writing at the age of twenty and since then, writing has become a passion. His first book, *Until Love Sets Us Apart* released in September 2018 and became an instant national bestseller, winning him an award as well. He is currently working on his next book.

Aditya is also an avid reader and a photographer and has a keen interest in music. He is active on social media and loves interacting with his readers and fans.

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